ALMOST

A NOTE ON WHAT IS TRUE

This is a true story in a parallel world.

Not every name is the name it once was, and not every event happened in precisely this order. But the silences, the tenderness, the fears, and the choices that changed everything began somewhere real.

I carried them into another world, where memory could become fiction without losing the truth of what it felt like to live through it. Here, the details have changed; the heart of the story has not. These people may choose differently from the people who inspired them, and their lives may find a different ending, but the feelings that brought them here were lived before they were written.

Perhaps, in a world running quietly beside ours, this is exactly how it happened. Perhaps it is only how it might have.

“Almost is the cruelest distance: close enough to believe in what might be, yet too far to make it real.”

CHAPTER ONE

The Sentence We Kept

“Sometimes a life changes because someone refuses to let a sentence end where it was meant to.”

The sentence was not worth saving.

Kareem Nassar had read it three times before drawing a line through the final clause. It was sentimental, imprecise, and entirely unnecessary to the paragraph around it. The manuscript had been delivered late, the author had ignored most of the notes from the first edit, and Kareem had spent the morning trying to convince a page of prose to behave like language.

He was reaching for his red pencil when a hand appeared beside his monitor.

“Why did you remove that?”

He looked up.

The woman standing beside his desk held a printed copy of the manuscript. Her dark brown hair was tied back, though several strands had escaped near her temples. There was a pen behind her ear and the expression of someone who had already decided that the answer would disappoint her.

“Because it doesn't add anything,” he said.

“It changes the meaning.”

“It repeats the meaning.”

“Those aren't the same thing.”

Kareem looked back at the page. “It's an unnecessary explanation of something the paragraph has already established.”

“Or,” she said, pulling over the spare chair, “it's the first moment when the character admits what she's afraid of.”

He considered the sentence again. He disliked being asked to reconsider a decision he had already made, particularly when the decision had been correct. He disliked even more that she might have a point.

“She's afraid of being alone,” he said. “We know that.”

“We know she says she doesn't want to be alone. We don't know what that means to her until the next sentence.”

He turned the page toward himself. “The next sentence explains it.”

“The next sentence explains it to the reader. This one admits it to herself.”

He looked at her.

She looked back, entirely unmoved by his attention.

“What is your name?” he asked.

“Layla Fares. I manage the editorial projects you keep dismantling.”

“I'm not dismantling them. I'm editing them.”

“Of course. And I'm not arguing. I'm providing an alternative interpretation.”

He almost smiled. “That's a very editorial way of arguing.”

“It's a very editorial way of being right.”

He looked at the sentence again, then restored the clause in the document. He did not like admitting that it worked, so he chose the more dignified route of pretending the decision had been his all along.

“Fine. It stays.”

Layla leaned forward to inspect the screen. “Thank you.”

“You're welcome.”

“You're welcome for what?”

“For allowing you to win.”

She laughed, a sudden warm sound that seemed to surprise them both. Then she stood, gathered the manuscript, and returned to the other end of the office.

Kareem watched her go for half a second longer than necessary. He returned to his edits, though he found himself reading the same sentence again. He did not like the author any more than he had before. He disliked the clause. But the paragraph had become harder to dismiss now that someone had pointed out what it was trying to do.

By two o'clock, the argument over the sentence had reached the author, who responded to the restored clause by sending a new email in which he accused the editorial team of “overthinking the emotional architecture.” Hany read the message aloud from the production desk, giving the phrase the grave emphasis of a newsreader announcing a national emergency.

“Emotional architecture,” he repeated. “Does this man think he is building a bridge?”

Layla stood beside the printer with a stack of pages tucked against her hip. “He thinks he is writing a novel.”

“Same thing, apparently.” Hany turned to Kareem. “Tell me honestly. Is there a professional qualification for this? Can I get certified in emotional architecture? I could put it on my CV.”

“You'd need to demonstrate an ability to support a roof,” Kareem said. “Your current work suggests otherwise.”

Hany pressed a hand to his chest. “Betrayal from the only man I trusted.”

Layla laughed. Kareem found himself listening for the sound after she had stopped.

The email itself was not funny. The author had rejected several necessary revisions, and the publishing house had already promised a delivery date to the printer. Layla read the message, checked the marked pages, and began drafting a reply that was firm without being needlessly humiliating. Kareem watched her work for a moment. She did not simply make a difficult sentence less difficult; she found a way of telling the person who had written it what was wrong without making the person feel that the work itself was worthless.

“You can be more direct,” he said when she turned the draft toward him.

“I can be direct without making him defensive.”

“He's already defensive.”

“Then I don't need to give him another reason.”

Kareem read the reply. It explained why the paragraph needed revision, offered two possible alternatives, and made it clear that the deadline could not move again. It was more considerate than his version would have been. It was also more likely to get the work done.

“You're good at this,” he said.

Layla looked up, surprised by the lack of teasing. “Thank you.”

“I mean it.”

“I know.” She returned to the screen. “You don't have to sound so alarmed about it.”

He smiled. “I'm adjusting to new information.”

At three, her phone began vibrating against the desk. She glanced at the screen and silenced it. A minute later, it rang again. She answered with an apologetic look toward Kareem.

“Youssef, I'm working.”

His voice came through loudly enough for Kareem to hear only its shape, not its words. Layla rubbed the bridge of her nose.

“No, I can't come to the school right now. What do you mean you forgot? You knew about the form on Monday.”

She listened. Her expression softened, then tightened again.

“I'm not angry. I'm trying to understand why you waited until the last day to tell me.”

Another pause.

“All right. Send me a picture of it. I'll tell you what to do, but you'll have to speak to the administrator yourself.”

She ended the call and looked at the phone as though it had personally inconvenienced her.

“Everything all right?” Kareem asked.

“Probably. Youssef forgot to submit a form and has decided this is a problem that requires the presence of an older sister.”

“Does it?”

“No. It requires him to speak to someone and explain that he forgot.” She glanced at her screen again. “But he's worried he'll get into trouble.”

“Will he?”

“Probably.”

Kareem waited for her to explain further, but she had already begun typing a reply to her brother. He wondered what it was like to be the person a family called before they tried anything themselves. He imagined the role as an honor, then remembered the tone in Layla's voice when she had said she did not always know how to stop being the person everyone called first.

“Does he always call you when something goes wrong?” he asked.

“Not always.” She finished the message. “Sometimes he calls Mariam first, and she calls me.”

He laughed. She did, too, but hers ended in a sigh.

“You sound like you don't mind,” he said.

“I don't mind helping. I mind being expected to know what to do before I know what the problem is.”

He looked at her. The sentence seemed to contain something larger than a forgotten form, but she was already returning to her work. He wanted to ask what happened if she was the one who did not know what to do. He wanted to ask whether anyone in her family noticed when she was tired. He did not ask. The questions felt too personal for the few weeks they had known each other, and he was afraid of making her regret having answered the first one.

Instead, he said, “At least nobody can accuse you of being redundant.”

She gave him a small smile. “A terrible quality in an editor.”

The afternoon returned to work. Yet Kareem found himself noticing the way Layla placed her phone face down when she needed to concentrate, the way she paused before replying to an author who annoyed her, and the way she never let irritation do the work that careful thought could do better. He had assumed at first that her confidence came naturally. He was beginning to suspect it was a form of discipline.

He wondered what his own silences looked like from the outside. He had always thought of them as neutral, as spaces in which he could think without imposing his confusion on anyone else. Watching Layla handle a problem she had not created, he began to see that silence could also leave another person alone with the burden of making the next move.

The thought stayed with him until the office began to empty.

He had not decided whether this was a new kind of happiness or simply a new kind of fear. He only knew that it had made the world feel more vivid. When Layla laughed, he noticed the sound in a way he had not noticed the laughter of other people. When she asked a question, he wanted to answer it well. When she was quiet, he wanted to understand whether she was thinking or hurting.

He knew this could become dangerous. The people who mattered most could also disappoint him most profoundly. He had spent years keeping the important parts of himself out of reach, and now he was beginning to hand them over without knowing what he expected in return.

At four, the author called.

Kareem saw his name on the screen and let it ring twice before answering. He had already explained the edit in writing. He knew the call would not be about the sentence itself so much as the author's feeling that someone had questioned his authority over the book.

“Mr. Nassar,” the author began, without greeting him. “I want to understand why you are changing the tone of my work.”

“I'm not trying to change the tone. I'm trying to make sure the sentence carries the tone you've established.”

“But I wrote it that way for a reason.”

Kareem looked at the marked page. He could see the reason. He could also see that the reason had not survived the final clause. “I understand. The difficulty is that the sentence explains an emotion the scene has already shown. It tells the reader what to feel after you've already given them enough to feel it.”

There was a pause. “Are you saying I'm not a good writer?”

“No,” Kareem said, surprised by the heat in his own voice. “I'm saying this sentence is not as strong as the rest of the page.”

He heard himself making a distinction he had wanted to make for years: the difference between criticizing a thing someone had done and criticizing who they were. It was a distinction he could see easily on the page. In his own life, he often failed to make it. If someone disagreed with him, he heard the possibility of rejection. If someone asked what he wanted, he imagined that the answer might inconvenience them. If someone was disappointed, he assumed he had failed in some larger, more permanent way.

The author sighed. “I suppose you do this all day.”

“Edit sentences?”

“Tell people they're wrong.”

Kareem looked through the glass partition toward Layla's desk. She was reading a manuscript with a pencil in her hand, pausing now and then to write something in the margin.

“I try to explain what isn't working,” he said. “That's not always the same as telling someone they're wrong.”

The author was quiet for a moment, then asked him to send the suggested revision again. The call ended without an apology, but it ended. Kareem returned to the document and wrote a note that gave the author two alternatives. It was the most he could do.

Later, he noticed that Layla had left a small square of paper beside his keyboard. It contained the sentence he'd restored that morning and a note beneath it: *Sometimes explaining the feeling is the only way a character knows how to admit it.*

He looked across the office. Layla was speaking with Hany and did not appear to be watching him.

Kareem folded the paper and slipped it into his wallet. He told himself he was keeping it as a useful editorial observation. He did not examine why he wanted to keep a sentence about admitting a feeling.

At five thirty, the office began to empty. Hany, who worked in production and treated every minor inconvenience as an occasion for a public announcement, declared that the coffee machine had finally stopped making coffee and started making what he called “hot disappointment.” Someone laughed from the corridor. Layla emerged from her office carrying a canvas bag and a stack of folders.

Kareem shut down his computer.

He had not intended to leave at the same time as she did. He had, in fact, intended to work for another half hour. But he had finished the pages he needed to finish, and the thought of sitting alone in the office because it might look as though he had waited for her seemed ridiculous enough that he decided to go.

At the entrance, he found her adjusting the strap of her bag.

“Which way are you going?” she asked.

“South. Toward Sayyida Zeinab.”

“I'm walking that way for a while.”

“Are you?”

“Yes. Unless you've decided the pavement needs editing.”

He laughed. “I can walk and tolerate imperfection.”

“That's encouraging.”

They stepped into the evening.

Cairo moved around them in layers: the honking traffic, the calls of shopkeepers, the smell of frying onions from a small restaurant, the sharp afternoon light caught between old buildings. Layla walked quickly, as though there were still things waiting for her even after the workday had ended. Kareem kept pace beside her.

They spoke first about the manuscript. Then about the office, the kind of books they liked, and the strange things authors believed about punctuation. Layla told him she had once received a manuscript in which the protagonist's name changed spelling three times. Kareem said that was not a mistake but a character-development strategy. She laughed and accused him of defending the indefensible.

At a crossing, the traffic stalled, and they waited beside a kiosk. Layla bought a bottle of water and asked if he wanted one. He said no. She bought him one anyway.

“Why did you do that?” he asked.

“You look like someone who forgets to drink water.”

“You've known me for three hours.”

“I'm a good observer.”

“Or a reckless one.”

“Both can be true.”

They crossed when the road cleared. Near the corner where their routes would eventually divide, Layla slowed.

“Do you walk this way every day?” she asked.

“Usually.”

“Me too, for part of it.”

He had known this. He had seen her leave the office before, but he had never considered that their routes might overlap. He had never had a reason to consider it.

“We could walk together tomorrow,” she said, casually enough to make the invitation seem like nothing. “If you want.”

He felt an unreasonable amount of pleasure at being asked.

“Sure,” he said. “If you want.”

“I just said I wanted.”

“Then I suppose we have a plan.”

She smiled and turned down her street. He continued toward his own, the bottle of water cold in his hand.

Before the call from his mother, Kareem stopped at the small shop beneath his building to buy tea. The shopkeeper asked whether he was on his way to the family dinner that Friday. Kareem was surprised the man remembered. He said yes, and the shopkeeper told him to give his regards to his brother.

It was a small exchange, barely worth remembering. Yet on the stairs to his apartment, Kareem thought about how many people knew the practical outline of his life while knowing almost nothing about its interior. The shopkeeper knew where he lived and which tea he bought. His mother knew the details of his schedule. His brother knew he was often absent. None of them knew that he had begun looking forward to a walk home with a woman who argued about sentences.

At home, his mother called before he had taken off his shoes.

“Where are you?” Hala asked.

“Home.”

“You didn't answer your phone.”

“I was walking.”

“Your father asked whether you're coming Friday.”

Kareem leaned against the kitchen counter. “Tell him I'll try.”

“Try isn't an answer.”

“It is the answer I have.”

She sighed, the sound weighted with every sacrifice she believed she had made for her children. She reminded him that his father needed a prescription collected, that his brother had mentioned a family dinner, and that Kareem had not visited in weeks. He agreed to get the prescription. He promised to call his brother. He said he would try to come on Friday.

After the call, he stood in the quiet apartment and looked at the water bottle Layla had bought him. He had not thrown it away. It sat on the counter beside his keys, an ordinary object made noticeable by the fact that someone else had thought of him.

His phone lit up with a message from an unknown number.

This is Layla. In case you need to ask the manuscript any further questions.

He smiled before he could stop himself.

It says it regrets the disagreement.

Her reply arrived quickly.

Tell it I accept its apology. You can work on yours tomorrow.

He laughed alone in the kitchen.

He typed three different answers and deleted them all before sending a simple goodnight. It seemed absurd to be cautious about a message. It seemed even more absurd that he cared what she might think of it.

He put the phone down and went to make tea.

While the kettle warmed, he found himself looking at the photograph tucked into the back of a poetry collection on the shelf. He had placed it there years ago, then forgotten it was there until he needed a book and the picture fell onto his desk. It showed his grandmother sitting in the family's old living room, surrounded by relatives who seemed to have occupied the whole frame. Kareem stood near the edge, small enough that one of his cousins had partly hidden him. His older brother and sister were together in the middle, laughing at something beyond the camera. They looked like children who belonged to the same world.

Kareem had been too young to remember much of the gathering. He remembered his grandmother's hands, the smell of cardamom, and the way the older relatives spoke as though they had been continuing a conversation that began before he was born. His brother and sister remembered more: the jokes, the arguments, the names of people who had since died or moved away. At

family dinners, they sometimes laughed about incidents Kareem had never heard of, and he had learned to smile along rather than ask how a person could belong to a family and still miss half its history.

The house had grown quieter over the years. His grandmother had died. Relatives moved away, married, grew ill, or became too old to travel. His brother left home first, then his sister. The family gatherings continued, but the room seemed to lose people even when everyone was present. Kareem, the youngest, remembered the tail end of a world that his siblings had known more fully.

Everyone says the youngest is lucky. Nobody tells you that you might spend your entire childhood watching people leave a life you haven't even had the chance to live yet.

He remembered one particular family gathering, though he could not have said why the memory had come back so clearly. It was a summer evening at his grandmother's house, the rooms hot despite the fans, the dining table covered with dishes that seemed to arrive faster than anyone could finish them. Kareem had been eight or nine. His brother and sister were old enough to tell stories about an uncle who had once fallen into a swimming pool fully dressed, and every time they reached the punch line they began laughing before the rest of the family did.

Kareem asked what had happened.

His sister waved a hand. “You were too little. You don't remember.”

“I can still understand the story.”

“It won't make sense if you weren't there.”

He had not been offended at first. He had gone back to his plate, waiting for someone to explain. Later, when the story came around again, he asked his brother to tell it from the beginning. His brother tried, but skipped details the others seemed to know already. Everyone laughed at the same point, and Kareem laughed a second too late because he was still trying to work out what was funny.

His grandmother noticed. She placed a piece of chicken on his plate and asked if he wanted to hear about the time his father had broken a window playing football. She told the story properly, with the details and the pauses and the family names. For a little while, Kareem was included.

Then someone called his grandmother from the kitchen, and the conversation moved elsewhere. His brother and sister began telling another story. Kareem sat beside his plate, listening to a history that seemed to belong to everyone except him.

He did not remember the evening because anyone had been unkind. Nobody had excluded him deliberately. They had simply shared things he had not been there to see, and their pleasure in remembering made his absence seem like a small personal failure. He learned to stop asking questions when a story began before he could follow it. It was easier to laugh when everyone laughed, to let the details pass, to appear less interested than he was.

Years later, when the family gatherings became smaller and less frequent, he understood that his siblings had not been keeping him out. They had been remembering a world he had only partly known. The realization did not make him less lonely. It only made the loneliness harder to explain, because there was no person to blame for it.

His father had been at that dinner. Kareem could remember Mahmoud at the end of the table, talking to an uncle about a problem with the car. When Kareem had tried to join the conversation, his father had asked him to bring a screwdriver from the hallway. The request was ordinary. Kareem had fetched the tool and returned to find the men talking about something else. Nobody had meant to dismiss him. Still, the small moment had lodged somewhere in him: he had been useful, and then he had disappeared again.

He had never told his father that he wanted to be asked to sit down and talk. He did not even know if that was what he wanted until years later, when he saw other men talking with their sons about things that did not need to be fixed. He had assumed that closeness was a quality some families possessed naturally, like a good singing voice or the ability to make pastry. You were either born into it or you weren't.

Now, in his apartment, with Layla's message still on his phone, he wondered whether people could learn closeness later in life. He did not yet know how to ask for it. But the question had become difficult to ignore.

He had never told anyone how much it bothered him. It seemed ungrateful to feel lonely in a family that had provided him with a home, food, education, and the kind of practical care that could be relied upon. He had grown into the sort of man who did not ask for what he could manage without. Over time, that habit had begun to look like independence.

He made his tea and returned the photograph to the book. His phone lit up with a message from his brother confirming Friday's dinner. Kareem typed that he would be there, then paused before sending it. The promise was small, but he wanted to keep it. He was beginning to suspect that loneliness did not always

come from being left behind. Sometimes it came from standing still while everyone else assumed you would eventually catch up.

The sentence had survived the edit. Layla had survived his jokes. Tomorrow, apparently, they would walk home together again. For reasons he could not yet name, he found himself looking forward to it.

CHAPTER TWO

The Houses We Come From

“We learn the shape of love in the rooms where we first discover what is missing.”

Kareem arrived early the next day and told himself it was because the traffic had been unusually light.

The office was nearly empty. Hany had not yet arrived to complain about the coffee machine, and the lights above the editorial desks were still switching on in sections. Kareem put his bag down, opened the manuscript, and read the same paragraph three times without understanding a word of it.

Layla arrived at nine twelve.

He did not look up immediately. He waited until he heard her greeting the receptionist, then turned as though he had only just noticed she was there.

“Morning,” she said.

“Morning.”

“You're early.”

“Am I?”

“Yes.”

“Interesting.”

“Were you waiting for someone?”

“No.”

She looked at the clock, then at his open computer. “Well, whoever you were waiting for, I hope they appreciate your sacrifice.”

He smiled. “I'm sure they will.”

The day passed in fragments: meetings, edits, phone calls, a printer that had somehow shifted the title page by half an inch, and an author who regarded any change to his prose as an attack on his character. Layla moved through the office with a calm competence Kareem found both admirable and difficult to imitate. She could tell someone their work was not ready without making them feel stupid. She could tell Hany that a deadline was impossible without causing him to announce a crisis to the entire floor.

At six, they left together.

This time, the walk was not an accident. Layla had waited beside the door while Kareem gathered his things. She did not mention it, and neither did he.

They stopped at a café when a brief rain began, though neither had brought an umbrella. The place was narrow, with metal chairs and a window that had fogged at the edges. They ordered tea and coffee and watched people hurry along the pavement.

“Do you always work this late?” Layla asked.

“Not always. Sometimes I work later.”

“Is that because you love your job?”

“It's because the manuscripts are very good at multiplying when no one is watching.”

She laughed. “That's not an answer.”

He looked through the window. “I like the work. I don't know if I'd say I love it.”

“What would you love to do?”

The question was simple, and he was surprised by how little he had thought about it. He liked books, language, the small satisfaction of correcting a sentence that had been trying to say something it could not quite manage. But he had never thought of his job as a path toward something else. It was what he did. It paid his bills. It filled his days.

“I don't know,” he said.

Layla studied him. “That's an honest answer, at least.”

“I'm full of them.”

“Let's not get carried away.”

The rain intensified. Layla watched it for a while, then began telling him about her father. She did not announce the story with any ceremony. She spoke of him as one might speak about a room one had not entered in a long time: carefully at first, then with a growing familiarity that made the distance between past and present feel less absolute.

“He died when I was sixteen,” she said. “It started with a cut to his hand. He was fixing the broken latch on the back gate with an old utility blade, and it slipped. The blade was filthy from sitting in his toolbox, but the cut didn't look serious. He washed it, wrapped it, and carried on as though it were nothing. A few days later, his palm swelled. Then the fever came. The infection spread into his bloodstream. The doctors called it sepsis. They admitted him and gave him antibiotics, but his condition kept getting worse. He stayed in the hospital for weeks. He never came home.”

Kareem looked at her, but did not interrupt.

“I spent so much time at the hospital that I knew the smell of the corridors, which vending machine swallowed coins, which nurse came on at night. I was sixteen and had no idea how to make a dying person less alone, so I stayed. I told

him about school and Mariam and Youssef as though an ordinary conversation could keep the world from narrowing."

She stirred her coffee, though there was nothing left to dissolve.

"I was beside him when he died. I was holding his hand. I remember the warmth leaving it, and how I kept waiting for someone to come in and tell me there'd been a mistake. I had imagined that if the end came, I'd know what to do. All I could do was say *Baba, Baba*, as if the word could bring him back."

She looked down at the table.

"I know I wasn't responsible. But knowing that doesn't stop the helplessness. Sometimes I still feel that I failed him simply because I couldn't do anything to keep him here."

After her father died, she became the person everyone could depend on. Nobody noticed that she had never learned where to put the part of herself that still needed a father.

She stirred her coffee, though there was nothing left to dissolve.

"My father used to invent stories about strangers. We'd be in traffic, and he'd point at someone waiting at a bus stop and tell me where they were going, why they looked sad, what they might have eaten for breakfast. I thought he knew everything about everyone."

She smiled at the memory.

"He didn't. He just liked imagining that people had lives beyond the few seconds we could see them."

Kareem understood that impulse. He often invented private explanations for the people around him. It was easier to imagine what someone might be feeling than to ask them and risk hearing something he could not respond to properly.

"Did you keep doing it after he died?" he asked.

"Sometimes. But it was different. I would look at people and think about all the conversations they still had time to have. All the things they assumed they would say tomorrow."

She looked at him.

"Do you ever think about the things you keep postponing?"

"More than I should."

"Why do you postpone them?"

He considered giving her a joke. Instead, he said, “Sometimes I think I'll know what to say later.”

“And do you?”

“No.”

She smiled faintly. “That's the trouble with later.”

They sat until the rain weakened. When they finally left, Layla told him about her younger sister Mariam and her brother Youssef. Since her father's death, she had become the person who remembered school forms, medical appointments, birthdays, and the small emergencies that arrived without warning. Her mother, Nadia, worked hard to keep the household going, but the family had learned to depend on Layla in ways that had become difficult to distinguish from affection.

“Do you mind?” Kareem asked.

“Helping them? No. I love them. I just don't always know how to stop being the person everyone calls first.”

She had spent her life being strong for people who loved her. She wanted, just once, to be weak beside someone who did.

“Have you tried not answering?”

She looked at him. “Have you?”

He laughed, conceding the point.

They left the café when the rain had thinned to a mist. Rather than turn toward their usual routes immediately, Layla suggested a secondhand bookshop she had discovered a few streets away. The owner kept the books in leaning towers, and a small bell above the door gave a tired ring when they entered.

“I used to come to places like this with my father,” she said, running her fingers along a shelf of old paperbacks. “He liked books that looked as though people had already lived with them.”

Kareem smiled. “Books are meant to be read.”

“Not according to the people who keep first editions in plastic covers.”

“Those people are protecting the books.”

“From what? Reading?”

He laughed.

Layla moved toward a shelf near the back. She pulled out a worn collection of stories and went still. The cover had faded, and the corners were softened by years of handling. She turned it over, then opened the first page.

“My father used to read these to us,” she said. “He did voices. Terrible voices. He insisted the wolf sounded like a man from his office, and the rest of us had to pretend we understood the joke.”

She laughed at the memory, then looked down at the book again. Kareem saw the change in her face and did not offer to take the book from her. He simply stood beside her while she turned a few pages.

Between two stories, a small notebook had been tucked into the book as a marker. Layla opened it by instinct, then stopped when she saw the handwriting. It was her father's. The notebook was full of reminders: telephone numbers, errands, dates, small tasks written in the uneven rush of a person who expected to return to the list later. Near the middle, two lines had been underlined.

Ask Layla how the exam went.

Ask Youssef about the football match.

Layla did not cry at first. She stared at the words as though they belonged to a stranger, then closed the notebook and opened it again, hoping the second reading might change what it said. Her shoulders began to shake. She held the book close to her chest, embarrassed by the suddenness of her grief.

Kareem stood beside her. He did not say that her father would have wanted her to be happy, or that the notebook proved how much he loved her, or any of the phrases people offered when they were desperate to make sorrow useful. He simply stayed while she cried.

“He thought he had time,” she said eventually. “It's only a list of things he thought he would get around to doing.”

Kareem looked at the notebook. “Maybe that's what most of a life is. Things we expect to have time for.”

She wiped her face. “That's a terrible thought.”

“Yes.” He hesitated. “But it doesn't mean the things he did get to do mattered less.”

Layla looked at him. He was not trying to repair the grief or explain it away. He was letting it be what it was. She had spent years being praised for her strength, and the praise had often sounded like an instruction to stop needing comfort. Kareem made no such demand.

She looked at the notebook again.

“Can I tell you something that sounds awful?” she asked.

“Of course.”

“Sometimes I have to prove to myself that he existed.” She gave a small, embarrassed laugh. “I know how that sounds. I have photographs. I remember his voice. I remember things he said. But sometimes the years before he got sick feel like a story someone told me so often that I adopted it. I'll look at a photograph and know the man in it is my father, but I can't always make the person in the picture feel real.”

Kareem said nothing, so she continued.

“Some days I can hear him so clearly that I almost turn around. Other days I can't remember the exact sound of his laugh, and I panic. I start wondering whether I've invented parts of him, whether I'm remembering the stories instead of the person. It feels as though I'm losing him again, only this time I'm losing him inside my own head.”

“You don't sound awful,” Kareem said. “You sound frightened of losing what you still have.”

She looked at him, her eyes bright.

“I think I am. And it affects more than memory. I hate leaving conversations unfinished. If someone doesn't answer a call, part of me knows there may be a simple explanation, but another part remembers the hospital and how quickly ordinary days can become the last days. I know that's not fair to everyone. I know they can't live as though every conversation is their last one with me.”

She stopped and looked at the notebook.

“Sometimes I wish I could remember what it felt like to have him in the room, not just the details of what he did. I want the past to feel like somewhere I actually lived, not somewhere I keep trying to prove I lived.”

Kareem offered his hand. After a moment, she placed hers in it and held on.

“I can't tell you how to remember him,” he said. “But I don't think you have to make every memory certain for it to have been real.”

She looked down at their hands.

“I wish knowing that made it easier.”

“I know.” He did not tell her it would. “I'm glad you told me.”

She bought the book and the notebook. Outside, the pavement was still wet. They walked slowly, neither of them trying to return the conversation to something lighter too quickly.

Youssef called while they were walking away from the bookshop. Layla saw his name on the screen and stopped so abruptly that Kareem nearly walked into her.

“Sorry,” she said, answering. “What's happened?”

She listened for several seconds, her face changing from concern to disbelief.

“No, a fever doesn't mean you should take every medicine in the cupboard. What did the doctor say? Youssef, listen to me. Read me the name on the box.”

Kareem moved a little away, giving her privacy, but the street was narrow and the conversation carried. She spoke to her brother with the patience of someone who had repeated the same instruction many times and knew repetition was sometimes the only thing that worked. She asked about his temperature, told him to call their mother into the room, and made him promise not to take anything else until Nadia had checked it. When he began to complain, she interrupted him.

“I know you're uncomfortable. I'm not saying you're not. I'm saying you need to do what Mama tells you. I'll call when I get home.”

She ended the call and stood still for a moment, looking at the dark screen.

“Is he all right?” Kareem asked.

“He's fine. He has a fever and has apparently decided that a medical emergency is an opportunity to negotiate the terms of his university application.”

Kareem smiled, but Layla was still frowning.

“Do you want to go home?” he asked.

“No. Mama's with him. There's nothing I can do from here that she can't do there.” She began walking again. “I just hate that he waits until he's frightened before he tells anyone what's happening.”

Kareem thought of the message he had deleted the night before, the question he had not asked his father, and the conversations he had postponed because he wanted to be certain he could finish them properly.

“Maybe people think they can manage something until it becomes too difficult,” he said.

“Maybe.” Layla slipped her phone into her bag. “But sometimes by the time you ask for help, you're already exhausted.”

He wanted to ask who helped her when she was exhausted. The question stood at the edge of his attention, clear enough to recognize and still too intimate to touch. He told himself that he had known her only a short time. He told himself

that people were entitled to reveal themselves at their own pace. Both things were true. So was the fact that he was relieved not to have to ask.

They reached a small square where a few boys were playing football between the benches. One of them kicked the ball too hard, and it struck the leg of an older man reading a newspaper. The man scolded them. The boys apologized, retrieved the ball, and resumed the game at a slightly safer distance. Layla watched them with a smile.

“Youssef used to do that,” she said. “He would break something, look terrified, and then come to me with a story about how it happened.”

“Did you believe him?”

“Never. But I used to let him finish explaining.”

“That's kind.”

“It was practical. If I interrupted, he'd start again from the beginning.”

Kareem laughed.

She looked at him. “What about you? Were you the kind of child who got into trouble?”

“No. I was the kind of child who avoided making trouble.”

“Those aren't the same thing.”

“No,” he said, surprised by how easily the answer came. “They aren't.”

She waited, but he did not continue. He could have told her about being the youngest, about the older siblings who seemed to share memories that began before he was old enough to understand them, about the way the family gatherings slowly thinned as relatives moved away or died. He could have explained that avoiding trouble had become one way of staying out of a family that was already full of other people's needs. But he did not know how to tell the story without sounding ungrateful.

Layla seemed to recognize the edge of a thought he was not ready to share. She did not push.

“Sometimes I think the person everyone calls first is the person everyone forgets to ask about,” she said instead. “They think you're fine because you're the one who answers.”

He looked at her.

“Do you ever tell them you're not fine?”

She laughed without much humor. “Not very often.”

“Why not?”

“Because then someone has to do something about it, and I don't always know what I want them to do.” She glanced at him. “That's not a very good answer.”

“It's honest.”

“So is not knowing.”

He smiled. “I'm becoming a bad influence.”

“Don't worry. I was already like this.”

They walked the rest of the way toward the corner where their routes divided. Layla talked about a book she wanted to buy for Mariam, and Kareem listened, but the conversation had changed something between them. He had seen her carrying responsibility in real time, not as a summary of the past but as an ordinary interruption that would have been invisible to anyone who did not know what to notice.

When they parted, she reminded him to call his brother about Friday's dinner.

“You remembered that?” he asked.

“You told me yesterday.”

“I tell people many things.”

“Most people expect you to remember the things they tell you, Kareem.”

He grinned. “I see why you manage editorial projects.”

She smiled and turned down her street.

At home, Layla found Nadia sitting beside Youssef with a thermometer and a glass of water. His fever was already lower. He looked miserable in the way people sometimes do when they have been ill for several hours and are beginning to recover but have not yet received the sympathy they believe they deserve.

“You called me as though the hospital was on fire,” Layla said.

“I felt terrible.”

“I know.” She touched his forehead, then sat beside him. “Next time, tell Mama first. Don't make yourself more frightened by waiting until you can't manage it.”

Youssef looked at her. “You sound like Mama.”

“That's because we're both trying to keep you alive.”

He smiled, and she kissed his head. She stayed until he fell asleep, then helped Nadia put away the medicine. Her mother thanked her for coming home,

although Layla had not been there in person until after the crisis had already passed. The thanks made her feel useful and tired in equal measure.

The next morning, Layla was tying her shoes when Nadia appeared in the doorway with her phone in one hand.

“You came home late yesterday,” her mother said. “And you didn't tell me you had stopped at the bookshop.”

“I was with a colleague.”

“That isn't the point. You should have called.”

“Mama, I'm twenty-six. I can't report every place I go.”

Nadia's expression tightened. “I need to know you're safe.”

“I was safe.” Layla kept her voice low, though irritation had already risen in her chest. “You call to check where I am, what time I'm coming home, whether I've eaten, whether I've taken a taxi. Sometimes I feel as though you think I'm still sixteen.”

“Sometimes you behave as though being grown means nobody is allowed to worry about you.”

Layla looked away. It was the kind of sentence that made disagreement feel like ingratitude. She hated being monitored, hated having to defend ordinary decisions, hated that a late walk could become an argument about whether she respected her mother. Yet she knew where Nadia's strictness had come from. During her father's illness, Nadia had learned to ask every question, keep every appointment, and make decisions while frightened. After he died, she had become both parents in a house full of children who still needed someone to tell them what came next. Worry had hardened into rules because rules were something she could enforce when the rest of life had become uncontrollable.

Layla understood that. Understanding did not make the rules feel less suffocating.

“I know you worry,” she said. “I know you've had to do everything on your own. But I need you to trust me enough to let me make ordinary decisions.”

Nadia's face softened, though she did not surrender the point entirely. “Just tell me when you'll be late.”

“I can do that.”

It was not a resolution. Layla left for work still annoyed, and Nadia remained unconvinced. But for the first time, Layla had said the resentment out loud instead of converting it into silent obedience.

Later, alone in her room, she thought about Kareem's question: *Do you ever tell them you're not fine?* She had answered honestly. She rarely did. But the truth was more complicated than that. She had learned early that being the person who could manage things made the people around her less frightened. She was proud of that ability. She did not know how to put it down without worrying that someone would be left holding something too heavy.

Her phone lit up. Kareem had sent a message.

Did Youssef survive the medical drama?

She smiled.

Barely. The family is considering a commemorative plaque.

His reply came quickly.

I'm sure he'll insist on having his name spelled correctly.

She laughed quietly and set the phone beside her pillow. She had been needed by her family all evening. It felt unexpectedly good to receive a message from someone who was not asking her to do anything at all.

They parted at the corner. That night, Kareem called his brother as he had promised. The conversation was awkward at first, full of questions about work and whether Kareem was eating properly. His brother mentioned a family dinner the following Friday and said that his daughter had been asking about him. Kareem promised to come.

The promise frightened him more than it should have. He had postponed visits so often that his family had learned to expect uncertainty. He wanted to be better about that. He did not yet know how.

Two evenings later, he went to his parents' house to collect the prescription his mother had mentioned. His father, Mahmoud, sat in the living room with his phone, listening to the television without appearing interested in it. When Kareem asked how he was feeling, his father said he was fine. When Kareem asked whether he needed anything else from the pharmacy, Mahmoud said no.

There was nothing wrong with the exchange. That was the problem. It contained all the words they knew how to say and none of the words Kareem had been waiting for.

He remembered a university friend's father who used to call simply to ask how his exams had gone, who could talk for ten minutes about nothing and somehow make the conversation feel important. Kareem had envied that friendship without admitting it. He had assumed, for a long time, that some

families were naturally close and others were not, and that he was meant to accept the arrangement he had been given.

For a moment, as the rain tapped against the café window, Layla was sixteen again.

The week after her father's funeral, the house had been full of people who brought food and spoke in low voices. There had been so many cups of tea that she stopped counting them, so many relatives who said they were there for her mother that she began to understand how much of grief was organized by the people who were still alive. Someone had to answer the door. Someone had to remember which neighbor had brought the tray. Someone had to tell Youssef that he could not go outside because the adults had asked him to stay home.

Nadia sat in the bedroom with the curtains closed, exhausted beyond the point of conversation. Mariam, still young enough to cry whenever she saw someone else cry, followed Layla from room to room. Youssef asked the same question several times: when was Baba coming home?

Layla answered gently the first time. The second time she told him that their father was not coming home. The third time, she had to turn away because she could not bear to say the words again.

That afternoon, a school administrator called to ask about a form that had not been submitted. Layla took the call in the kitchen, standing beside the sink while someone in the living room explained to a relative that Nadia was not ready to see visitors. She listened to the administrator's instructions, wrote down the deadline, and promised to bring the form herself.

When she hung up, she found that she had written the same date three times on the paper.

Mariam came into the kitchen. “Are you crying?”

“No.”

“You are.”

Layla wiped her face with the back of her hand. “I'm just tired.”

Mariam stood beside her, unsure what to do. Then she reached for the form and asked which office it had to go to. Layla explained the route. Her sister listened carefully, then said she could come along.

“You don't have to,” Layla said.

“I know.” Mariam folded the paper. “I want to.”

The offer was small, and it did not remove any of the things Layla had to do. But it stayed with her. It was one of the few moments in the first week after her father's death when someone had offered help without making her prove that she needed it.

After that, she became more practiced. She learned which bills were due when, how to speak to school administrators, how to tell her mother that a problem had been handled. People praised her for being strong, and the praise gave her a role she could perform when she did not know how to be a grieving child. Eventually, she began to believe that if she could keep the household functioning, the grief might become manageable.

A week after the funeral, the school called to say Youssef had forgotten a form that needed a parent or guardian's signature. Nadia was asleep when the phone rang. She had spent the morning sorting documents, then lay down in the bedroom without taking off her clothes. Mariam was sitting on the floor with a stack of schoolbooks, opening one and closing it again without reading anything.

Layla answered the call in the kitchen.

"Can you bring it tomorrow?" the secretary asked. "Otherwise, he won't be able to go on the trip."

Layla looked at the form on the table. Their father's name was still printed in the space marked *Father/Guardian*. No one had crossed it out yet. She had seen the same space on other documents that week, the same small blank waiting to be filled by someone who was supposed to know how these things worked.

"I'll bring it," she said.

After she hung up, she found Nadia in the bedroom and explained what had happened. Her mother opened her eyes, then closed them again.

"I can't think about another form today," Nadia whispered.

Layla sat on the edge of the bed. She wanted to tell her mother that she couldn't think about it either. She wanted to lie down beside her and be sixteen, to let someone else answer the phone, speak to the school, decide which documents mattered. Instead, she said, "I'll take care of it."

The next morning, she walked to the school before classes began. The secretary gave her the form and explained where it needed to be signed. Layla read each line carefully, then told her that her father had died. The woman looked startled, apologized, and offered a softer voice that made Layla want to leave the room.

"Who should sign it now?" Layla asked.

The secretary told her that Nadia could sign as guardian. Layla took the form home, woke her mother gently, and placed it on the bedside table with a pen. Nadia signed her name without looking at the other lines.

On the way back to school, Layla felt proud of herself for having solved the problem. The trip would go ahead. Youssef would not be embarrassed in front of his classmates. Her mother could rest. There was a sequence of actions, and she had completed it.

Only when she returned to the empty hallway did she realize that no one had asked how she was doing. They had not meant to overlook her. Their grief filled the house, and the practical tasks had to be completed whether anyone was ready or not. Layla understood that. She even felt grateful for having been useful.

But later, when a teacher told her she was "such a strong young woman," Layla smiled because she did not know what else to do. The praise gave her a place to stand. If she was strong, she could be the one who remembered the forms, took Youssef to the doctor, and helped Nadia answer the telephone. She could be the person who did not make another problem for anyone.

She did not notice when the temporary role began to feel permanent. It became a part of the family arrangement, and as the months passed, people stopped asking whether she could help. They simply told her what needed to be done.

Years later, when Layla tried to explain why she sometimes found it difficult to ask for help, she would remember the form and the hallway and the pen in her mother's hand. She would remember that she had been praised for doing something she had not known how to refuse. She would not call the memory the beginning of everything. It was only one small moment in a long sequence of them. But it was one of the moments in which she learned that being needed could earn a person a place, even when nobody knew how much it cost.

It never became manageable in quite the way she had hoped. It became familiar. She learned how to carry it while doing other things.

Back in the café, Kareem was watching the rain. Layla had not intended to tell him all of this. She had said the facts more easily than the feeling of being beside her father at the end and still being unable to help him. She was used to people treating her grief as a story with a lesson. Kareem had not done that. He had allowed her to speak without turning the loss into an instruction about how she should live.

She looked at him and felt, unexpectedly, the urge to be less composed.

“I think I got used to being useful,” she said. “It was easier than being sad. People knew what to do with me if I was useful.”

Kareem turned toward her. “What did you need them to do?”

She was surprised by the question. She had expected him to say that it must have been difficult, or that she had been too young to carry so much. Instead, he had asked what she needed, as though the answer still mattered.

“I don't know,” she admitted. “I think I wanted someone to notice when I was tired before I had to ask.”

He looked down at his tea. He understood the sentence more than he wanted her to know.

“That's a difficult thing to ask for,” he said.

“Yes.” She smiled faintly. “It's a difficult thing to admit you want.”

The rain began to ease. Neither moved to leave. For a while, they sat with the feeling she had given a name to, and Kareem did not try to make it smaller.

The memory of Adam's father was not a single grand gesture. It was a collection of small ones, which was perhaps why Kareem had never found a way to dismiss it. During their second year at university, Kareem had spent an afternoon at Adam's house working on a project. Adam's father came home from work with a paper bag of sandwiches and asked whether they had eaten. When they said no, he set the bag on the desk and asked about their exams.

He did not ask because he needed information. He sat on the edge of the chair and listened while Adam complained about a lecturer who seemed to enjoy making students feel stupid. He laughed at the right places, asked a follow-up question, and told Adam that he had been difficult at university, too. Then he turned to Kareem and asked which course he was worried about.

Kareem answered, surprised to be included. The man asked what the exam involved and whether Kareem had found a way to prepare. When Kareem explained his notes, Adam's father nodded and offered to quiz him after dinner. He was not particularly knowledgeable about the subject, but he listened as though the details were worth understanding.

Later, when Kareem was leaving, the man walked him to the door and asked whether he had a ride home. Kareem said he could take a taxi. Adam's father gave him money for the journey, despite Kareem's protest that he had enough. He said it was too late to make a young man spend his savings on a taxi, and then asked him to call when he got home so he would know he had arrived safely.

Kareem had called. The man had answered on the first ring, asked whether he had reached home, and told him to get some sleep before the exam.

He remembered the walk home afterward, too. Adam's father had insisted on calling a taxi, then stood beneath the building's entrance light until the car pulled away. It was a small thing, performed without ceremony, and Kareem had spent the journey wondering why it felt so different from the arrangements his own family made.

When he reached home, the apartment was dark except for the television in the living room. His mother had gone to bed. His father was still awake, sitting in his armchair with his glasses low on his nose. He looked up when Kareem entered.

"You're late."

"I was studying with Adam."

"You have an exam tomorrow."

"I know."

Mahmoud nodded toward the kitchen. "There's food in the fridge if you're hungry."

It was not an unkind thing to say. Kareem understood that. His father had remembered that he might be hungry and had left food where he could find it. He had not asked about the exam, the project, or whether Kareem had enjoyed the evening. He had offered what he knew how to offer.

Kareem warmed the food and ate standing at the kitchen counter. He thought about calling Adam to thank him for the afternoon, then decided it would be strange to thank someone for something that had not been offered as a favor. He thought about telling his father that Adam's family made him feel welcome, but he could not imagine what the conversation would become.

In the morning, his father asked whether the exam had gone well. Kareem said yes. It had gone well enough. His father nodded and asked whether Kareem could take a package to the post office on his way to university.

Years later, Kareem would remember that morning not as proof that his father did not care, but as the moment he first began to understand the difference between care that was present and care that could be felt. His father had not abandoned him. He had simply never learned to ask the questions Kareem needed answered.

That distinction would take him a long time to understand, and longer still to stop using it as an excuse for his own silences.

It was not that Mahmoud never cared for him. His father had paid his school fees, attended important ceremonies, and made sure he had what he needed. Kareem had never doubted that his family would help him if something went wrong. What he envied was the ease with which Adam's father seemed to enter the ordinary parts of his son's life without waiting for a problem to justify the visit.

Kareem had never told anyone about the envy. It felt disloyal. He could list all the things his father had provided, and every item would be true. Yet none of them answered the question he had been afraid to ask: why had practical care been easier to give than curiosity?

He thought of asking Layla about it. She would probably listen. She might understand. But the story felt too old and too tender to place in the hands of someone he had only recently begun to trust. He did not yet know that trust was often the act of allowing another person to hear something before he had found a way to make it sound simple.

So he kept the memory to himself and walked the rest of the way home. By the time he reached his apartment, he had convinced himself that there was no point in comparing one family with another. People loved differently. Some showed it through money, errands, and the doors they kept open. Perhaps he simply had to learn to appreciate the form his family had chosen.

But appreciation did not entirely erase longing.

On the way home, he messaged Layla.

Do you think people can change the way they love each other?

Her reply came after several minutes.

I think they can learn to love each other differently. But they have to notice what they're doing first.

He read the message twice.

Then he typed: *I'm not very good at noticing things about myself.*

She replied: *You noticed I was right about the sentence.*

He smiled.

An isolated incident.

We can work with that.

He put the phone away, but the phrase stayed with him. We can work with that. It was a small sentence, offered lightly, without knowing how much he needed to hear it.

Across the city, Layla sat at her mother's kitchen table while Youssef complained about a school assignment and Mariam searched for a document she had misplaced. Nadia asked Layla to call the doctor the next morning. Layla agreed, then looked at her phone when it buzzed.

She smiled at Kareem's message and returned to the conversation at the table.

She was used to being needed.

She did not yet know what it might feel like to be wanted for no reason other than that someone wished she were there.

When Layla finally went to her room, she placed the old storybook on the desk and opened the notebook again. The house had quieted. Nadia was in the kitchen, rinsing the last of the cups; Youssef had fallen asleep with the television still on; Mariam had retreated to her room with her laptop. For the first time that evening, no one was asking Layla to do anything.

She sat on the edge of the bed and read the two reminders again.

Ask Layla how the exam went.

Ask Youssef about the football match.

She had told Kareem that her father thought he had time, and she knew the statement was true. But the notebook made the truth feel more specific. Her father had not simply assumed that life would continue. He had assumed that he would be there to ask the questions, to hear the answers, to make the small things part of the family's shared memory.

She heard the bedroom door open and looked up. Nadia stood in the doorway, holding a folded towel.

“Is that his notebook?” her mother asked.

Layla nodded.

“I thought we'd lost it.”

“It was in the bookshop. Inside one of his old story collections.”

Nadia came closer and sat beside her. She took the notebook gently, as though she were unsure whether she had the right to touch it, and turned a few pages. Her fingers paused over a list of groceries, then a telephone number, then a note about a dentist appointment that had taken place years earlier.

“He wrote everything down,” Nadia said. “He was always afraid he'd forget something.”

Layla gave a small, uneven laugh. “I think I inherited that.”

Her mother smiled, but the expression faded as she reached the underlined reminders.

“Do you remember that exam?” she asked.

“English. I was convinced I'd failed.”

“He knew you were worried. He kept saying you would be fine, and you kept telling him he didn't understand the questions.” Nadia traced the edge of the page. “He wanted to ask you about it when you got home.”

Layla looked down. “I remember.”

For a while, they sat with the notebook between them. Nadia began telling her about a small argument she'd had with Layla's father over a birthday present, then stopped halfway through the story to laugh at herself. Layla had heard the story before, but never from this part of it. Her mother described the way her father had insisted on buying something impractical and then spent days defending the purchase. The memory made them both laugh, and the laughter carried a little grief inside it without being swallowed by it.

“I think I forget sometimes that you miss him in ways I can't know,” Layla said.

Nadia looked at her. “And I think I forget that you were a child who lost her father. I saw how much you were doing, and I relied on it. I didn't always notice what it cost you.”

Layla's throat tightened. She had wanted to hear something like this for years, but now that the words were here, she did not know how to receive them without trying to reassure her mother.

“You had a lot to manage, too,” she said.

“I did.” Nadia held her gaze. “That doesn't mean you didn't.”

Layla looked away, blinking hard. It was not a complete resolution. It could not undo the years in which she had learned to make herself useful before admitting she was tired. But for a moment, her mother had seen something other than her competence.

Nadia returned the notebook to her. “Take it with you when you move. If you want to.”

Layla nodded. “I think I will.”

After her mother left, she placed the notebook beside her bed rather than putting it away in the drawer. She did not read the rest of the pages. She did not need to turn every reminder into an argument about time. She only wanted the notebook to be somewhere she could reach for it when she felt like remembering.

Before she slept, she sent Kareem a message.

I told Mama about the notebook.

He answered: *How did that go?*

Better than I expected. We talked about Baba without making it a lesson about how I should feel.

Kareem replied after a pause: *I'm glad you got to do that.*

She read the words twice. He had not asked her to explain further, and he had not tried to turn the evening into a problem he could fix. She put the phone down and rested her hand on the notebook's cover.

For once, she did not feel she had to be the only person who remembered.

The following evening, Kareem and Layla walked home along a quieter street, where the shops were beginning to close and the traffic had thinned enough for them to hear each other without raising their voices. Kareem had been quiet since they left the office. Layla noticed, but this time she did not immediately ask him to explain.

At the corner, he stopped.

“Can I tell you something about my father?”

“Of course.”

He looked down at the pavement. “Sometimes I don't like him. I think sometimes I hate him, and then I feel terrible for saying it because he's my father.”

Layla said nothing. She did not rush to defend Mahmoud or correct the word.

“I wish I'd had a different father,” Kareem continued. “Someone who wanted to know me. Someone who asked about things that weren't errands or work or what needed fixing. Then I feel ashamed, because my father did provide for us. He paid for school. He made sure we had a home. He wasn't cruel in any obvious way. If I told someone I wished I'd had a different father, they'd probably think I was ungrateful.”

“Do you feel ungrateful?”

“Sometimes. And then I feel angry that I feel guilty, because providing for a child and knowing him aren't the same thing.” He swallowed. “I hate how little he seems to want to know about my life. I hate that I still want him to ask. I can be furious with him and then hear his voice on the phone and become a child again, hoping this time he'll ask something that matters.”

There is a difference between growing up without a father and growing up with a father you keep waiting for.

Layla looked at him with quiet attention.

“I think the worst part is that I don't know what to call what I feel. I love him because he's my father. I resent him because of what he's never been able to give me. I wish he were someone else, and then I feel disloyal for wishing my father had been a different man.”

“Those feelings don't cancel each other out,” she said. “You can be grateful for what he gave you and still grieve what you needed from him and didn't get. You don't have to pretend one truth makes the other untrue.”

Kareem let out a breath he seemed to have been holding for years.

“I've never said that to anyone.”

“I'm glad you told me.”

He looked at her. “I don't want you to think I hate him all the time. Sometimes we have an ordinary evening, and everything is fine. Then I leave and realize we haven't talked about anything that would tell either of us who the other person is.”

“I don't think feelings have to be consistent to be real,” Layla said. “Especially when the relationship has been complicated for a long time.”

He nodded. They began walking again, slowly.

“I don't know what I'm supposed to do with it,” he said.

“Maybe you don't have to decide tonight. Maybe for now you can stop pretending it isn't there.”

He held her hand as they crossed the next street. It was the only answer he could manage, but for once he did not feel that he needed to explain it away.

CHAPTER THREE

The Name We Hadn't Given It

“Love often begins as an ordinary habit that one day becomes impossible to lose.”

The first time Kareem asked Layla to dinner, they were walking home from work together. He had spent most of the afternoon considering how to ask, then spent the walk trying to convince himself that there was no need to make the invitation sound like something important.

At the corner where their usual routes began to separate, he slowed.

“Would you like to get dinner with me?”

Layla turned toward him. “We have lunch together almost every day.”

“I know.” He cleared his throat. “I mean dinner. At a restaurant. Just the two of us. Not because we're finishing a deadline or arguing about a manuscript.”

The last words came out too quickly. He wished he could pull them back and try again with less evidence of how much he cared about the answer.

Layla felt a small flutter beneath her ribs. She had noticed his attention for weeks, the way he remembered things she said and found reasons to extend their walks, but she had been careful not to decide what those things meant before he told her himself.

“I'd like that,” she said.

They chose a restaurant a few streets away. It was not especially fashionable or expensive, only quiet enough for conversation, with broad windows looking onto the pavement. Kareem ordered too cautiously, then let Layla persuade him to try something he would not normally have chosen. They talked about books, colleagues, the strange confidence of authors who refused to change a sentence, and the places in Cairo they wanted to visit but somehow never did. When the food arrived, the conversation had become easy enough that Kareem stopped measuring every answer before he gave it.

Then the rain began.

At first, it was only a scattering of drops against the window. Within minutes, the pavement shone beneath the streetlights, and people ran beneath shop awnings or stood waiting for the weather to change. Layla turned to watch the rain, smiling at the suddenness of it.

“We may be here for a while,” she said.

“I'm sorry. I didn't plan for this.”

“Why are you apologizing? I like the rain.”

“I thought we'd finish dinner and walk.”

“We still can. Eventually.” She glanced at him. “Unless you're trying to escape.”

“I'm not.” He said it so quickly that she laughed.

For a moment he watched the rain instead of her. He had been afraid that naming what he wanted would change the evening, that it would make the quiet between them awkward or require a promise he was not ready to make. But the evening had already changed. He had asked her here because he wanted to be with her, and pretending otherwise would only make him smaller.

He looked back at her.

“It's a date,” he said.

Layla's smile softened. The words sent a rush of butterflies through her, bright and almost embarrassingly young. She had wanted him to say something like that—not because a label could guarantee what would happen next, but because she wanted to know she had not imagined the tenderness growing between them.

“It's a date,” she replied.

He smiled then, his nervousness giving way to relief. Neither reached across the table. They remained where they were, with the rain between the restaurant and the rest of the city, and talked until the storm weakened enough for them to leave. They walked beneath the shop awnings and parted at her street with a quiet goodnight. Kareem went home knowing that something had begun, and Layla went inside with the feeling that she had been chosen, however cautiously, by someone she had been hoping would choose her.

The next few weeks were a period of small, accumulating discoveries. They began eating lunch together. Layla sent him photographs of ridiculous signs and badly written menus. Kareem sent her sentences he found in books and asked whether she thought they were brilliant or merely trying too hard. She came to recognize the expression he wore when he was working through a difficult edit. He learned that she disliked being offered advice before she had finished explaining the problem.

A few weeks later, they went to a small cinema downtown to see an old Egyptian film. Layla arrived five minutes late and accused him of looking as though he had been abandoned at the station. He told her he was considering reporting her to the authorities. She bought him a packet of popcorn by way of apology, then ate most of it herself.

The film's central character spent nearly two hours avoiding a decision that everyone around him seemed capable of making. When the lights came on, Layla shook her head.

“I have no sympathy for men like that.”

Kareem glanced at her. “What did he do?”

“He spends the entire film waiting for the perfect moment to say something, and then the moment passes. When the consequences arrive, he acts as though the world has surprised him.”

“Perhaps he wanted to be certain.”

“About what? That his words would have no consequences? That's not certainty. That's cowardice with excellent manners.”

Kareem laughed, though the comment stayed with him.

They walked beside the Nile afterward. The water was dark, the city lights moving across it in broken reflections. They spoke about the film, then about the choices people made when they were afraid of losing something. Layla did not accuse Kareem of being like the character. She did not need to. He carried the comparison home himself.

One evening, after a long walk that neither of them had wanted to end, they stopped beside a closed shop while a light rain passed over the street. Layla was telling him about a friend from university she had recently reconnected with, and how surprised she was by the ease with which they had begun speaking again after years apart.

“Do you think people stay in each other's lives?” Kareem asked.

She glanced at him. “Some do.”

“I've always assumed most people are temporary.”

The sentence sounded colder than he intended. He looked down at the pavement and tried to explain.

“Someone comes into your life. You get close. You start telling them things you don't tell other people. Then something changes. They move, get married, find a new job, become busy, or simply become someone you used to know. No one has to do anything terrible. Life just keeps moving, and one day you realize you haven't spoken in months.”

Layla listened without interrupting.

“I think I've used that as an excuse not to depend on people,” he continued. “If I tell myself everyone leaves eventually, then I don't have to ask anyone to stay. I can pretend the ending was inevitable instead of admitting I was afraid of wanting more.”

She looked at him. “Do you think everyone leaves?”

“No. Not exactly. I know people stay. My brother has stayed, even when I've made it difficult. My family is still there, in its own way.” He paused. “But even the people who stay change. The relationship changes. The house changes. The person you remember isn't always the person standing in front of you.”

The rain had softened. A taxi passed, sending a thin wave of water toward the kerb.

Kareem turned toward her.

“I don't know what will happen with us. I don't want to make a promise I can't keep. But I wish you'd be in my life forever.”

Layla's expression softened, though she did not smile immediately.

“Forever is a very long time.”

“I know.” He gave a small, embarrassed laugh. “I don't mean I expect life to stop changing. I just mean I don't want you to become someone I used to know. I don't want to get to a point where I see something funny and have to remind myself I can't send it to you.”

She looked at him for a long moment.

“Then don't treat me as temporary just because you're afraid I might leave,” she said. “I'm here now. You can let that be real without asking me to guarantee the rest of our lives.”

He held out his hand, and she took it.

“I think that's what I'm trying to learn,” he said.

They walked on, their hands joined between them. Neither called it a declaration. Neither asked the other to promise forever. But the words stayed with them, a quiet wish placed inside a relationship that was still becoming itself.

A few weeks after their first dinner, Layla saw Kareem genuinely nervous in a different way. By then, he had begun to look for her in the office without admitting that he was doing it.

They had stayed late to finish a set of proofs. By the time they reached the street, most of the shops were closing, and the air smelled of dust cooling after a hot day. Layla suggested they get something to eat from a stall she liked. Kareem said he wasn't hungry, then followed her anyway.

She ordered two sandwiches and handed one to him.

“I said I wasn't hungry.”

“You also said you didn't want coffee that morning and drank half of mine.”

“Your coffee was better.”

“It was the same coffee.”

“Then perhaps it was the company.”

The words escaped him before he could reconsider them. Layla looked at him, her expression briefly surprised. He felt the familiar urge to make a joke that would disguise the sincerity of the remark.

Instead, he took a bite of the sandwich.

She smiled and did not make him explain.

They found a low wall beside the street and sat there to eat. A shopkeeper was pulling down a shutter nearby. Two boys argued over a football. A woman crossed the pavement carrying a bag of oranges, one of which rolled free and stopped near Kareem's shoe. He retrieved it and handed it back to her.

“Thank you,” she said, continuing on her way.

Layla watched him. “You always notice when someone drops something.”

“It's difficult not to notice an orange rolling past your foot.”

“Not everyone picks it up.”

He shrugged. “It's a small thing.”

“Small things are usually what people notice about you,” she said.

He turned toward her. “What do you notice?”

She took a moment before answering. He was not asking with the easy confidence of someone who expected to hear praise. His expression had become careful, almost wary, as though he had asked a question he might regret.

“I notice that you pay attention,” she said. “I notice that you remember what people say, even when you pretend you don't. I notice that you can be very funny when you stop trying to sound serious. And I notice that you often say you don't mind something when I think you do.”

He stared at her. “That's quite a list.”

“I'm an editor. I collect evidence.”

He laughed, but he could feel the truth of the last item settling somewhere uncomfortable. He had spent years learning to make his preferences invisible, and Layla had noticed that the invisibility itself had become a habit.

“What do you notice about yourself?” he asked.

She looked down at the sandwich in her hands.

“That I don't always know when to stop helping. That I can become impatient when people don't tell me what they need, even though I sometimes don't tell people what I need either.”

He smiled faintly. “Perhaps we're both difficult.”

“Perhaps.”

They sat for a while longer. When they finally stood, Kareem offered to walk her to the corner. She took his arm, and the gesture felt natural enough that neither commented on it. Yet he was aware of the warmth of her hand through his sleeve, and of the fact that he had begun to think of the walk home as something he wanted rather than simply a route he took.

At her street, she turned toward him.

“I had a good evening,” she said.

“So did I.”

She hesitated, then took his hand for a brief moment before stepping back, as though she wanted to give him room to decide what it meant.

Kareem was so surprised that he forgot to speak.

Layla's face changed. “Was that all right?”

“Yes.” He cleared his throat. “Very all right.”

She smiled. “Goodnight, then.”

“Goodnight.”

He watched her disappear inside the building, his hand lifted halfway as though he had intended to wave and forgotten how. Then he walked home, replaying the moment with such care that it seemed possible to damage it by thinking too much.

He did not tell anyone. He simply went to bed with the unfamiliar certainty that he wanted to see her again, and again after that, and that the wanting had become part of his ordinary day.

A few days after the reading, Layla asked Kareem to help her choose a gift for Mariam. Her sister's birthday was coming up, and Layla had promised to find something that was neither practical nor expensive, two requirements that seemed to contradict each other whenever she tried to shop for anyone she loved.

They walked through a small market after work, passing stalls of jewelry, scarves, old books, and household objects whose usefulness was difficult to establish. Layla picked up a set of painted cups, put them down, and then

returned to them as though the cups had said something persuasive while she was looking away.

“What does Mariam like?” Kareem asked.

“Things she doesn't need.”

“That's a broad category.”

“She likes notebooks, but she has too many. She likes jewelry, but she never wears the same thing twice. She likes books, but if I buy her one, she'll ask whether I've read it and then borrow it from me anyway.”

“Perhaps you should buy her a book you've already read.”

“Then she'll ask why I didn't give it to her sooner.”

Kareem laughed. “Your family sounds like a difficult audience.”

“Only when they're awake.”

They stopped at a stall selling old postcards and prints of Cairo. Layla picked up a postcard showing a street she recognized from childhood. The colors had faded, and the buildings looked older than she remembered them, though the street itself had probably changed less than the image suggested.

“I used to collect these,” she said.

“Postcards?”

“Places I wanted to visit. When I was younger, I'd buy one whenever we went somewhere. Then I stopped.”

“Why?”

She turned the postcard over, running her finger across a blank space where someone might once have written an address. “I think I began collecting things for other people. Things my mother needed, things Youssef had lost, things Mariam wanted. I stopped buying things just because I liked them.”

Kareem looked at the display. “Do you like this one?”

“Yes.”

“Then buy it.”

She gave him a sideways look. “That simple?”

“I can't think of a more complicated approach to purchasing a postcard.”

She laughed, but she did not put it down. She bought the postcard and slipped it into her bag. Then she found a small hand-painted cup for Mariam, which she purchased after another ten minutes of consideration.

On the walk back, Kareem asked what Layla would do if she had an entire day with no work and nobody asking her for anything.

She thought about the question for so long that he wondered whether she had heard him.

“I'd probably sleep,” she said at last.

“An ambitious plan.”

“Then I'd go somewhere without telling anyone where I was going. I'd walk around, eat something because it looked good, buy a book I didn't need, and come home when I felt like it.”

“You could do that tomorrow.”

She smiled. “I could.”

“Would you?”

The question made her uncomfortable in a way she did not entirely understand. She had spent years assuming that a free day was an opportunity to catch up on the things she had not managed to do. The idea that she could spend it without being productive seemed almost irresponsible.

“Maybe,” she said.

Kareem nodded. He did not tell her she should go, or promise to accompany her, or turn the possibility into a plan. He let it remain hers.

They reached her street just as the shops were beginning to close. Layla took the postcard from her bag and held it up to the light.

“I think I'll keep this one for myself,” she said.

“An excellent decision.”

“I might even put it on my wall.”

“You're becoming reckless.”

She laughed and slipped the postcard away.

At the entrance, she turned toward him. “Thank you for helping me choose the gift.”

“You did most of the choosing.”

“Yes, but you helped me remember that I can buy something because I like it, even if nobody else needs it.”

He felt the weight of the sentence. He had not meant to teach her anything. He had simply asked a question, and she had answered it in a way that revealed

more than he expected. He wondered whether she ever felt that people loved her most when she was useful. He wondered whether she knew how much he liked her when she was simply standing beside him, looking at a postcard.

“I like you when you're not solving anything,” he said.

The words came out before he could prepare for them.

Layla looked at him, her expression suddenly still.

“Good,” she said after a moment. “Because I'm not always good at solving things.”

“I've noticed.”

She laughed and took his hand for a moment before stepping away. The small gesture was becoming familiar, but it still surprised him every time. He watched her disappear inside and continued walking home, thinking about the postcard she had bought for no reason other than that she wanted it.

Two evenings later, Kareem and Layla were walking home when his phone rang for the third time in twenty minutes. Hala wanted to know whether he had eaten, whether he had remembered to call his brother, and when he planned to visit his parents. Kareem answered each question with increasingly clipped replies. When the call ended, he slipped the phone into his pocket and kept walking.

“You sound angry,” Layla said.

“I'm not angry.”

She looked at him.

“I'm irritated,” he admitted. “I hate how involved she is in every detail of my life. She wants to know where I am, what I'm doing, whether I've eaten, whether I've called someone, whether I'm coming home. Sometimes I want her to leave me alone for one entire day.”

“Then why do you sound guilty about it?”

“Because she does care. She has done a lot for us. She spent years managing the house and worrying about all of us. I know that's how she shows love, and I know she'd say she's only trying to help. If I complain, I feel like I'm rejecting everything she's done.”

Layla listened.

“Sometimes I want her to stop calling,” he continued. “And then I imagine she doesn't call at all, and I feel awful. What if I only hate the attention because it's

the wrong kind? What if I complain about her being over-involved and then discover that I'd miss it if she stopped?”

“Both can be true,” Layla said. “You can be grateful for what she's given you and still want boundaries. You can love her and be frustrated with her. A boundary isn't a verdict on whether she's a good mother.”

He considered that.

“I don't know how to tell her that.”

“You don't have to solve it in one conversation. But you can start by being honest about what you can and can't do, rather than agreeing to everything and resenting her afterward.”

He gave a small laugh. “You make it sound very simple.”

“It isn't simple. It's just clearer than pretending you're fine.”

He nodded. The advice was familiar in theory, but hearing it applied to his mother made him uncomfortable. He could see how much he wanted her to understand him without having to risk upsetting her. He could also see how often he had used her over-involvement as a reason not to explain himself.

“Thank you,” he said.

“For what?”

“For not telling me I'm a terrible son.”

Layla smiled. “I think you can be a frustrated son and a good one at the same time.”

When they parted at the corner, Kareem did not feel that the problem had been solved. But he felt less ashamed of naming it.

He hoped she would put it on the wall. He hoped she would remember the day. He hoped she would keep discovering things she wanted for herself, and that he might be there to hear about them.

He did not think to ask what it meant that he had begun imagining himself in the ordinary details of her future. For now, he was content to know that he wanted to see her again tomorrow.

One Friday, a few weeks after their first date, Layla invited Kareem to a small reading at a bookshop near the office. One of the authors she worked with was launching a collection of essays, and she had promised to attend. Kareem nearly declined. The day had been long, and he had planned to go home, finish a set of proofs, and spend the evening in the quiet apartment he had come to regard as a reliable refuge.

Then Layla sent a second message.

You don't have to come if you don't want to. I just thought you'd enjoy it.

He read the message, then typed, *I'll come.*

At the bookshop, they stood near the back of the room while the author spoke about memory and place. Kareem liked the writing more than he had expected. He liked the way Layla listened, the slight tilt of her head when a sentence caught her attention, and the fact that she sometimes wrote a word in the margin of her program when she wanted to remember it later.

After the reading, a woman from the publishing house came over to greet Layla. She asked whether Kareem was her colleague. Layla paused for only a moment before saying, “He's someone I'm seeing.”

The phrase was casual, but Kareem felt it land inside him with a significance he could not hide from himself. She had not called him her boyfriend. She had not made a declaration. She had simply placed him in the sentence where he belonged.

The woman smiled and began talking about another book. Kareem answered when asked, but he was aware of Layla beside him, aware of how easy it had been for her to say the words. He wondered whether he could have done the same if the question had been asked of him. He suspected he would have hesitated, not because he was ashamed of her, but because he still treated the public acknowledgment of a feeling as though it might somehow make the feeling more dangerous.

When they left the shop, Layla noticed his quietness.

“What is it?” she asked.

“Nothing.”

She stopped walking. “Do you want to try that again?”

He laughed, caught. “I was thinking about what you said.”

“About you being someone I'm seeing?”

He nodded.

“Was that all right?” she asked.

“Of course.” He paused. “I was surprised by how much I liked hearing it.”

Layla's expression softened. “I liked saying it.”

They walked a little farther. The air had cooled, and the streetlights were beginning to come on. Kareem wanted to tell her that he had not been

accustomed to being chosen openly, that in his family affection was often assumed rather than spoken, and that he was learning how much it mattered to hear himself described as someone another person wanted in her life.

Instead, he said, “I think I need to update my professional profile.”

She laughed. “To what?”

“Someone being seen.”

She shook her head, smiling. “You are impossible.”

He took her hand. She let him. For the rest of the walk, he did not try to explain the feeling. He simply allowed himself to be happy that she had said the words and that he had liked hearing them. It was a small form of courage, and one he did not yet know how to repeat on command.

A week later, Kareem learned that Layla disliked being comforted too soon.

It happened after an author sent her a reply so dismissive that even Hany, who usually regarded workplace conflict as a form of entertainment, stopped smiling when he read it. The author had rejected her revisions, accused her of misunderstanding the book, and suggested that perhaps someone with more experience should handle the project. Layla read the email, set it down, and went to the kitchen for water.

Kareem found her there a few minutes later, staring at the paper cup in her hands.

“You know he's wrong,” he said. “The changes make the chapter clearer.”

Layla looked at him.

“I didn't say he was right.”

“I know. I just thought—”

“You thought I'd feel better if you explained why he was wrong.”

Kareem stopped.

She sighed. “I'm not upset because I think he's right. I'm upset because I've spent two weeks trying to do this well, and now I have to spend another two weeks persuading him that the work isn't a personal insult.”

He took in the distinction. He had offered a solution to a question she had not asked. The correction was small, but he felt a flush of embarrassment.

“I'm sorry,” he said. “Would you rather complain?”

She looked at him, surprised. Then she laughed.

“Yes. I'd rather complain.”

“Excellent. I'm well qualified to listen to complaints.”

She told him everything: the author's email, the awkward meeting, the revisions she had already made, and the frustration of having to protect the work from someone who had written it. Kareem listened without interrupting. Once, he started to suggest a reply, caught himself, and closed his mouth. Layla noticed and smiled.

“Thank you,” she said when she had finished.

“For not speaking?”

“For noticing that I hadn't asked you to.”

He looked at her. “I'm learning.”

“Good.” She put the cup in the sink. “You can help me write the reply later, if I ask.”

“I'll prepare my best professional outrage.”

She laughed, and the tension left her shoulders.

That evening, they walked home together as usual. Layla talked about the author's response, then about a book she had been trying to finish. Kareem told her about a manuscript whose main character had been given three different ages in the same chapter. They argued about whether that counted as a continuity error or an experimental approach to time.

Near the corner, Layla stopped at a small cart and bought roasted corn. She offered him some. He declined, then accepted when she held it out again.

“You always do that,” she said.

“What?”

“Say no before you've thought about whether you want something.”

He laughed. “It's a useful habit.”

“Is it?”

He thought about it. He said no to invitations when he was not sure he wanted to go, then spent the evening wondering whether he had missed something. He said he did not mind when someone cancelled plans, then felt disappointed. He said he was fine with whatever people chose, then found himself quietly wishing they had chosen differently.

“I suppose not always,” he admitted.

Layla smiled. “You could try saying what you actually want.”

“That's dangerously simple advice.”

“I specialize in it.”

They ate the corn while standing beside the street, watching traffic move through the crossing. It was a small moment, almost too ordinary to remember. Yet Kareem remembered it later, because it was one of the first times Layla had spoken about his habits without treating them as fixed qualities. She seemed to believe he could change them. He found that belief both comforting and unsettling.

The following day, he arrived at work with two coffees. He had remembered that Layla preferred hers with milk and no sugar. When he placed it on her desk, she looked at the cup, then at him.

“You remembered.”

“You make a point of telling me when I forget things.”

“I do not.”

“You have a very distinctive expression.”

She laughed and took the cup. “Thank you.”

He walked back to his desk feeling absurdly pleased. It was not a grand gesture. It required no confession, no careful arrangement, no risk of being refused. He could remember a detail and act on it. He could offer something small without needing the other person to explain why it mattered.

He wondered whether that was why practical acts of care came more easily to him than words. An action could be completed. A feeling, once spoken, belonged to another person as well as to him. It could be misunderstood, rejected, or met with a silence he did not know how to bear.

The thought stayed with him. He was learning to say what he felt, but he did not yet understand that love would one day require more than naming the feeling; he would need to tell Layla what he was willing to do, and then follow through. For now, she smiled at the coffee, and he let the small happiness be what it was.

One evening, they sat in a café and talked about family. Layla asked whether he had told his parents about her.

“Not exactly.”

“What does that mean?”

“I haven't told them much about my personal life.”

She considered this.

“I don't want to feel like something you have to hide.”

He looked at her, startled by the directness of it.

“You're not something I want to hide.”

“Then don't.”

He felt the familiar impulse to postpone the conversation until he could explain himself properly. He did not want her to think that his silence meant shame. He wanted her to understand that he had never learned how to introduce private feelings into a family that preferred practical information.

But those were explanations, not answers.

“I haven't told them because I'm not very good at talking to them about things that matter to me,” he said. “It's not because I'm ashamed of you. I think I've spent so long keeping my life separate from theirs that I don't know how to bring it together.”

Layla listened carefully.

“Thank you for telling me.”

He reached for her hand. “I will tell them.”

“When you're ready. But don't leave me guessing.”

He promised he wouldn't.

A few days later, he told Hany at work that he was seeing someone. Hany reacted with theatrical astonishment, demanded to know whether Kareem had always been capable of romance, and then insisted that he had detected a change in Kareem's mood weeks earlier.

“You're smiling more,” Hany said.

“I have always smiled.”

“Not where people can see it.”

Kareem laughed and returned to his desk, embarrassed by how pleased he was that the change had become visible.

The first time Layla told him plainly that her feelings had become something more happened outside the bookshop where she had been looking for a collection her father used to read to her. She had found an old copy, and they had spent the walk home discussing the stories. At the corner, she stopped, looked at him, and said, “I think I want us to be more than two people who happen to walk home together.”

He stared at her.

“That's a very direct announcement.”

“Would you prefer a formal invitation?”

“No.”

“Good.”

He looked at her, trying to find a reply that would not hide behind a joke. “I want that, too.”

She offered him her hand. He took it, and they stood there for a moment, both smiling at the simplicity of having finally said what had been gathering between them.

A few days after they first admitted what they wanted from each other, Layla invited Kareem to spend a Sunday afternoon with her. They had no plan beyond lunch and a walk, which was precisely what made the invitation feel different from their first date. This time, neither needed to pretend the meeting had been arranged for a practical reason. He arrived at her building carrying a paper bag of pastries, and she greeted him with the amused suspicion of someone who knew he would deny having bought them especially for her.

“You've brought food,” she said.

“I was told there would be lunch.”

“There will be lunch.”

“I thought it prudent to prepare for contingencies.”

She took the bag. “You're getting very attached to this idea of being useful.”

“It's my most attractive quality.”

“I'm beginning to think that's not true.”

They ate with her family, though it was not yet a formal introduction. Kareem had come to drop off a book she had lent him, and Nadia had insisted that he stay for lunch. Mariam asked him about his work. Youssef asked whether he supported a football team. Layla watched him try to answer without turning the conversation into an editorial debate and found herself feeling unexpectedly protective of him.

Her family was warm, but it was also busy. Nadia asked Layla to call the pharmacy. Mariam needed help checking a document. Youssef wanted to know whether Kareem could explain a problem with his phone. Layla responded to each request almost automatically, and Kareem noticed the way her attention kept moving away from the conversation and toward the next thing someone needed.

After lunch, they went for a walk. Layla seemed quieter than she had been in the café.

“Is everything all right?” Kareem asked.

“Yes. Why?”

“You were here, but you weren't quite here.”

She smiled without much humor. “That's what happens when you're the person everyone asks for things.”

“You could say no.”

“I do.”

He gave her a look.

“Sometimes,” she amended.

He laughed, then grew serious. “Does it bother you?”

She thought about it. “I like helping. I like knowing what to do. I just sometimes wish someone would ask what I want before giving me something to fix.”

Kareem understood the feeling more than he expected to. At home, he had become the person who could be trusted to collect prescriptions, answer practical questions, and appear when something needed doing. He had also learned that if he did not ask for attention, nobody could refuse it.

“Maybe we should make a rule,” he said.

“What rule?”

“When we're together, we get to finish one conversation before either of us solves anyone else's problem.”

She looked at him, surprised.

“That sounds selfish.”

“Then we can call it an editorial rule. It will sound professional.”

She laughed, and the tightness in her shoulders eased.

They walked toward the river, talking about books and the ways people learned to be themselves in the presence of others. At one point, Layla stopped and looked at him.

“I think I like you more than I intended to,” she said.

He felt his face warm.

“That's unfortunate.”

“Very.”

“I've developed a similar problem.”

She reached for his hand.

“Good,” she said. “I would hate to be the only one.”

They continued walking, hand in hand, and Kareem realized that he was no longer thinking about how the relationship might be named. He was thinking about the next time he would see her, what she might say, and whether he could learn to be as honest with her as he was beginning to wish he could be. They still had awkward conversations. Kareem still sometimes took too long to answer a question, and Layla still pushed when she was frightened. But they were happy. They learned what the other person liked, what made them laugh, what memories hurt, what small kindnesses could make a difficult day easier.

Kareem began bringing Layla coffee when she had a long morning. Layla began leaving notes on his desk when she knew he would be working late. They walked home together whenever they could, and sometimes took the longer route simply because neither wanted the evening to end.

One evening, they were walking home after a day that had seemed ordinary until they stepped outside and found the sky turning violet above the traffic. They were side by side on the pavement, talking about a sentence Kareem had spent the afternoon trying to fix. Layla disagreed with his solution and explained why. He listened, smiling, then fell quiet.

“What is it?” she asked.

“There's something I want to say, and I'm trying not to make a joke out of it.”

“That sounds serious.”

“It is.” He looked ahead for a moment, gathering the courage to keep going. “I'm in love with you, Layla.”

The traffic moved around them. A horn sounded somewhere behind them, and someone hurried past carrying a paper bag of bread. The city did not pause for the words, but Layla felt as though something inside her had stopped and turned toward him.

Butterflies rose beneath her ribs, sudden and bright. She had been waiting for him to say it—not demanding it, not wanting him to speak before he was ready, but hoping that the feeling she had trusted was one they could finally name together. For a moment, she could not find the answer she had imagined so many times.

“I've been waiting for you to say that,” she admitted.

His face changed, and the relief in it was so unguarded that she wanted to remember it exactly as it was.

“You have?”

“Yes.” She smiled, trying to quiet the fluttering in her chest. “I didn't want to put the words in your mouth. I wanted to hear them from you.”

He nodded. “I should have said it sooner.”

“Maybe. But you said it now.” She drew a breath. “I'm in love with you, too.”

They kept walking beside one another, not reaching for each other, both suddenly aware of how little the street had changed and how much the evening meant. Kareem did not turn the confession into a promise that nothing would ever go wrong. Layla did not ask him to. For that stretch of the walk, it was enough that neither of them had to guess what the other was trying to say.

One night, sitting by the river, Layla told him that she liked how he noticed things others overlooked.

“I think you see a great deal,” she said. “You just don't always let people see you seeing it.”

He looked at the water.

“Perhaps I'm afraid they'll ask what I think.”

“And that would be terrible?”

“Potentially catastrophic.”

She smiled and took his hand.

“I want to know what you think, Kareem.”

He wanted to tell her that he had begun imagining his life with her in it. That he had started buying two cups of tea without thinking about it, saving stories because he wanted her to hear them, and looking forward to ordinary afternoons because they might be shared. He wanted to tell her that he was happy in a way that made him feel both braver and more vulnerable than he had ever been.

Instead, he said, “I like having you around.”

She lifted her head and gave him an amused look.

“An extraordinary declaration.”

“I'm known for my eloquence.”

She laughed, then took his hand.

“I like having you around, too.”

It was not all he meant to say.

For now, it was enough to keep them walking together.

That evening, Layla found Mariam on the sofa, scrolling through a series of messages from a friend who had become convinced that her new boyfriend was deliberately replying late. Mariam was composing a response with the concentration of someone trying to settle a diplomatic dispute.

"Are you writing a treaty?" Layla asked.

"I'm explaining that people have jobs and cannot always answer within three minutes. It's a difficult concept for some people."

Layla laughed and sat beside her.

Mariam glanced up. "You've been smiling since you came in."

"Have I?"

"Yes. It's unsettling. Should I call a doctor?"

Layla threw a cushion at her.

Mariam caught it, grinning. "Is it Kareem?"

Layla tried to look offended. She did not succeed.

"I like him," she admitted.

"I gathered that from the smiling."

"I don't know what it is yet."

Mariam put her phone down. "You don't have to know what it is yet. You can just like him."

Layla looked toward the kitchen, where Nadia was rinsing a cup. "I think I keep waiting for the part where I have to work out how to make it fit with everything else."

"Everything else will still be there tomorrow," Mariam said. "You don't need to organize the whole future tonight."

The sentence was so unlike the way Layla spoke to herself that she felt almost embarrassed to hear it. She was accustomed to considering the consequences of a decision before allowing herself to enjoy it. If she liked Kareem, she wanted to know what it meant for her family, her time, her plans, and the careful balance of obligations she had learned to manage.

"I don't want to become careless," she said.

Mariam tilted her head. "About what?"

"About people. About the things I owe them."

"You don't owe everyone the whole of yourself, Layla. You owe them honesty and kindness. The rest depends on what you choose."

Layla was quiet. She knew her sister was right, but knowing something and allowing it to shape a life were different acts. She had learned to think of wanting something for herself as a problem that required a plan. Kareem made her want to try something simpler: to be happy without first proving that happiness would not inconvenience anyone.

Mariam picked up her phone again. "I'm glad you're happy," she said, returning to the messages. "You deserve to be happy about something that doesn't involve solving a problem."

Layla looked at her sister and felt an affection that was older and less frightened than the affection she felt for Kareem. She did not need to choose one to make room for the other. She could have a life in which the people she loved remained important without becoming the only measure of what she was allowed to want.

She went to her room later and found a message from Kareem asking whether she had reached home safely. She replied that she had. He sent a joke about the bookshop owner, and she laughed at the screen.

Then she put the phone down and allowed herself to be happy without turning the feeling into a decision.

A few days later, they discovered that neither of them knew how to spend an afternoon without giving it a purpose.

Layla had finished work early after an author postponed a meeting, and Kareem had been sent home with a set of proofs he could easily have completed the following morning. They met outside the publishing house with no plan beyond walking until one of them became hungry.

At first, they talked about work. They discussed a paragraph that both considered beyond repair, a reviewer whose criticism was more entertaining than useful, and the extraordinary confidence with which people defended sentences they had not bothered to read twice. Then the conversation wandered into childhood books, badly remembered films, and the meals they would choose if they were forbidden from eating anything sensible for a week.

“Cake,” Layla said.

“That isn't a meal.”

“It can be if you believe in yourself.”

“I'd choose koshari.”

“Of course you would.”

“What does that mean?”

“It means you would turn an opportunity for culinary freedom into a practical decision.”

He considered this. “And you'd eat cake for seven days and complain about feeling unwell.”

“Probably.”

They found a small shop selling old records and books, and Layla insisted they go inside. The owner had placed several boxes of records beneath a table, with handwritten labels that were less useful than he seemed to believe. Kareem examined a stack of novels while Layla listened to a record playing near the counter.

“You like this?” he asked.

“I do.”

“Why?”

She turned toward him. “Does everything need a reason?”

“No. I'm asking because I want to know.”

The answer quieted her for a moment. She had grown accustomed to questions that carried a task behind them: What happened? What do you need? What should we do? Kareem's question asked for no solution. He wanted to know what she liked, and the fact that she did not have to justify the answer made her feel strangely unguarded.

“I like the way it sounds,” she said at last. “And I like that it reminds me of being young enough to listen to a song without thinking about what I should be doing.”

He nodded. “That makes sense.”

She looked at him. “What about you? What do you like that has no practical use?”

He opened his mouth, then closed it. The question seemed simple until he tried to answer it. He liked books, but they were also his work. He liked walking, but it helped him think. He liked being alone, but sometimes he used solitude to avoid people.

“I like finding a sentence that says something I thought I was the only person thinking,” he said eventually.

Layla smiled. “That's a good answer.”

“I'm relieved. I was worried I'd have to invent a hobby.”

“You could collect spoons.”

“I'd prefer not to become interesting in that particular way.”

They left the shop without buying anything. Outside, Layla took his hand without looking at him first. The gesture was casual, as though it had occurred to her only after she had already done it. Kareem felt the familiar rush of wanting to preserve the moment, to give it a name that would make it feel secure.

Instead, he let them keep walking.

They ate sandwiches at a small table beside the pavement. Layla stole the last pickle from his plate, and Kareem accused her of violating the rules of shared dining. She argued that the rules had never been written down. They debated whether this made the act legal or merely difficult to prosecute.

By the time they parted, the afternoon had passed without either of them doing anything particularly useful. Neither had solved a problem, completed an errand, or made a decision about the future.

That evening, Kareem realized he had not once wondered whether the time had been well spent. He had simply enjoyed it. The discovery was small, but it unsettled an old belief: that a day was easiest to justify when it produced something measurable.

Layla, on her way home, found herself smiling at the thought of the record shop. She had not bought anything, and she had no reason to return. Yet she could remember the song, the dust on the shelves, and the exact expression on Kareem's face when she accused him of having practical taste in food.

She wanted to tell him she had enjoyed the afternoon. Then she remembered that he had been there for it. She did not need to send a report.

Instead, she sent him a single message: *I had a very good day.* He replied: *Me too.* For once, neither needed to add anything.

By the time Layla's twenty-seventh birthday arrived, the time she spent with Kareem had become one of the parts of her life she looked forward to without having to justify it. He asked her to meet him after work at a coffee shop. She expected an ordinary hour together, perhaps a coffee and one of their arguments

about a book, and arrived still thinking about a difficult email she'd received that afternoon.

Kareem was already there. A small paper bag sat on the table beside a single flower, and when he saw her looking at them, his nervousness became so obvious that she almost smiled before he had said anything.

“Happy birthday,” he said. “I wasn't sure whether this was too much.”

“For a coffee?”

“For you.” He looked embarrassed by his own answer and pushed the bag toward her. “You mentioned the book once. I remembered it.”

She took the book out first. It was the exact one she'd spoken about weeks earlier, in passing, never expecting him to remember the title. Beneath it was a small box. Inside lay a delicate silver bracelet, its tiny butterfly wings lifted as if it were about to take flight.

For a moment, Layla simply looked at it. The gifts were not extravagant, and that was part of what moved her. He had paid attention. He had heard her when she had not been trying to make herself memorable.

“Do you like it?” he asked, his voice uncertain.

She laughed softly, already struggling to keep the happiness from showing too plainly. “Kareem, I love it.”

He helped her work the clasp closed, careful not to make too much of the gesture. The silver butterfly caught the light when she turned her wrist. She kept looking at it, surprised by how young and delighted she felt, as though someone had handed her a little proof that she could be cared for without having to earn it first.

The flower lay between them on the table, its pale petals opening at the edges. She thanked him again, then leaned over the book to show him the passage she'd first thought of when she'd mentioned it. They spent the next hour talking about the book, about birthdays, and about the small details people remembered when they listened properly. Kareem admitted that he had chosen the flower at the last minute because the book and bracelet had seemed too easy to wrap without it. Layla told him it was perfect, and he believed her.

When she got home, she placed the flower between the first pages of the book as it began to wilt. Later, when the petals had dried and softened to the color of old paper, she left it where it was. She wore the bracelet the next morning, then the day after that, and every day that followed. It became part of her without ceremony, a small silver shape at her wrist through workdays, train journeys,

happy afternoons, and the difficult conversations that would come later. She did not take it off again until the last time she saw Kareem.

CHAPTER FOUR

Everything He Meant to Say

“There are moments when silence does not protect love; it leaves love alone to defend itself.”

Layla learned about the fellowship on a Tuesday morning, when an email arrived from a small publishing house in Alexandria inviting her to interview for a one-year editorial position.

She read it at her desk, then closed the email and opened it again. The position was exactly the kind of opportunity she had been hoping for: developmental editing, work with new writers, and a chance to help shape the publishing house's list rather than simply rescue manuscripts near the end of the process.

She was excited.

She was frightened, too.

Alexandria was not far from Cairo, but a year away felt like a door she had never quite given herself permission to open. She thought about her mother, who still called when something in the household needed fixing. She thought about Mariam and Youssef, whose lives were changing in ways she could not supervise forever. She thought about Kareem, and how the daily rhythm of their relationship had grown around the city they shared.

She applied.

The interview had taken place in a bright room above a bookshop near the Alexandria waterfront. Layla had spent the train journey rehearsing answers to questions she had not yet been asked. She had prepared examples of difficult editorial decisions, notes about the kinds of writers she wanted to work with, and a list of questions about the publishing house's plans for the coming year.

Salwa, the editorial director, had been direct but warm. She asked Layla what she would do if an author disagreed with a substantial revision, how she decided when to preserve a writer's voice and when to intervene, and what she hoped to learn from the fellowship. Layla answered carefully at first, then more confidently as the conversation moved toward the work itself. She described a manuscript she had helped rescue the previous year and explained why the best edit was not always the one that made a sentence technically correct.

“What do you want to be doing in five years?” Salwa asked.

Layla had prepared an answer about senior editorial responsibilities, but the question made her hesitate. She had spent most of her adult life planning around what her family needed, then around what work required. She had rarely allowed herself to describe a future simply because she wanted it.

“I want to be trusted with books before they're finished,” she said finally. “I want to help shape them, not only make them presentable. I want to work with writers who are still discovering what they're trying to say.”

Salwa smiled. “That's a good answer.”

Layla left the bookshop with the feeling that she had been seen clearly enough to be frightened. The interview had been difficult, but it had not required her to perform certainty. Salwa had challenged her answers, asked for examples, and waited when Layla needed a moment to think. There had been no easy way to hide behind the language she used at work. She had needed to say what she actually wanted.

Outside, the wind moved in from the water, lifting the loose pages in the folder she carried. The street below the shop was crowded with people coming and going, and somewhere nearby a tram rang its bell. Layla walked without deciding where she was going, letting the city take her along the waterfront for a while before she returned to the station.

She passed a couple arguing about directions, a man arranging books on a folding table, and a little girl who had stopped to watch the waves strike the breakwater. The girl kept asking her father how far the water went. He answered patiently the first two times, then began inventing distances, telling her that the sea reached places she had never heard of. The child accepted each answer with delight.

Layla smiled at them, then felt the sudden ache of remembering her own father. She had been thinking about him all morning, though the interview itself had left little room for grief. She wondered what he would have said about the fellowship. She could almost hear him asking whether she had negotiated the salary, whether she liked the people, whether the work would make her happy. Then he would have invented a story about the man selling books, giving him a family and a destination and a reason for standing on that corner.

She took out her phone and opened Kareem's conversation.

The interview went well, she typed.

She stared at the words. They were true, but they did not convey the strange feeling of having said aloud what she wanted her life to become. She tried again.

I think I might actually get this. I think I might be good at it.

Her thumb rested above the screen. She wanted to send the message, but she also wanted to wait until she knew what the answer would be. She did not want to confuse hope with certainty, or ask Kareem to respond to an outcome that had not yet happened.

She deleted the second sentence and sent the first.

His reply arrived as she reached the corner.

I'm glad. Tell me everything when you get back.

She smiled at the phone. It was a good answer, and she was grateful for it. Still, as she continued toward the station, she recognized how much she was already trying to manage the meaning of each conversation: how much to say, when to say it, what she could ask him to carry, and what she should keep to herself until it became easier to explain.

The interview had given her a possible future. It had also shown her how much practice she still needed in allowing someone to witness a decision before she had made it perfectly safe.

The offer arrived three days later. Layla read it in the stairwell of her office, sitting on the step between two floors while the sound of her colleagues moved faintly above her. She called her mother first. Nadia was proud, but the pride quickly tangled with practical worries: the rent, the move, the distance, the effect on Youssef and Mariam. Layla answered what she could and promised to look at the details.

When she hung up, she stayed on the stairs for a few minutes. She felt the pull of the familiar life she would leave behind and the force of the life she might build. She wanted both. She wanted her family to be all right without her constant supervision. She wanted to find out who she was when she was not automatically the person who had to take responsibility.

She thought about Kareem. She wanted to tell him, but she was afraid that his reaction would become another thing she needed to interpret. She wanted him to be happy for her and honest about what the distance would mean. She did not want his approval to become the condition that allowed her to choose.

That evening, Layla went home with the offer open on her phone and a knot of competing feelings beneath her ribs. She found Mariam in the living room, sitting cross-legged on the sofa with a laptop balanced on her knees. Nadia was in the kitchen, asking Youssef whether he had put his school papers away. The television played quietly, though no one appeared to be watching it.

Mariam glanced up. “You look like something happened.”

“Something did.” Layla put her bag down. “I got the fellowship.”

Mariam's face changed immediately. “You got it?”

Layla nodded. Her sister shut the laptop and stood to hug her. For a few seconds, Layla allowed herself to feel only the happiness of the news. Mariam was proud of her. She said so without qualification, without turning the opportunity into a calculation about what it would cost the family.

“You have to go,” Mariam said.

Layla laughed. “You sound very certain.”

“Because you've been talking about this kind of work for years. You think I haven't noticed?” Mariam sat again. “You get home from the office and tell us about an author who doesn't understand his own book, and you look happier talking about that than you do about anything else.”

“That is a very unflattering description of my social life.”

“It's an accurate one.”

Layla sat beside her. “Mama's worried.”

“Of course she's worried. She's Mama.” Mariam's expression softened. “But she'll be proud of you, too. Those feelings can exist at the same time.”

Layla looked toward the kitchen. She could hear her mother opening cupboards, moving plates, doing something with her hands while she considered the news. Nadia had been the same way since their father's death. Practical tasks gave her somewhere to put feelings she did not know how to express.

“What about you?” Layla asked. “Are you worried?”

“I'm going to miss you.” Mariam shrugged, trying to make the admission sound smaller than it was. “And I'll probably hate having to make my own appointments.”

“You should have been doing that anyway.”

“I know. Which is why this move may be good for both of us.”

They laughed, and Layla felt the tension ease. Then Mariam took her hand.

“Don't make your decision based on what we might need from you. We'll ask for help because that's what families do. You can decide when you can give it.”

Layla stared at her sister. “When did you become sensible?”

“About ten minutes ago. Don't tell anyone. I have a reputation.”

Their laughter drew Nadia from the kitchen. When Layla told her the news, her mother's face brightened, but the brightness was followed by questions. The rent. The train. Whether the apartment would be safe. Whether the fellowship included health insurance. Whether Layla had considered how much she would spend on food. Each question was practical; together, they formed a wall of concern between Layla and the future she had just been offered.

“I haven't decided whether to accept,” Layla said at last, even though she had already decided in the stairwell at work. “I have a few days.”

Nadia nodded. “Of course. You should think carefully.”

Layla wanted to tell her that she had thought carefully for years. She wanted to say that a person could spend so long preparing to do something that everyone around her forgot she was allowed to choose it. Instead, she asked whether her mother wanted tea.

Later, after the apartment had quieted, Mariam came into Layla's room and sat on the edge of the bed. Layla was still looking at the offer letter.

“Are you waiting for Kareem to tell you what to do?” Mariam asked.

Layla's head came up. “No.”

“Good.” Mariam paused. “Are you waiting for him to tell you that he wants you to stay?”

Layla looked away.

Her sister did not press. She simply said, “Those are different things.”

“I know.”

“Do you?”

Layla smiled without humor. “Apparently, not enough.”

She lay awake long after Mariam left, thinking about the distinction. She did not want Kareem to decide whether she should go. She did not want to become another woman who arranged her ambitions around a man's comfort, or who needed permission to pursue work she had earned. But she wanted him to want her. She wanted his desire to be clear enough that she would not have to guess at it while making a decision that would affect them both.

It frightened her to admit that. She had worked hard to become independent, and there was a small, unkind voice inside her that suggested wanting to be wanted made her weak. She knew better, at least in theory. Independence did not mean the absence of attachment. It meant being able to choose without surrendering oneself to the choice.

The next day, when she met Kareem on their walk home, she had already decided she wanted to accept the fellowship. She would tell him because he was part of her life, not because she needed his permission. She would hope he could be honest with her. She would try not to turn his answer into a verdict on whether she had chosen correctly.

She would try.

She had not yet learned that trying to be fair to everyone could become another way of leaving herself out of the conversation.

By the time she told him, she had already decided that she wanted to go.

They were walking home when she mentioned it. She tried to sound casual, but her voice was too bright and her hands were too restless for the news to seem ordinary.

“I got the fellowship.”

Kareem stopped.

“You got it?”

She nodded. “They offered me the position. One year in Alexandria. I have to accept by next Friday, and I'd move in about six weeks.”

He felt the news arrive as two separate truths. She had been offered something wonderful. She was going to leave.

He smiled because he was happy for her, and because he knew this was what she had wanted.

“Layla, that's brilliant.”

Her face brightened. “You think so?”

“Of course I do.”

She began telling him about the position, the publishing house, and the kinds of projects she might work on. He listened and asked questions. He wanted to be entirely happy for her. He was happy for her.

But beneath the happiness was a fear he did not know how to express: that her life might become larger, more interesting, more satisfying, and that he might eventually feel like a person she had once loved in Cairo.

He hated himself for the thought. He hated it more because he could not make it disappear simply by knowing it was unfair.

“What do you think?” she asked at last.

“I think you should take it.”

She nodded slowly. “You do?”

“Yes. It's a good opportunity. You've worked hard for something like this.”

She looked at him, waiting for something else.

He knew what she was asking without her saying it. She wanted to know whether he wanted her to stay. Whether he would ask her to stay. Whether his happiness for her contained any grief for himself.

He wanted to tell her that he wanted both. He wanted her to go, and he wanted her to stay. He wanted her to become everything she was capable of becoming, and he wanted to be standing beside her when she did. He was afraid that the two desires could not coexist without one becoming a burden to the other.

So he said, “I want you to do what's best for you.”

Layla's face changed.

“Is that what you want?”

He looked at her.

“What do you mean?”

“I mean, do you want me to go?”

He could have answered her. He could have said that he wanted her to take the fellowship, but he wanted her to know how much he would miss her. He could have admitted that he was afraid of becoming less important to her, that he wanted her to choose him without having to be asked, and that he was terrified of making his fear sound like a demand.

Instead, he waited for a sentence that would allow him to express all of that without risking any of it.

The sentence never arrived.

Layla watched him struggle, and then she nodded as though she had understood.

“Okay.”

She went home and cried. Not because Kareem had told her to go, but because he had not told her that he wanted her to stay. She felt ashamed of wanting him to ask. She had worked for this opportunity, had imagined the city and the work and the life she might build there. She did not want to need his approval.

But she had wanted his desire. She had wanted to know that her leaving would matter.

The next morning, she accepted the fellowship.

When she told Kareem, he smiled and said he was happy for her. She thanked him. They spoke about practical details, and the conversation remained polite enough that neither of them could accuse the other of being unkind.

That evening, Kareem sat at his desk and wrote a message he did not send.

I want you to go to Alexandria. I want you to have this opportunity. I want you to become everything you've been working toward.

He stopped, then continued.

But I want you to stay, too. I want to see you every day. I want to keep walking home with you. I want to hear about your work and your family and the things that make you happy. I want to be the person you call when something goes wrong, and the person you tell when something goes right.

He looked at the words, surprised by how easily they came once she was not there to hear them.

I'm afraid that if you leave, things will change. I'm afraid you'll discover a life that doesn't have room for me. I'm afraid I'll become another person you have to make time for, another obligation you feel guilty about neglecting.

He read the message again.

I'm afraid I'll lose you, and I'm more afraid that you'll never know how much I wanted you to stay.

He deleted it.

Later that night, Kareem went to his parents' house to return a set of keys his mother had left in his car. He found Hala sorting receipts at the dining table and Mahmoud watching a football match with the sound turned low. The ordinary scene made the distance between his public and private life feel even stranger. A few hours earlier, he had been sitting across from Layla, wanting to tell her that he was afraid. Here, he was the son who had come to return something and would be expected to stay long enough to drink tea.

Hala asked whether he had eaten. He said yes. She asked whether work was still busy. He said it was. His father asked if the car was making a strange noise again, and Kareem explained what the mechanic had said. The conversation moved smoothly through the subjects they all knew how to discuss.

When Hala went to the kitchen, Mahmoud turned the television up slightly. Kareem sat beside him, waiting for an opening that never seemed to arrive. His father commented on the referee, then asked whether the car's tires had been changed. Kareem answered, and the conversation settled back into its familiar track.

For reasons he couldn't have explained, Kareem said, “I'm seeing someone.”

Mahmoud gave a small nod without taking his eyes from the screen. “Mm.”

Kareem waited. He could have offered her name, explained that she worked at the publishing house, or said that he had begun looking forward to every walk home. Instead, he sat beside his father while the match continued. Mahmoud asked whether Kareem could check the car registration before the end of the month. No question about the woman followed. The absence was not hostile enough to call rejection, which somehow made it harder to name.

He could have volunteered the information. He could have told his father that Layla was clever, kind, and impossible to dismiss once she had decided a sentence mattered. He could have said that she had made him look forward to the walk home, and that he had begun to change small parts of his day because he wanted to see her.

He did not.

On the drive home, he was annoyed with himself. He had wanted his father to ask about Layla, and when the questions did not come, he had waited anyway, as though enough silence might eventually make Mahmoud curious. It was not fair to expect another person to ask every question he was too frightened to volunteer. He knew this in theory. In practice, he still wanted his father to notice the things he could not quite bring himself to say.

When he reached his apartment, he opened the message from Layla and read her last reply again. He wanted to tell her he had tried to share something personal with his father and that the conversation had returned almost immediately to the car. It was a small disappointment, but it had stayed with him.

He began typing, stopped, then tried again. He did not want to make the story sound more significant than it was, or turn it into a report about his own development. He wrote: *I told my father I'm seeing someone. He said "mm" and went back to the football match.*

Layla replied: *That sounds lonely.*

He stared at the words. They were not an accusation, and they did not tell him to stop expecting anything from his father. They simply named what he had been trying not to name.

It is, he wrote. *And I feel ridiculous for still wanting him to ask.*

That doesn't make you ridiculous, she replied. *It makes you his son.*

He read the sentence twice. Nothing terrible had happened because he had allowed someone to know what mattered to him. For once, he did not need to make the feeling sound smaller before sharing it.

The next day, Layla was formal with him at work. She spoke about deadlines, returned a manuscript, and thanked him for reviewing a set of proofs. He noticed the distance in her voice but could not decide how to ask about it. After work, he asked whether they could talk.

They sat in a café and spoke carefully around the problem. Kareem said that he wanted her to do what was best for herself. Layla told him she could not keep asking what he felt and then having to figure it out from what he did not say. She needed him to participate in the conversation, not simply approve of whatever she decided.

The day after he deleted the message, Kareem tried to work as though nothing had changed. He corrected a manuscript, answered Hany's questions about a deadline, and sat through a meeting in which his supervisor described the next quarter's publishing schedule. He took notes diligently enough that no one would have guessed he was thinking about a conversation he had not been able to finish.

At lunch, Hany sat across from him and pushed a plate of food toward the middle of the table.

“You're quiet.”

“I'm usually quiet.”

“Not this kind of quiet.”

Kareem looked at him. Hany rarely asked personal questions directly. He was the sort of man who wrapped concern in jokes, making it possible for the other person to accept it without having to admit they needed it.

“Something's going on,” Kareem said.

“Work?”

“No.”

Hany waited.

Kareem thought about telling him. He could say that Layla had been offered the fellowship, that he was proud of her and afraid of losing her, that he had failed to tell her what he wanted when she asked. But the story felt intimate in a way that made him hesitate. He did not want to turn Layla into a problem to be analyzed by someone who barely knew her. He did not want Hany to offer a practical answer that made the feelings sound simpler than they were.

“I'm seeing someone,” he said finally. “She's been offered a job in Alexandria.”

Hany's face brightened. “That's good.”

“It is.”

“And the problem?”

Kareem looked down at his plate. “I don't know how to tell her that I want her to go and stay at the same time.”

Hany considered this without laughing. “Have you tried telling her exactly that?”

“Yes.”

“Did it go badly?”

“I haven't told her.”

Hany leaned back. “Ah.”

Kareem looked up, irritated by the little sound. “What does that mean?”

“It means you're asking me how to solve a conversation you haven't had.”

He was not wrong. Kareem felt himself become defensive, then tired of the defensiveness almost immediately.

“I don't want her to feel responsible for my fear,” he said.

“Then don't make your fear her responsibility. Tell her it's yours. She's allowed to know that you're frightened without being required to fix it.”

Kareem stared at him. The advice was so close to what Layla had said that it felt as though the world were conspiring to repeat a message he had failed to hear the first time.

“What if she thinks I'm asking her to stay?”

“Then you tell her what you're asking. You're a man who edits sentences for a living, Kareem. Use the language.”

Kareem laughed despite himself.

“I thought you were a production manager.”

“I contain multitudes.” Hany took a bite of his food. “Also, I have been married for eleven years. I have learned that people are not as good at guessing as we hope they are.”

The conversation did not solve anything. It did, however, make it harder for Kareem to pretend that silence was a neutral choice. He returned to his desk with the knowledge that he was avoiding a conversation because he feared its consequences, not because he lacked the words entirely.

That evening, he did not send Layla a long message. He did not try to make the relationship safe through a carefully written paragraph. Instead, he called her and asked whether they could talk after work the following day. When she said yes, he felt both relief and dread.

He had made a small decision.

He still had to keep it.

He listened. He wanted to answer. He wanted to tell her that he had been so afraid of asking her to stay that he had made it sound as though he did not care whether she did.

But again, he could not bring the sentence to his mouth.

That night, he finally sent a message.

I want us to try to make this work. I don't know how yet, but I want to. I'm scared of losing you, and I think I've been so afraid of asking you to stay that I've made it sound as though I don't care whether you do.

Layla read it twice.

Thank you for telling me, she replied.

Then, after a pause: *I want us to try, too. But we need to talk properly about what that means.*

For the first time since the offer arrived, Kareem felt that they were speaking about the same future.

It was a small distance they had crossed, not a guarantee that they would never drift apart again. But it mattered.

They spent the following week making plans. They agreed to call in the evenings when possible, to tell each other when plans changed, and to visit as often as work and money allowed. They decided to alternate journeys and to have one longer conversation every week in which they talked about more than what they had eaten or what the weather was doing.

They wrote the plan in Layla's phone.

At the bottom, she added two words: *Do not assume.*

Kareem laughed when he saw them.

“Are those directed at me?”

“They're directed at both of us.”

He wanted to believe the plan would be enough. It was practical, clear, and made by two people who loved each other and wanted to try.

Neither of them understood yet that a plan could tell two people where to meet and still leave them unprepared for what they might bring with them when they arrived.

The first small test of their plan came on a Tuesday evening.

Kareem had promised to call at nine, but his supervisor stopped him on the way out of the office to discuss a set of proofs that needed to be sent to the printer the following morning. The conversation lasted longer than expected. By the time Kareem reached the street, his phone showed 9:17.

His first instinct was to hurry home and call as soon as he could. Then he remembered that Layla might be waiting, and that arriving twenty minutes late without an explanation would mean she had to decide whether he had forgotten or simply become busy.

He sent a message before getting into a taxi.

I'm delayed at work. Nothing's wrong. I'll be home in about twenty minutes. Do you still want to talk when I get there?

Her reply arrived while the taxi was moving through traffic.

Yes. Thank you for telling me.

The message was ordinary. It did not praise him or suggest that the problem had been solved forever. Still, he felt a small, unfamiliar relief. He had not needed to predict how she would feel. He had told her what had happened and left her free to answer.

When he reached home, he called. Layla was sitting at her kitchen table with a cup of tea and a manuscript open beside her. She looked tired, but she smiled when she saw his name on the screen.

“I'm sorry I'm late,” he said.

“You told me you would be.”

“I know. I still wanted to apologize.”

She nodded. “All right.”

He almost asked whether she was upset. Then he stopped. He could hear the old reflex in the question: the wish to make sure the discomfort had disappeared before he allowed himself to continue. Instead, he asked, “How was the rest of your day?”

She told him about an author who had returned a chapter with more mistakes than the version she had sent. He laughed, and she laughed too. They talked for

nearly an hour, not because either of them needed to prove that the plan worked, but because they still wanted to speak to one another.

After the call, Layla sat for a moment with her phone in her hand. The message had not been important because Kareem was late. It mattered because he had thought about the fact that she might be waiting. She knew that one message could not guarantee anything about the year ahead. But it gave her something concrete to remember the next time she began to wonder whether silence meant what she feared it meant.

Kareem, meanwhile, put his phone on the desk and returned to the proofs. He was still tired. The conversation with his supervisor had still delayed him, and the manuscript still needed work. Nothing about his life had become easier in the space of one evening.

But he had done one small thing differently before the old habit could take over.

Neither of them called it progress aloud. They were wary of congratulating themselves too early. They simply went to bed believing that a plan might be useful if they were willing to practice it, one ordinary decision at a time.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Plan We Made

“A promise is not a bridge until someone begins to walk across it.”

The six weeks before Layla left seemed to contain more days than the rest of the year.

Kareem's birthday fell early in those weeks. He had never cared much about the day. As a child, he had accepted whatever small celebration his family happened to arrange; as an adult, he sometimes forgot the date until his sister or brother reminded him. He did not dislike birthdays. He simply had never understood why a day should require him to feel something special about himself.

When Layla asked what he wanted to do, he shrugged. “Nothing, honestly.”

“That isn't a plan.”

“It's a very efficient plan.”

“It's an empty plan.”

He smiled. “Then I'm sure you'll improve it.”

She did not tell him where they were going. She only asked him to keep the afternoon free and wear something he would not mind getting paint on. That last instruction made him suspicious, but he followed it. She led him to a small pottery-painting studio near the Nile, tucked into a side street where the windows glowed warmly against the late-afternoon light.

He stopped at the door. “We're painting pottery?”

“We are.”

“For my birthday?”

“Especially for your birthday.”

Inside, shelves held plain cups, bowls, plates, and small ceramic figures waiting for someone to decide what they might become. Kareem looked around with the wary expression of a man who had agreed to a surprise and was now being asked to participate in it.

“I should warn you,” he said, “I have no artistic ability.”

“Wonderful. Neither do I. We can be terrible together.”

They chose a mug each, then sat at a long table covered with small pots of paint and brushes of different sizes. Layla began with a plan she abandoned almost immediately. Kareem studied the colors with an unexpected seriousness. He tested a blue on the bottom of the mug, frowned, mixed it with a little white, and tried again. Then he began painting a small night sky around the rim, adding dots for stars with the careful concentration he usually reserved for punctuation.

At first, Layla painted too. But after a while she found herself watching him more than looking at her own mug. His shoulders had relaxed. He leaned closer to the ceramic, lips pressed together in concentration, then brightened when a line came out the way he wanted. When his hand slipped and left a crooked mark, he stared at it, considered the damage, and turned it into a little moon. He laughed at his own solution, delighted by the discovery.

There was a boyishness in him she rarely saw: not childishness, but the part of him that could become absorbed in something simply because it was fun. He wasn't trying to do it well enough to impress anyone. He wasn't useful to anyone. He was just there, choosing colors and making a mess, happy enough to forget that he was usually the person who kept watch over what might go wrong.

Layla's brush rested untouched in her hand. The silver butterfly at her wrist caught the light when she moved, but she barely noticed it. She didn't care whether his painting was beautiful. She cared that he was happy in a way that asked nothing of him beyond being present. She watched him as though this were the part of him she most wanted to remember: focused, unguarded, quietly delighted by the smallest success.

At one point, he looked up and found her watching him.

“What?” he asked, suddenly self-conscious.

“Nothing.”

“You're smiling.”

“I'm allowed.”

“Am I doing something ridiculous?”

“Probably.” Her smile deepened. “But I like watching you.”

He looked down again, embarrassed and pleased. “Then watch quietly. I'm making an important artistic decision.”

She laughed, and he returned to his mug with renewed determination.

They stayed until the studio began to empty and the staff carefully took their painted pieces away to be glazed and fired. Outside, the Nile was darkening, carrying the last strips of sunset along its surface. They walked by the water with paint still staining the sides of their fingers, talking about what they had made and what each of them might look like after the kiln. Kareem seemed reluctant to admit how much he had enjoyed himself.

“Thank you,” he said at last. “I don't think I've ever done anything like that for my birthday.”

“Did you have fun?”

He glanced at her. “More than I expected.”

“Then it was a good birthday.”

He looked out at the river. For years, his birthday had been a date he could ignore without losing anything. Layla had turned it into a day he wanted to keep—not because she had made a grand gesture, but because she had found a way to give him a few hours in which he did not have to be careful, useful, or afraid. She had let him be happy without asking him to explain why.

He did not know how to tell her how much that meant. He only said, “I think I might actually celebrate next year.”

Layla turned toward him, pleased by the promise hidden inside the joke. “I'll hold you to that.”

On a Wednesday evening, they sat at the café with Layla's laptop open between them and a list of apartment expenses on the screen. The lease was still being finalized. She had received the estimated deposit, the monthly rent, and the cost of the basic utilities. There were train tickets to consider, groceries, a few household items she could not take from Cairo, and the question of how much she should keep aside for emergencies.

Kareem leaned forward to read the numbers.

“You've included the deposit twice.”

“Have I?” She checked the spreadsheet. “No, one is the deposit and one is the first month's rent.”

“Right.”

“Don't look so disappointed. I was hoping to make at least one financial error in your presence.”

“I can arrange one.”

She laughed and continued down the list. He noticed that she had included a line for trips home, calculated conservatively so she would not have to choose between visiting her family and paying for something necessary in Alexandria.

“You've made room for a lot of train tickets,” he said.

“I don't want to spend the year trying to decide whether I can afford to come home.”

He nodded. The answer made sense, but it also made him consider how much the relationship itself would cost—not only in money, but in weekends, fatigue,

and the effort of coordinating two lives that had become accustomed to sharing the same streets.

“I could help with some of the expenses,” he said.

Layla looked up. “What?”

“The moving costs. Or some of the things you need to buy for the apartment. I have some savings.”

Her expression changed so quickly that he regretted the offer before she answered.

“I can pay for my apartment, Kareem.”

“I know you can.”

“Then why are you offering?”

He drew back slightly. “Because I want to help.”

“I don't need someone to pay for the life I'm building.”

“I didn't say you did.”

“No, but that's how it feels.” She closed the laptop, then immediately looked sorry for doing it. “I'm sorry. I know you're trying to be kind.”

He looked at the table. The offer had seemed obvious to him. He had money saved, she had expenses, and the person he loved was about to move to another city. Helping was something he knew how to do without having to explain the more complicated things he felt. He had not considered that his offer might sound like an attempt to take responsibility for a decision that belonged to her.

“I don't want you to feel as though I think you can't manage,” he said. “I know you can. I just wanted to be part of it.”

Layla's expression softened, but she did not reopen the laptop.

“I know. And I want you to be part of it. But I need to know that I'm doing this because I want it, and that I can afford it because I've planned for it. I don't want to feel as though I owe you something because you helped me leave.”

He nodded slowly. “That makes sense.”

She studied him. “Are you upset?”

“No.” He paused, then corrected himself. “A little embarrassed, perhaps. I thought I was offering you something useful, and I hadn't considered how it might feel from your side.”

She let out a breath. “Thank you for saying that.”

“I can still help carry the boxes.”

She smiled. “That service is acceptable.”

“And I'm willing to contribute to train tickets when I visit.”

“That's different. We'll work it out together.”

He nodded. They reopened the laptop and continued reviewing the expenses. The conversation had taken an uncomfortable turn, but it had not become a fight. Kareem had offered something, Layla had told him how it felt, and he had listened without insisting that his intention should settle the matter.

Later, walking home, he thought about how often he treated practical help as a substitute for a more vulnerable form of participation. He could buy a lamp, carry a box, or pay for a meal. Those gestures allowed him to show care without exposing much of himself. He had always believed actions were more reliable than words. He was beginning to understand that actions could be misunderstood, too, if he never explained what he meant by them.

Layla thought about the conversation from another direction. She had been so accustomed to being the person who handled the practical needs of others that accepting help could make her feel indebted before anyone had asked her to repay anything. She did not want Kareem to stop offering. She wanted to learn how to receive kindness without confusing it with obligation.

That evening, she sent him a message.

I hope you know I appreciated the offer, even though I got defensive.

He replied:

I hope you know I offered because I wanted to help, not because I doubted you could manage.

She read the message twice and felt the quiet relief of a conversation that had not been allowed to turn into a misunderstanding. It was not a grand moment. It was a small example of what they said they wanted to do: speak early, listen, and correct the assumptions before they hardened into resentment.

They would not always manage it so quickly. But that night, they had.

There were practical matters: the apartment in Alexandria, the lease, the train schedules, the list of things she needed to pack. There were family conversations, some of them easier than others. There were evenings with Kareem that they both tried not to treat as farewells, even though every familiar routine had acquired a shadow of its future absence.

Kareem told his parents about Layla on a Thursday evening. His mother, Hala, responded with a flood of questions about her age, her family, her work, and how long the relationship had been going on. Mahmoud remained in his armchair, attending to the television and occasionally asking practical questions about the car or Kareem's work. When Kareem explained that Layla had accepted a year-long fellowship in Alexandria, his mother worried aloud about what the distance might do to them.

“People change,” Hala said. “They get used to living without each other.”

“I know,” Kareem replied. “But I don't think that means we should give up before we've tried.”

He surprised himself with the firmness of his voice. He had spent years avoiding conversations that might upset his mother. Now he was telling her that his choices belonged to him, even when he could not guarantee the result.

When Hala asked how they had met, Kareem told the story of the manuscript sentence, Layla's argument, and the first walk home. He found himself speaking faster than usual, trying to make the story vivid enough to hold the room's attention. His mother listened and asked follow-up questions. Mahmoud glanced up once, nodded, then returned to the television. Kareem felt the old, childish impulse to add another detail, to make the story interesting enough that his father might want to hear the rest. He stopped himself. He was tired of auditioning for attention, even though a part of him still wanted to be chosen.

He asked Layla to meet them. She agreed, nervous but curious.

The dinner was warm at first. Hala welcomed her, asked about her work, and admired the pastries she had brought. Mahmoud asked about the fellowship, and Layla explained the kind of editing she hoped to do in Alexandria. Then Hala asked what would happen to the relationship if the year apart became difficult.

Layla answered calmly, explaining that they had made a plan and intended to try. Hala continued to ask whether it would not be safer to make a decision before feelings became more complicated. Kareem watched the conversation with a familiar dread. He wanted to defend Layla, but he also wanted to preserve the peace of his parents' home.

For several moments, he said nothing.

Layla looked at him once. She did not ask him to rescue her. She simply waited to see whether he would speak.

At last, he said, “She's right. The fellowship is important to her, and I want her to take it. I want us to try to make this work while she's there.”

Hala looked at him. “And if it doesn't?”

“I don't know,” he said. “But she shouldn't have to prove she loves me by staying.”

The room went quiet. Mahmoud did not enter the discussion. After a moment, he asked Kareem whether he had called the mechanic back. The practical question shifted the room toward a subject he understood, and the evening continued. Kareem felt the familiar disappointment of wanting his father to have an opinion about his life, then felt foolish for wanting it.

On the walk home, Layla told him she did not need him to fight with his mother. She needed him not to leave her alone in a room where their future was being discussed. He apologized and admitted that he had been more worried about making his mother unhappy than about how Layla felt sitting there.

“Peace that depends on me defending my life while you sit there isn't peace,” she told him.

He remembered the sentence long after they parted.

A few days later, Kareem visited Layla's family. Nadia welcomed him with food and questions. Mariam wanted to know how they had met, and Youssef asked whether Kareem was a serious person or merely someone who made jokes about punctuation. The evening was noisy, affectionate, and disorienting. Kareem watched Layla move around the household, remembering appointments, answering questions, and offering to fix small problems before anyone had finished describing them. Near the end of the meal, Nadia asked—gently, without accusation—whether he and Layla had discussed what would happen after the fellowship. She wanted her daughter to be happy, but she also knew how much Layla had already rearranged her life around the needs of others. Mariam, trying to lighten the question, asked whether Kareem would ever come to Alexandria more often. Everyone smiled, but Kareem felt a future being measured against answers he was not yet sure he could give. His own family wanted him to stay; Layla's family wanted assurance that she would not be left waiting. Neither family was trying to hurt him. Both made the decision feel as though more people than the two of them were already living inside it.

When Youssef asked for help with an application during dinner, Layla said no for the first time in a way that surprised the whole table. She wanted to finish eating without being responsible for the next task. The family moved on, but Kareem noticed how uncomfortable she seemed after refusing, as though she were waiting for someone to accuse her of selfishness.

Later, he told her he had noticed how much everyone expected her to carry. She explained that after her father's death, she had become the person who knew what to do. She loved her family, but she was beginning to understand that being needed was not the same as being known.

“I don't want you to become the person who takes care of me instead of letting me take care of myself,” she said.

“I don't want that either.”

“I want you to notice when I'm carrying too much. But I don't want you to decide what I should put down.”

He nodded. “Then I need to ask you what you need, instead of guessing.”

“Exactly.”

They made one trip to Alexandria together before the move, ostensibly to check the lease and measure the apartment's windows. In truth, neither wanted Layla to choose the details of her new life entirely alone, and neither quite knew how to admit that the trip mattered to them for reasons beyond furniture and paperwork.

The landlord met them outside the building and handed Layla the keys. She opened the apartment door and stepped inside first. The rooms were still mostly empty, the afternoon light resting across the floor in pale rectangles. Kareem followed with a notebook in which he had written measurements for the shelves, the desk, and the space beside the bed where a lamp might fit.

“You've made a list,” Layla said.

“Several.”

“Of course you have.”

He moved toward the bedroom and measured the wall beside the bed. She watched him, smiling at the seriousness with which he treated an empty room.

“You know I could do this myself,” she said.

“I know.”

“You don't have to make yourself useful every time we're together.”

He stopped and looked at her. He recognized the concern beneath the tease. He had spent the previous weeks offering practical help because it was the form of care he understood best. He did not want to become the person who solved problems for her in order to avoid speaking about what the move meant.

“I know I don't have to,” he said. “I just like doing some of it with you.”

Layla's smile softened. “Then do it with me. Not for me.”

He nodded. The distinction was small, but he wanted to remember it.

They measured the windows, checked the kitchen cupboards, and argued about where the bookshelf should go. Layla wanted it near the window so she could read in the light. Kareem pointed out that the afternoon sun would fade the spines. She told him that the books had not been purchased to spend their lives in darkness. He conceded the point after she threatened to consult an independent expert.

In the living room, she stood by the balcony doors and imagined where the sofa might go. Kareem watched her trying to picture the space furnished, and he felt the strange ache of seeing a future he wanted to inhabit without knowing whether he would be part of it in the same way she would.

“Can you imagine it?” she asked.

“Yes.”

“Me living here?”

He took a breath. “Yes. I can imagine you here. I can imagine you coming home from work and leaving books on every surface. I can imagine you complaining about the tram and telling me about an author who has misunderstood his own manuscript.”

She laughed. “That sounds very much like me.”

“It does.”

She looked at him. “Can you imagine yourself here?”

The question was gentle, but it touched the uncertainty they had been careful not to turn into a demand. He could imagine visiting. He could imagine spending weekends there, learning the neighborhood, sharing the apartment's ordinary hours. He could imagine moving, too, though he did not know what work he would find or how he would leave a job he had spent years trying to make meaningful.

“I can imagine visiting,” he said. “And I can imagine that the future might change. I don't know enough yet to promise more than that.”

Layla nodded. She appreciated the honesty, though a part of her wished the answer had been different. She did not want to pressure him into a decision he was not ready to make. She also did not want to mistake the possibility of a future for a plan to create one.

“That's fair,” she said.

They returned the keys to the envelope and went downstairs. Before leaving, Layla looked up at the windows once more. The apartment was still empty. It would become hers through the ordinary accumulation of days, not because a lease had been signed or a key had changed hands.

Kareem took her hand as they walked toward the station. Neither spoke about the fact that she had asked whether he could imagine himself there, or that he had answered honestly without offering the certainty she might have wanted. They had tried to be kind to each other. They were still learning that kindness did not always make an answer easier to hear.

The practical arrangements grew more complicated once the families understood that the move was real. Hala called Kareem several times to ask whether he was sure he wanted to continue a relationship across two cities. Mahmoud did not ask about the relationship; when Kareem visited, his father spoke about the car, work, and family errands, leaving Kareem to decide whether to volunteer anything personal. Kareem listened without arguing more than he had to, then told his mother that he wanted to try.

He found himself surprised by his own certainty. He was frightened of the distance, but he was more frightened by the possibility of allowing fear to make the decision for him. He had spent too much of his life waiting for difficult feelings to become easier before acting. He did not want to make that mistake with Layla.

At work, Hany noticed that Kareem had begun keeping a list of weekends when he planned to travel. He leaned over the desk one afternoon and examined the calendar.

“You've become organized.”

“I've always been organized.”

“You once forgot your own birthday until your sister called.”

“That was a deliberate test of whether anyone remembered.”

Hany laughed. “And now you're planning train journeys weeks in advance.”

Kareem looked at the calendar. “Someone matters enough that I don't want to leave everything to chance.”

Hany's expression softened. He did not tease him again.

Layla, meanwhile, began to discover how difficult it was to prepare to leave a home that had been built around her availability. Nadia asked her to help with the family budget. Mariam wanted advice about a problem at work. Youssef

asked her to review his application. Layla did what she could, then began setting limits when she could not.

The first time she told her mother she would call the next day rather than immediately handle a small problem, she spent half the evening feeling guilty. The second time, it was easier. The third time, she discovered that her mother could solve more than she believed she could.

The family did not suddenly become independent. They still called, still needed her, and still worried about the move. But each small boundary changed the arrangement by a fraction. Layla began to understand that leaving did not require her to stop loving them. It required her to stop treating their every need as an instruction.

Kareem saw the effort it took. He also understood that he could not do it for her. When she told him she was worried about disappointing her mother, he asked what she wanted to do rather than telling her what she should do. Sometimes she knew. Sometimes she did not. He was learning to let uncertainty remain in the conversation without rushing to solve it.

Two days before the move, Layla returned to the office to hand over a project that had taken nearly four months to complete. The manuscript was ready for production, the author had approved the final changes, and the schedule had been updated to show who would take over while she was in Alexandria.

She had expected the handover to be straightforward. Instead, the young coordinator who would take responsibility for the project sat beside her desk with a notebook open and asked, “What do I do if the author rejects the edit again?”

Layla looked at the manuscript between them.

“You explain why the edit matters. You give him a clear alternative if one exists. You tell him what can't change because of the deadline. And then you let him be unhappy about it.”

The coordinator frowned. “What if he thinks I'm being difficult?”

“He might.” Layla smiled. “You can be kind without making every decision for the other person. Your job isn't to stop him from feeling disappointed. It's to do the work well and communicate clearly.”

As she spoke, she heard the advice she had been trying to learn in her own life. She had spent so long anticipating disappointment that she sometimes treated it as evidence that she had done something wrong. The possibility of

upsetting someone could make her reconsider a decision even when the decision was right.

The coordinator asked a few more questions. Layla answered them, showed her where the correspondence was saved, and pointed out two sections of the manuscript that might need attention if the author requested further changes. Then she closed the file and sat back.

“You'll be fine,” she said. “You don't have to know everything before you begin. You only need to know how to ask when you don't.”

The young woman looked relieved. “Thank you. I was worried I'd be left alone with it.”

Layla smiled. “You won't be. There are people here. Ask them for help. That's what they're here for.”

After the coordinator left, Layla remained at her desk for a few minutes. She had been the person who knew where everything was, who could explain what had happened in a meeting three months earlier, who remembered which author required a gentler email and which one needed a firmer deadline. She was proud of the work she had done. She was also ready to let someone else take responsibility for it.

Hany appeared with the plain notebook he had given her. “Have you written anything in it yet?”

“Not much.”

“Good. You need to leave room for the interesting things.”

She laughed. “Is that your editorial advice?”

“It's my life advice. My editorial advice is to stop leaving your coffee on top of paperwork.”

She looked at the desk. Her cup was, in fact, sitting on a stack of proofs.

“That's a very specific criticism.”

“I believe in actionable feedback.”

She moved the cup and closed the notebook. “I'll miss this place.”

Hany's usual theatrical expression softened. “We'll miss you, too.”

She felt her throat tighten. “Don't make it sentimental.”

“I'm not. I'm establishing a professional fact.”

She laughed, and he returned to production. For a while she watched the office carry on around her: phones ringing, printers starting and stopping, someone

asking where a file had been saved. The ordinary rhythm would continue after she left. Someone else would answer the questions, fix the mistakes, and take responsibility for the manuscripts. The knowledge was both comforting and painful.

On her way out, she stopped at Kareem's desk. He was reading a proof, pencil in hand, his expression concentrated enough that he did not notice her at first.

“I'm leaving,” she said.

He looked up. “For the day?”

“For the office.”

The correction seemed to strike him more deeply than she intended. His expression softened, then became careful again.

“Right.” He put down the pencil. “How does it feel?”

She thought about giving him a reassuring answer. Instead, she told him the truth. “It feels like I've spent years building something here, and I'm proud of it. I'm also ready to leave. I think both things are going to be true for a while.”

He nodded.

“I think that's how it should be,” he said.

She watched him for a moment. “I'm glad you can say that.”

He looked at her. “I am, too.”

She squeezed his hand, gathered her bag, and walked toward the door. She did not look back until she reached the corridor. Kareem had returned to his proof, but his pencil was still resting in his hand, unmoving.

She wanted to go back and ask him what he was feeling. She wanted to make sure he was all right. She wanted to make the leaving a little easier for him, because she loved him and knew that the change would hurt.

Then she remembered that he was allowed to be sad without her turning that sadness into another responsibility. She let him have the feeling she had not been able to name for him, and walked out into the evening.

The last week at the office brought its own kind of farewell. Layla had expected Hany to make a joke, and he did: he announced that the publishing house would have to hire someone to correct the mistakes Kareem made in her absence. Kareem objected that his work had never depended on Layla's supervision. Hany asked whether he wanted the room to vote on that claim. By the time the laughter died down, Layla felt the familiar ache of leaving something ordinary behind.

After lunch, Hany placed a small notebook on her desk. The cover was plain, the pages unlined.

“For the train,” he said. “You can use it for your notes.”

Layla opened it. “Thank you. That's thoughtful.”

“Don't sound so surprised. I have depths.”

“I'm sure you do.”

He lingered beside her desk for a moment, his usual theatrical ease giving way to something more awkward. “It's going to be strange without you here.”

She looked up. Hany rarely spoke sincerely without disguising the moment with a joke. “I'll still be working in publishing. It's not as though I'm joining a monastery.”

“I know. But you're good at making people feel as though the work is possible when it gets difficult.” He shrugged, embarrassed by his own honesty. “That's not a small thing.”

Layla felt a surprising pressure in her throat. She had spent so much time preparing to leave that she had not considered how much of her ordinary life had been shaped by the people she worked beside. She had complained about Hany's dramatic announcements, his terrible coffee, and his insistence on treating every formatting error as a public emergency. She would miss those things. She would miss them more than she had expected.

“Thank you,” she said. “I'll miss you, too.”

When he left, she looked at the notebook again. She put it in her bag beside her father's notebook, then laughed softly at the coincidence. One notebook held reminders from a life that had ended unexpectedly. The other was empty, waiting for a life she had chosen. She did not need to make the comparison into a lesson. Still, she carried both home.

That evening, she and Kareem met outside the office and walked their usual route. They passed the shop where they had once bought water, the crossing where Layla had invited him to walk with her again, and the café where they had sat during the rain. The city seemed to be offering them a list of places in which something had begun.

“Do you think we'll come back here?” she asked.

“Of course.”

“Together?”

He glanced at her. “Yes.”

She smiled, but did not miss how quickly he had answered, as though certainty were a kindness he could offer without having to examine it. She wanted to believe him. She also knew that wanting something to be true was not the same as knowing it would happen.

They walked on, holding hands. For once, neither tried to use the conversation to make a plan. They let the streets carry them past the familiar corners, and when they reached the place where their routes divided, they did not immediately say goodbye. They stood there for a while, listening to the traffic, letting the last ordinary walk become a memory without turning it into a ceremony.

On the last Sunday before the move, they made a list together: apartment keys, train tickets, documents, books, clothes, the notebook, the plant. Layla checked the items twice. Kareem added “the lamp” in the margin.

She looked at him. “Why is the lamp on the list?”

“Because it has become a member of the family.”

She laughed. “You are impossible.”

“Yet you continue to invite me into your life.”

She looked at him for a moment, then took his hand. “I do.”

Neither said what they were both thinking: that the life they were about to attempt would require more than lists, and that no amount of preparation could make the leaving painless. Later that afternoon, Layla opened her father's notebook, its pages filled with reminders and small tasks he had expected to complete. She hesitated over whether to take it to Alexandria. Kareem told her that protecting something she loved did not have to mean leaving it where it was. She placed it in the box marked PERSONAL, beside the photographs her mother gave her.

Nadia struggled with the move. One evening, she admitted that she had become used to Layla being available because, after her husband died, Layla had helped hold the family together. “I don't want you to stay here because you're afraid of what I'll do without you,” she said at last.

Layla cried. Her mother held her and told her she would miss her, but that she should go.

The night before the departure, Kareem took Layla to the café where they had first spoken about her father. They agreed not to spend the evening counting the hours left in Cairo. They argued about a film, bought a book they did not need, and walked beside the Nile until the city lights trembled on the water.

They talked about the rules they had made for the coming year. They would call when possible, tell each other when plans changed, and return to difficult conversations instead of letting them disappear. They would not demand that every day be easy, but neither would they treat silence as proof that nothing was wrong.

“Do you think we're overplanning this?” Layla asked.

“A little,” Kareem said.

“Then why are we doing it?”

“Because I'd rather have a plan we can change than a set of assumptions neither of us knows how to question.”

She held his hand. “That's almost wise.”

“I'm saving my best material for Alexandria.”

She laughed and held his hand.

That night, they stood at the door of Layla's apartment longer than either had intended. The boxes were stacked beside the wall, the documents lay in a folder on the desk, and the keys to Alexandria rested in her bag. There was nothing practical left to prepare that could not wait until morning.

“I wish tomorrow weren't so close,” Kareem said.

Layla looked at him. “I wish I could leave without feeling as though I'm leaving everyone.”

He took her hand. “You aren't leaving everyone. You're going somewhere.”

She smiled sadly. “I know. I just wish knowing it made it easier.”

They held hands, neither of them willing to decide who should let go first. Eventually, Layla drew a breath and said, “We should sleep.”

“Yes,” he said.

Neither moved.

At last she laughed, and he laughed with her. They made one final list of things to check in the morning, though both knew the list was mostly an excuse to postpone the goodbye. When Kareem finally left, he promised to meet her outside the building early the next morning. Layla promised to be ready.

They had made enough plans to fill a year. What they could not plan was how it would feel to wake up in different cities.

That night, each lay awake for a while, listening to the familiar sounds of home and trying to imagine the unfamiliar ones waiting on the other side of morning.

CHAPTER SIX

The Morning of the Train

“Leaving is not one act. It is a hundred small departures that begin long before the door closes.”

The morning Kareem left, Layla woke before the alarm.

For several seconds she lay still, listening to the unfamiliar sounds outside the apartment. The tram rattled in the distance, and someone on the street below was calling to a delivery driver. The other side of the bed was empty. Kareem had returned to his hotel after their goodbye at her door, as they had agreed. She had known it was the sensible arrangement; knowing it did not stop the morning from feeling strange.

She had wanted him to see the apartment, to know the route to work, to hear the sounds that were becoming part of her days. Now she wanted his visit to last a little longer, long enough that the new place would feel less separate from the life she had left behind. She made tea, checked her bag twice, and went downstairs to buy bread and salt for the kitchen. On the way back, she bought a small plant she had not intended to buy. She had wanted the apartment to feel inhabited by something living.

When her phone lit up with Kareem's message—*I'm outside*—she locked the door and went down to meet him. He was waiting beside a taxi with his own bag at his feet. His eyes moved to the plant in her hands.

“You went out for salt,” he said, looking at the plant.

“I also bought bread.”

“And a plant.”

“It looked lonely.”

“That's not a reason to buy a plant.”

“It looked lonely and inexpensive.”

He smiled. “A compelling argument.”

They were still laughing when it was time to leave for the station. Kareem put his bag in the taxi and checked that he had his ticket. Layla reminded him that he had checked it twice already. He said he was being prepared; she said she was beginning to suspect preparedness was his favorite excuse for worrying.

Before they got into the taxi, Kareem took the small bag with the groceries from her while she adjusted the plant against her side. She reached for the bag, then stopped herself. She wanted to be capable of carrying her own things. She also appreciated that he had offered, and there was no reason to turn every act of help into a referendum on her independence.

The station was crowded. They stood together while the departure board updated, surrounded by families and people carrying bags, boxes, and the small

necessities of travel. Kareem bought her water and then bought another bottle because he had forgotten that she already had one in her bag.

“You're nervous,” she said.

“I'm being prepared.”

“That's what you call it?”

“It's a professional skill.”

She smiled, but her eyes filled with tears before she could stop them. She hated that the goodbye was happening in public, where she had to make a small effort to keep from crying too visibly. Kareem noticed and put down the bag he was holding.

“Do you want to talk?” he asked.

She shook her head, then nodded. “I don't know.”

“That's all right.”

“I wish you could come with me.”

He reached for her hand and held it. “I wish I could, too.”

For a moment, they let themselves say the things they had been trying to make easier for each other. They wished they could keep the old routines. They wished the distance were smaller. They wished they knew what the year would do to them. None of those wishes became a demand. They were simply truths they could share without asking the other person to solve them.

When the train was announced, Kareem lifted his bag. He held her hand for a few seconds longer than necessary, then let go. He stepped onto the train, turned once to wave, and found her still standing on the platform.

The train began to move.

Layla watched it leave until the last carriage disappeared beyond the station. Then she stood for another minute, as though some part of her expected the train to return or the morning to rearrange itself into something less final.

It did not.

She went back to the apartment, unlocked the door, and stepped inside. The room was quiet. The lamp stood beside the bed, the books were on their shelves, and the plant waited beside the balcony door. The things she had chosen to bring with her looked ordinary in the daylight.

She placed her keys on the table and sat on the sofa.

She was alone in the city she had chosen.

She was also, for the first time in a long while, allowed to be alone without immediately being needed by someone else.

The freedom and the grief arrived together. She did not try to decide which one was more important.

The first night, after Kareem's train had departed and the last box had been unpacked, Layla stood in the living room and listened to the silence. In Cairo, silence had never been empty. It was always interrupted by someone calling from another room, the television in the living room, or her mother asking whether she had remembered something important.

Here, the silence belonged to her.

She made tea and sat on the sofa. She did not have to explain where she was going or when she would return. She did not have to check whether Youssef had sent his documents or whether Mariam had remembered an appointment. She could choose to do nothing, and nothing would immediately become a problem.

The freedom was so complete that it made her anxious. She spent the first evening making a list of groceries, then a list of things to buy for the kitchen, then a list of what she needed to ask the landlord. When she realized she had begun turning the apartment into another project, she put the notebook down and opened the balcony doors.

The sea air moved through the room. A tram rattled in the distance. Someone laughed in the street below.

She stayed by the window until she felt herself settle.

The next morning, she walked to the publishing house on her own. She had rehearsed the route in her head the night before, but she still checked the building number when she reached the street. The office was already awake. Salwa stood by a table covered in manuscripts, speaking to another editor about a deadline that had moved without warning. She welcomed Layla, introduced her to the team, and showed her the desk she would use.

No one treated Layla as a guest. They asked her to review a short-story collection whose order had been disputed, and when she suggested beginning with a quieter piece, one of the editors challenged her reasoning. The question made her nervous, but it was a useful kind of nervousness. She explained the shape she imagined for the collection, listened to the objections, and changed part of her proposal when she saw that the argument could be stronger.

Salwa asked her to present the revised idea to the rest of the team. The request surprised her more than the criticism. She had expected to spend the first few

days proving that she belonged. Instead, she was being asked to contribute before she had time to become comfortable.

At lunch, a colleague took her to a small restaurant nearby. They talked about books, the neighborhood, and the practical difficulties of living in a city where the wind could change the weather in the space of a single street. The colleague asked whether Layla was settling in. Layla said yes, then realized she meant it.

When she returned that evening, she bought bread from the bakery and ate dinner on the balcony. She called Kareem and told him about the office, the disputed story order, and the fact that she had managed to get lost for a few minutes before finding her way again without asking anyone for help. He laughed with her. She could hear that he was pleased.

She did not tell him that, at one point, she had nearly called him from the street simply because she had not known what to do with the feeling of being alone. She had wanted to discover whether she could find her way through the newness without reaching immediately for the person who had become her most familiar refuge.

She had managed it, though not without effort. After the call, she unpacked the last box of books and placed her father's notebook on the bedside table. Beside it she put the empty notebook Hany had given her. One recorded the things her father had intended to do; the other had no entries yet. She wondered what she would write in it over the coming year: names of authors, notes about stories, places she liked, things she did not want to forget.

She opened it to the first page and wrote the date. Then she wrote: *I am here.*

She looked at the words for a long time before closing the notebook. It was not a declaration that she was no longer homesick or afraid. It was simply a record of the fact that she had arrived, that she had chosen this place, and that the next part of her life had begun whether or not she felt ready for it.

When Kareem returned to Cairo after the move, his apartment felt more orderly than it had before, which was a way of saying that it felt emptier. He unpacked his bag, washed the cup he had used in Layla's kitchen, and placed the book she had asked him to bring back on the shelf beside the poetry collection. He stood in the living room for a while, not quite sure what to do with the evening.

He had always been accustomed to solitude. He liked quiet rooms and uninterrupted work. He had spent years defending the pleasure of being alone, often with good reason. Yet now he noticed that he had begun to measure the

quiet against a different standard. The apartment was not simply peaceful; it was a place where he could not turn to Layla and ask whether she wanted tea.

He made dinner and ate standing at the kitchen counter. Halfway through the meal, he reached for his phone to send her a photograph of the burnt rice he'd somehow managed to produce despite making nothing more complicated than reheated food. He stopped, remembered that he had not burnt anything, and laughed at himself.

He sent her a picture of the empty kitchen instead.

The flat is unusually quiet. I suspect the furniture has noticed you've left.

Her reply came a few minutes later.

Tell the furniture to make itself useful.

He smiled. They exchanged a few jokes, then agreed to talk after she finished unpacking. The conversation was pleasant, but when it ended, Kareem found himself sitting at the table longer than he needed to. He had not realized how much of his ordinary day had come to include the expectation that he would tell Layla something before the day was over.

The next morning, he went to work. Hany asked how the trip had gone, and Kareem said it had been good. He did not explain that his own apartment was beginning to feel like a place shaped by someone who was no longer there. Hany was too busy complaining about the coffee machine to ask a second question.

At lunch, Kareem called his brother and asked whether he could visit on Friday. His brother sounded surprised but pleased. “Of course. Bring yourself.”

“I usually do.”

“Not always.”

Kareem accepted the correction without arguing. He knew that he had used busyness as a reason to put off visits, not because work left him no time but because he had allowed the decision to remain vague. He did not want his life in Cairo to become something he merely waited through until he could go to Alexandria again.

On Friday, he went to his brother's house. His niece ran to meet him, and his sister-in-law asked whether he would stay for dinner. He helped his brother with a small repair, read a story to the little girl, and listened while the adults discussed a holiday they were considering. The evening was ordinary and comfortable. It reminded him that his life had people in it who loved him, even when he was not particularly good at making himself available to them.

When he returned home, Layla had sent a message asking whether his visit had gone well. He told her about the dinner, his niece's new favorite book, and the holiday plan. She asked whether he had agreed to go. He said he had not decided yet, then paused and added, *I think I want to. I'll tell them tomorrow.*

She replied: *That's good. You should go if you want to.*

He stared at the message for a moment, pleased that she had encouraged him to build a life that did not revolve around her. He also felt a small, irrational sadness at the reminder that she would not be there. He could have hidden the feeling, but he was beginning to recognize that honesty did not require him to turn every sadness into a problem.

I will. And I'll miss you while I'm there, he wrote.

Layla sent a heart, then: *You can miss me and still have a good time.*

He smiled at the screen. It was the kind of sentence he would have struggled to say to himself. He put the phone down and went to wash the dishes, thinking that perhaps the work of the coming year would be less about learning how not to miss her and more about learning how to miss her without treating the feeling as a reason to stop living.

The first month in Alexandria was kind to them.

The first Saturday after her arrival, a colleague from the publishing house invited Layla to meet a few people for lunch. Layla almost declined. She had laundry to do, a cupboard that still contained nothing but plates, and a list of work she had promised herself she would review before Monday. More than that, she had imagined spending the afternoon talking to Kareem. Their evening call had become the most familiar part of the day, and the thought of missing it made the new city feel briefly less inviting.

Then she looked at the list on her table and recognized the old impulse: if she could keep herself busy enough, she would not have to find out what she felt when nobody needed anything from her.

She put on her coat and went.

The restaurant was small, noisy, and crowded with people who appeared to know each other well. Layla was introduced to an assistant editor, a designer, and a young writer whose first collection the publishing house had recently accepted. They talked about books, rent, the city's changing weather, and which neighborhoods had the most reliable internet. Nobody asked Layla to solve a problem. Nobody seemed to expect her to remember anything on their behalf. They were curious about her work and interested in what she thought.

At one point, the designer asked why she had come to Alexandria.

“For the fellowship,” Layla said.

“I mean, apart from the job. What made you want to come here?”

Layla considered the question. She could have explained the responsibility she carried at home, her mother's worries, the pressure of being the person everyone called first. Instead, she heard herself say, “I wanted to find out what I could do if I gave myself a chance to focus on work I care about.”

The designer nodded, as though this were a perfectly ordinary reason to move to another city.

“Good,” she said. “I hope you get to do that.”

Layla carried the sentence home with her.

She walked along the sea before returning to the apartment, stopping once to watch a group of children trying to fly a kite in a wind that seemed determined to carry it in the wrong direction. The kite rose, dropped, and rose again. The children ran after it, shouting advice to one another, laughing when their efforts failed. Layla stood watching until one of them managed to guide it higher into the air.

She thought of Kareem. She wanted to tell him about the lunch, the conversation, the kite. She wanted him to know that the city was beginning to give her things she had not expected to find. At the same time, she was aware that this was the first afternoon she had enjoyed without arranging it around their call or the fear of missing him.

The realization made her feel guilty for a moment.

Then she corrected herself. Enjoying her life was not evidence that she loved him less. It was the reason she had come.

That evening, she called Kareem and told him about the lunch. He listened with interest, asked what the other editors were like, and laughed at the story about the kite. She could hear that he was glad she was meeting people.

“I'm happy you're finding your place there,” he said.

She leaned back against the sofa. “I think I am.”

“Good.”

She wanted to tell him that she had missed him during the afternoon and had also enjoyed being away from the apartment, that both feelings had existed together without cancelling each other out. She worried that he might hear the

first half as a promise that nothing was changing, or the second as a warning that she was becoming less attached to him. She decided to say the simplest thing.

“I had a good day.”

“I'm glad.”

After the call, she opened the empty notebook Hany had given her and wrote a few lines about the lunch, the kite, and the way the city had felt less like a place she was borrowing and more like a place she could belong. She did not write about missing Kareem. That feeling was already part of her; she did not need to record it every time it appeared.

She closed the notebook, made tea, and sat on the balcony until the air grew cool.

Layla learned the tram schedule, found a bakery where the owner remembered her order, and began to recognize the voices of the people who worked in the shops near her apartment. She liked the publishing house. Salwa trusted her with meaningful work, and the other editors treated her as a colleague rather than a visitor. When she disagreed with a decision, people listened. When she made a mistake, they corrected it without making her feel that one mistake had erased everything she knew.

She was busy in the way she had wanted to be busy: challenged, curious, and occasionally overwhelmed. She came home tired, made tea, and sometimes sat on the balcony with a book until the sky darkened over the buildings.

Kareem called most evenings. Sometimes they spoke for an hour; sometimes they exchanged ten minutes of tired conversation before one of them had to sleep. He told her about manuscripts, Hany's campaign to replace the office coffee machine, and his efforts to visit his brother more often. She told him about the people she was meeting, the stories she was editing, and the city that was slowly becoming familiar.

They shared photographs of small things. Layla sent him a picture of the sea on a windy morning. Kareem sent her a photograph of a sentence he had found in a novel and thought she would like. She sent him a picture of the lamp beside her bed, its stained shade casting a warm circle across the wall. He replied that he was pleased it had found a purpose.

For a while, the distance felt manageable.

During the second week, they discovered that even a good routine could become another thing to maintain.

They had agreed to call each evening when possible, but neither had defined what “when possible” meant. At first, it seemed obvious. They called after work, exchanged the day's news, and said goodnight when one of them became too tired to continue. The calls felt generous because they were new. Each conversation was proof that the distance had not taken away the easy pleasure of hearing the other person's voice.

The first real test arrived on a Sunday afternoon, when Nadia called while Layla was unpacking the last of her kitchen things. A document had gone missing from Youssef's application folder, and her mother had spent the morning searching the apartment. She believed Layla might have taken a copy to scan before leaving Cairo.

"I can look when I get home," Layla said, putting a stack of plates into the cupboard.

"But the deadline is tomorrow."

"I know, Mama. I'll check my files."

"You always keep these things organized. I don't understand how it could have disappeared."

Layla looked at the cupboard, then at the boxes stacked in the corner. She could feel the old reflex taking hold: leave what she was doing, call Youssef, search the documents, tell her mother not to worry, and stay on the phone until everyone felt calmer. It would be easier than having the same conversation twice.

But she had promised herself that the move would mean something more than a new address. She could help her brother without turning every problem into an immediate emergency she was expected to manage from another city.

"I'll check my files tonight," she said. "If I have a copy, I'll send it. If I don't, you and Youssef will need to contact the office tomorrow and ask what they can do."

There was a silence on the other end.

"You can't call them? You know how these things work."

"I do. But Youssef can call them, too. I'll help him prepare what to say if he needs it."

Her mother sighed. "You've changed since you've gone away."

Layla felt the words as a small accusation, even though Nadia's voice was more sad than angry. She almost apologized. Instead, she took a breath.

"I hope I have, Mama. I'm still here. I just can't do everything from here as if I haven't left."

Her mother did not respond immediately. Then she said, "All right. Check your files."

They ended the call without the usual reassuring exchange. Layla stood in the kitchen, feeling guilty and relieved in equal measure. She wanted to call Nadia back and soften the conversation. She wanted to explain that the boundary did not mean she loved her family less. But she knew she could not make every change feel painless to the people around her.

That evening, she found the document in an old email attachment and forwarded it to Youssef. She added a note explaining where it was and suggested that he save a copy in a separate folder. He replied with a thank-you and a joke about how he would never survive without her.

She smiled at the message. Then she wrote back: *You'd survive. You'd just have to look for things yourself sometimes.*

Later, she told Kareem about the call. She expected him to reassure her that she had been right. Instead, he asked, "How did it feel to say no?"

She considered the question. "Like I was being selfish. Then like I could breathe. Then selfish again."

He laughed softly. "That sounds exhausting."

"It was."

"Do you want my opinion?"

She smiled. "Not yet. I think I need you to understand why it was difficult first."

He went quiet for a moment, taking the instruction seriously.

"You were worried she'd think you were abandoning them," he said. "And you were worried that if you didn't help, something would go wrong and you'd have to live with it."

Layla felt herself relax.

"Yes. Exactly."

He did not tell her what to do. He did not explain her family to her. He simply stayed with the feeling until it no longer seemed unreasonable to have had it.

When they said goodnight, Layla was aware of the distance between their apartments, but she was also aware of something else: for the first time since leaving Cairo, she had made a choice for herself and allowed it to remain uncomfortable without immediately trying to undo it.

Then ordinary life began filling the spaces around them.

One evening, Kareem called while Layla was at the grocery shop. She answered with her phone held between her shoulder and ear, trying to compare two brands of olive oil while a man behind her grew impatient. Kareem told her about a manuscript whose author had insisted that a character's silence should be printed as a full page of blank space. Layla laughed, then asked him to repeat the explanation because the cashier had spoken over him.

“You don't have to talk to me while you're shopping,” he said.

“I want to talk to you.”

“Then perhaps finish shopping first.”

She smiled. “You're allowed to want my attention, you know.”

He went quiet for a moment. “I do want it.”

“I know. I'm trying to give you some of it.”

The exchange was so ordinary that neither treated it as a lesson. But later, Kareem thought about the sentence. He had been ready to end the call rather than admit that he wanted her to stay on the line. Layla had noticed, and she had offered him a way to ask without making his need sound unreasonable.

Another evening, Layla was late returning from work because she and Salwa had stayed to review a manuscript. She messaged Kareem as soon as she realized the time, explaining that she would call when she got home. He replied that she should take her time and eat something before calling. When she finally rang, he was halfway through dinner.

“Have you eaten?” he asked.

“Yes.”

“Properly?”

She laughed. “My mother has been speaking to you.”

“Several sources have expressed concern.”

They talked for twenty minutes, and when Layla said she was tired, Kareem did not try to stretch the conversation. He told her goodnight and let her go. She appreciated that he had not treated the shorter call as a failure.

They were learning to make room for days that did not fit the plan.

On Sunday, Layla called while Kareem was at his brother's house. His niece had been insisting that he build a tower with her, and he had stepped into the

hallway to answer. Layla could hear the child shouting for him in the background.

“Go back,” she said. “I'll call later.”

“I can talk now.”

“I know. But I don't want you to spend the call worrying that you're missing something.”

He smiled. “I'm building a tower, not negotiating a peace treaty.”

“You sound like a man who has never met a four-year-old with a strong vision.”

He laughed. “That's fair.”

He returned to the living room, and Layla went back to her book. Later that night, they called again. Kareem told her that the tower had collapsed four times, and Layla said the giraffe's housing requirements had become unreasonable. They laughed until she had to put the phone down.

The distance, for a while, seemed to be something they could negotiate through kindness and small adjustments. They did not have to choose between being present for the person on the phone and being present for the person in the room. They could explain, postpone, and return.

That was what made the next missed call so difficult. It did not happen because they had failed to make a plan. They had made one. It happened because Kareem, tired and distracted, forgot to tell Layla that the plan had changed. She waited, and he remembered her only after the evening had already moved on.

The mistake was ordinary. Its meaning was not.

They had been learning that love could travel through messages and calls. They had not yet learned how easily the same channels could carry uncertainty when one person went quiet and the other had no way to read the silence except through the history they brought to it.

Then life began to interfere with the plan, as life always did.

One Thursday, Layla had a difficult meeting with Salwa. Her editorial notes had been too cautious in places, and Salwa suggested that she needed to be more confident in defending her decisions. The criticism was fair, which made it harder to dismiss. Layla spent the afternoon reviewing the manuscript, wondering whether she had been too cautious or too confident, whether she had earned the trust she had been given.

She wanted to tell Kareem. She sent a message asking whether they could talk properly that evening. He agreed to call at nine.

At half past six, Kareem's brother called to ask for help with his daughter. His wife had been kept late at work, and he needed someone to stay with the little girl for a while. Kareem agreed. He meant to message Layla when he arrived, but his niece wanted a story, then another one, and the evening ran late. When he finally looked at his phone, he was tired and worried that a serious conversation would become a struggle to stay awake.

He sent a short message asking to talk the following day.

Layla had waited. She knew people got busy, and she knew Kareem had responsibilities. Still, she had asked for the call because she needed it. She felt foolish for waiting and more foolish for being disappointed. When he asked whether she was upset, she said she was tired and they could speak tomorrow.

The next morning, they talked. Kareem apologized and explained what had happened. Layla told him she did not want him to stop helping his family. She did not want to compete with them. She wanted him to remember her before everything else was finished.

“I don't think you decided I wasn't important,” she said. “I think you stopped thinking about the fact that I was waiting.”

The distinction stayed with him. He understood that he had not intended to hurt her. He also understood that intention had not prevented the hurt. He had assumed she would understand and had left her to fill the silence with guesses.

They talked it through. Kareem promised to communicate sooner when plans changed. Layla promised to tell him when she needed something without waiting until she was already hurt. They ended the call with affection, but the conversation left an uneasiness neither could quite name.

A few weeks later, Kareem came to Alexandria for a weekend. Layla was delighted to see him and showed him the routes she had learned, the bookshop she liked, and the small restaurant where the owner had begun recognizing her. He was proud of her, and he was also unsettled by how completely her new life seemed to belong to her.

On Saturday morning, she had a work presentation. Kareem came to the publishing house to watch. Layla led the discussion confidently, defended her editorial choices, and answered questions from the authors. He watched her with genuine admiration. He also felt like a visitor in a world he did not share.

The presentation ran late. Afterwards, Layla spent longer than expected speaking with an author and Salwa. Kareem waited, telling himself that he had come to support her and that the work mattered. When she finally joined him, she apologized for the delay and thanked him for waiting. He told her it was fine.

He did not tell her that he had felt left out, or that he had spent part of the morning wondering where he belonged in the life she was building. He worried that his feelings would sound selfish, that telling her would turn her success into something she had to manage for him. He convinced himself that he was being considerate by keeping quiet.

That evening, Layla apologized again for keeping him waiting. He told her there was nothing to apologize for. She accepted the answer, believing that he meant it.

On the train back to Cairo, Kareem knew he had left something unsaid. He promised himself he would explain it later. The promise comforted him because it allowed him to postpone the discomfort without admitting that he was postponing it.

The following week, Layla was offered the possibility of a permanent role after the fellowship. It was only a possibility; funding had not been confirmed, and no decision was required yet. But she was excited. For the first time, she could imagine staying in Alexandria beyond the year she had originally planned.

She told Kareem on their evening call. He congratulated her and asked about the work. Then she asked whether he would want her to return to Cairo when the fellowship ended.

He wanted her back. He wanted them to share a city, to see each other without planning weeks ahead, to wake up beside her and hear about her day while they walked home together. He also wanted her to feel free to choose a future that was right for her. He was afraid of expressing his desire as a pressure she might feel obliged to satisfy.

So he talked about contingencies. If the position became permanent, she would have to consider it. If not, they would discuss what came next. They did not need to decide anything yet.

Layla listened and understood that he was trying to be fair. But she had not asked him to choose for her. She had asked whether he could imagine a future with her.

Later that evening, Kareem sent a message saying that, of course, he wanted her to return to Cairo, that he wanted them to live in the same city, and that he

wanted to find a way to make their lives fit together. He admitted that he did not know how to do it yet. Layla thanked him. She was relieved to hear the truth, but she also felt the exhaustion of having to ask for it.

The months continued. Layla grew more confident at work and began to develop relationships in Alexandria. Kareem made an effort to visit his brother, called his father more often, and discovered that his own life could grow while hers did. They were both changing in ways they had wanted.

The difficulty was not that their love had diminished. It was that they were learning to share two lives without the ordinary routines that had once made the relationship feel effortless. A call could be missed. A plan could be forgotten. A feeling could be postponed until it seemed too small to mention, then become a larger thing because it had remained unspoken.

They learned to recognize some of these moments. They did not always recognize them in time.

By the end of the first three months, the distance had become ordinary enough that they stopped talking about it every day. They made plans for visits, exchanged news, and continued to say they loved each other. The affection was real. The effort was real, too.

But sometimes, when a call ended, one of them would sit with the phone in hand and feel that the conversation had missed something important. Neither knew exactly how to bring that missing thing into the open without making it sound like an accusation.

They told themselves they were learning.

They were.

They had not yet learned that knowing a pattern is not the same as changing it, and that a small hurt can be survived many times without ever truly being repaired.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Space Between Goodnights

“Distance does not create every silence; sometimes it gives old silences somewhere to hide.”

By winter, Layla could tell which tram was approaching before she could see it.

She had learned the city's rhythms: the bakery's early rush, the slow hour after lunch, the sudden crowds near the waterfront when the weather cleared. She had learned to work in a room where no one knew what she had been like at sixteen, and to go home without feeling that somebody would need her before she had taken off her coat.

It was a good life. Not a perfect one, but a life she had chosen.

In December, Layla was invited to a small dinner at Salwa's apartment. It was not a formal work event, just a few editors and two writers gathered around a table that had not been intended to hold so many dishes. The conversation moved between books, the peculiarities of the publishing industry, and the things people did when they were too tired to be interesting. Someone brought a cake that leaned to one side. Someone else insisted on making coffee for everyone, then forgot to ask how they took it.

Layla laughed more than she expected to. Nobody at the table knew her as the eldest daughter, the person who remembered appointments, or the one who could be trusted to settle a family problem. They knew her as the editor who had argued successfully for the order of a collection, who noticed the emotional logic of a story, and who had a habit of defending a sentence if she believed it was doing something important.

After dinner, a colleague named Dalia walked her partway home. They talked about the collection and the possibility of working together on another project. Dalia was funny, slightly chaotic, and entirely comfortable admitting that she had no idea what she was doing half the time. Layla found the honesty refreshing. She had spent years around people who asked for help only after pretending they did not need it. Dalia asked for advice, accepted it, and then admitted when she had chosen to do something else.

When Layla returned to the apartment, she felt the particular satisfaction of having spent an evening without carrying anyone else's day. She made tea and called Kareem.

He answered from his apartment in Cairo, where a stack of papers sat beside his dinner and the television was playing to an empty room.

“How was your evening?” he asked.

She told him about the dinner, the cake, the conversation with Dalia, and the possibility of a new project. She could hear that he was pleased for her. He asked

what the project involved and whether it would give her a chance to work more closely with the authors.

“I think it might,” she said. “I'm excited.”

“Good.” He paused. “I'm glad you're finding people there.”

She heard the care in the sentence and also a small uncertainty she could not quite name. She wanted to tell him that finding people did not mean she was replacing him. But she had not been accused of anything, and she did not want to turn his simple question into a reassurance he had not asked for.

Instead, she said, “I think I'm beginning to feel at home.”

He was quiet for a moment. “I'm glad.”

She wished he had said more. She wished she knew what more would have sounded like. Then she remembered that she had spent years trying to predict the needs of people who had not asked her to predict them. She would not do that here. If Kareem wanted to tell her how he felt, he could. If she needed something, she could ask.

They talked about the week ahead and ended the call with affection. Layla went to bed feeling pleased with the life she was building, and slightly unsettled by the fact that happiness had begun to make the distance more visible. There were things she wanted to share with Kareem because he was the person she loved. There were also things that belonged to the days she lived without him, and she was learning that the two categories did not have to compete.

In Cairo, Kareem sat for a while after the call ended. He was glad Layla was making friends. He was glad her work was going well. He was glad she had a life that offered her more than the familiar responsibilities she had carried for so long.

He was also afraid that one day she might stop needing the connection between them.

He recognized the thought as unfair. He knew she had never asked him to be necessary to her happiness. She had asked him to be present in it. Yet the distinction was still difficult for him. He had spent much of his life measuring affection by the practical ways in which people depended on one another, and now he was learning to love someone whose life was becoming more complete in his absence.

He wanted to tell her he was proud of her. He had told her that already. He wanted to tell her he was frightened, too. He did not know whether saying so

would make her feel responsible for his loneliness or simply allow her to understand him. He decided he would find a way to say it when he knew how.

The decision made him feel temporarily better.

It was another form of waiting.

The following Sunday, Dalia invited Layla to a public reading at a small bookstore near the waterfront. Layla nearly declined. She had a manuscript to review, laundry to do, and a list of practical tasks that had quietly grown while she was busy adjusting to the city. She told Dalia she might be too tired.

“Then come tired,” Dalia said. “You can sit in the back and look disapproving. It will improve the atmosphere.”

Layla laughed and agreed.

The bookstore was crowded when she arrived. Folding chairs had been arranged between the shelves, and several people stood near the door holding paper cups of tea. Dalia waved her over and made room on a bench beside a woman who was arguing that a novel's ending was only ambiguous because the author had not decided what it meant.

Layla listened, then found herself joining the discussion. She spoke about the difference between an ending that refuses certainty and one that merely avoids a decision. The woman challenged her, and Layla enjoyed the disagreement more than she expected. Nobody required her to smooth it over. They argued, laughed, and moved on to another question.

Afterward, the group went for tea. Dalia introduced her to two writers who lived nearby, and the conversation drifted through books, rent, bad landlords, and the difficulty of making friends as an adult. One of the writers admitted that she sometimes went an entire weekend without speaking to anyone outside work. Dalia said she had once held a three-minute conversation with a cashier because she was desperate to hear another human voice.

Layla laughed so hard she nearly spilled her tea.

On the walk home, she realized she had not thought about Kareem for most of the evening. The realization brought a brief, guilty sting, as though enjoying herself without him were a small betrayal. Then she remembered his words beside the sea: he wanted her to find things that made her happy. He had not asked her to keep a part of every good experience untouched until she could report it to him.

She did call him when she reached the apartment. She wanted to tell him about the reading, the argument, and Dalia's confession about the cashier. But

she told him because she wanted to share the story, not because she needed to prove that the evening had not changed her feelings.

He listened and laughed at the right places. When she finished, he said, “It sounds like you had a good time.”

“I did.”

“I'm glad.”

She heard something warm in his voice and something more difficult beneath it, though she could not tell whether it was there or whether she was now listening for it. She wanted to reassure him that she had not forgotten him. She wanted him to ask for that reassurance if he needed it, rather than leaving her to guess.

“How was your Sunday?” she asked.

He told her about visiting his brother, helping his niece with a puzzle, and making a meal that was edible but not worth repeating. She laughed, asked questions, and pictured the room as he described it. The distance remained real, but for a little while it did not feel like a wall. It felt like two people standing in different rooms and opening the same window.

When they ended the call, Layla sat beside the balcony door and thought about how much she wanted their relationship to survive the year. She also recognized that her life was becoming fuller in ways she could not have predicted. She was making friends, learning new streets, and beginning to take pleasure in things without immediately calculating how they would affect everyone else.

She did not want to surrender that growth to preserve the shape of the relationship. She wanted Kareem to know the person she was becoming. She wanted to know the person he was becoming, too.

For now, she believed that was possible.

Kareem came to visit whenever he could. Sometimes he stayed a full weekend; sometimes a deadline or a family obligation made the trip shorter. They made the most of the hours, visiting bookshops, eating at small restaurants, and walking along the sea until the wind pushed them indoors. When he was there, Layla could almost forget that their relationship now required a calendar.

When he left, she felt the difference in the apartment.

At first, she kept his cups on the kitchen shelf and his book beside the bed. Later, she began putting things away more quickly, not because she wanted to

erase the evidence of his visit but because she was learning that she could miss him without leaving every room arranged around the fact that he was gone.

Their calls became a rhythm, too. They spoke most evenings, exchanged messages through the day, and tried to arrange a longer conversation on Sundays. The rhythm helped. It gave them a place to meet when they could not share a room.

But the rhythm also made it possible to confuse routine with presence.

Some nights, Kareem called while answering emails. Some nights, Layla spoke while finishing notes for work. They were both tired, and they both wanted to believe that the call itself was proof that they were making an effort. They said goodnight with affection, then hung up feeling that there had been something else they might have said.

Sometimes they remembered to return to it the following day.

Sometimes they did not.

One Thursday, Kareem called while walking home from work. Layla had had a difficult meeting, and she told him about a disagreement with an author who had dismissed her suggestions without reading them carefully.

“He said I was trying to change the way he writes,” she told him. “Which is interesting, because I was trying to help him publish a book that people might want to read.”

Kareem laughed. “An unreasonable ambition.”

“Apparently.”

She expected him to ask how the meeting had affected her. Instead, his phone beeped with a message from his supervisor, and he paused to read it. He said something about a deadline, then apologized for being distracted.

“It’s okay,” Layla said.

He returned to the conversation, but she had already lost the thread of what she had been trying to say. She summarized the rest, and he told her she should not let the author's opinion determine how she felt about her work.

She knew he meant to help. She also knew that she had not called him because she needed an assessment of the author's judgment. She wanted him to understand how it felt to sit in a room and be treated as though her work did not deserve consideration.

She did not say so.

They ended the call ten minutes later. Kareem went home believing he had been supportive. Layla sat at her kitchen table, feeling strangely alone after having spoken to someone she loved for nearly half an hour.

The next morning, she sent him a message explaining what she had wanted from the conversation. He apologized and asked whether they could talk that evening. They did, and the conversation went better. Layla told him she sometimes needed him to listen before offering a solution. Kareem told her that he sometimes worried he would make things worse by saying the wrong thing, so he hurried toward an answer he could defend.

They understood each other a little better.

They did not stop making the mistake.

The first time Kareem visited Alexandria after the move, he arrived with two books and an expectation that the weekend would feel like Cairo in a different place. He imagined they would walk, eat, talk, and recover the ordinary closeness that distance had interrupted. For the first few hours, it seemed possible. Layla met him at the station and took his hand. They ate at a restaurant she liked, and she showed him the streets she had begun to recognize.

But as the evening went on, he noticed that she checked her phone more often than she used to. Work messages arrived. Salwa wanted a file. A colleague had asked whether Layla could review a paragraph before Monday. Layla answered quickly, apologizing each time, and then returned to the conversation.

Kareem told himself not to mind. She had responsibilities. She was good at her work. He had encouraged her to take the fellowship because he wanted her life to grow.

Later, when they were sitting on the balcony, Layla noticed his quietness.

“Are you tired?” she asked.

“A little.”

“Do you want to go to bed?”

He almost said yes. Instead, he said, “I think I expected the weekend to feel more like it used to.”

She looked at him carefully. “What does that mean?”

He struggled to explain. He did not want her to feel guilty for working. He did not want to suggest she should ignore the people who depended on her professionally. He also did not want to pretend that he had come all this way simply to sit beside her while she answered emails.

“I think I miss the part where we don't have to arrange being together,” he said. “I miss being able to see you without making a plan.”

Her face softened. “I miss that, too.”

“I'm not asking you to do anything differently.”

“I know.”

But they both knew that was not entirely true. He wanted something to change, even if he could not yet say what. She wanted to make room for him, but she did not want to feel that every new responsibility in her life required proof that she still loved him.

They sat beside each other until the air grew cold. Layla put her phone away, then reached for his hand. It was a small gesture, but it mattered. Kareem felt the distance between what he wanted and what he had been given narrow for a while.

The next morning, they went for a walk and spoke more openly. Layla admitted she sometimes felt as though she had to make every visit perfect because the time was limited. Kareem admitted he sometimes treated each visit as evidence of whether he still had a place in her life. They laughed at the absurdity of placing so much pressure on a weekend.

“Maybe we need to stop treating visits like exams,” Layla said.

“Then how will I know whether I've passed?”

“You could try being here.”

He smiled. “I can do that.”

He meant it. He would remember the conversation, and for the rest of the visit he was more present. They ate lunch, explored a bookshop, and spent the evening talking about nothing important. When he left, Layla held his hand at the station and told him she was glad he had come.

He returned to Cairo believing they had learned something useful. They had. But neither yet understood how easily a difficult feeling could return when the circumstances changed again. In Cairo, the hours after work had once been shaped around the possibility of seeing Layla. He had taken the long route home because she was walking the same way, stopped at a café because she had suggested it, or delayed dinner because he wanted to tell her something in person. Without those small encounters, he had to decide what to do with the hours himself.

At first, he filled them with work. He came home, opened his laptop, and told himself that clearing the inbox would make the next day easier. Some nights he read until midnight. Other nights he sat in front of the television without following the program. The calls with Layla gave the evenings a center, but he sometimes reached them too tired to be fully present.

He began to notice the pattern. He would spend the evening avoiding his own thoughts, then call Layla and try to become attentive in the space of a few minutes. When she spoke about a difficult day, he wanted to help quickly because he felt guilty about how little energy he had left. When she asked how he was, he said he was fine because he had not yet worked out what he felt.

He told himself it was temporary, a matter of adjusting to the new routine. But the routine was becoming familiar, and he knew that if he did not change it, it would become the shape of their relationship.

In January, Kareem's father had a minor medical scare. It was not dangerous, but it frightened Hala, who called Kareem several times while he was at work. He left early, drove his father to a clinic, and spent the evening at his parents' house.

At the clinic, Mahmoud answered the doctor's questions with the same impatience he used when someone asked him to repeat a sentence he believed had already been understood. The symptoms had not indicated anything serious, but the doctor wanted follow-up tests and advised him to rest. Hala listened closely, asking about medication and warning signs. Kareem stood beside the examination table, holding his father's jacket and feeling younger than he was.

On the drive home, Mahmoud complained about the waiting time. Kareem explained that the doctor had been thorough. His father said he was sure the tests would show nothing. Then he asked whether Kareem could take him back next week if another appointment was necessary.

“Of course,” Kareem said.

The answer came automatically. He did not mind taking his father to the clinic. He was worried about him, and he would do what was needed. What unsettled him was how quickly concern had turned into a task and how easily he had accepted the task without finding a way to say that he had been frightened.

At the family home, Hala put the kettle on and began describing the possible complications the doctor had mentioned. Kareem listened, checked the medication instructions, and wrote the follow-up date on a piece of paper for his mother. Mahmoud sat in his armchair, irritated that the appointment had taken up most of the afternoon.

“I'm fine,” his father said for the third time.

“I know,” Kareem replied, though he was not sure what he meant by it.

He wanted his father to acknowledge that Kareem had been worried. He wanted him to ask whether the day had frightened him, whether he was tired, whether he needed anything. Instead, Mahmoud asked if Kareem could look at the car insurance the next time he visited.

Kareem felt irritation move through him, then shame for feeling irritated. His father had done nothing malicious. He had spent the day being examined by a doctor and was likely tired and anxious in his own way. Yet Kareem knew how familiar the exchange was: he did something practical, the family accepted the help, and the emotional part of the experience remained unspoken.

He sat at the table while Hala went to answer a call. Mahmoud was looking at the television, although the volume was low enough that neither of them could have followed the commentary.

“Baba,” Kareem began.

His father turned.

Kareem wanted to say, *I was worried about you today.* He wanted to say, *It frightened me to see you there, and I don't know why I can't tell you that without feeling foolish.* The words were clear inside his head. He could almost hear how they would sound.

Instead, he asked, “Do you want some more tea?”

Mahmoud nodded. “Please.”

Kareem stood and went to the kitchen.

On the drive back to his apartment, he felt angry with himself. He had wanted to be honest, and he had chosen the familiar task instead. He had told himself that the moment was not right, that his father was tired, that the conversation could happen another time. Each reason was reasonable on its own. Together, they made it almost impossible for anything to change.

When he finally remembered Layla's call, it was late. He knew he should tell her what had happened and explain that he had missed their plan. But he was exhausted, ashamed of his silence with his father, and reluctant to add another difficult conversation to an evening that already felt too full.

He sent the short message and told himself he would explain properly the next day. He was worried and irritated, and the old family dynamics returned with a force he had not expected. His mother asked him to call relatives, his father

insisted he was fine, and everyone behaved as though the best way to manage fear was to turn it into errands.

Kareem forgot to tell Layla that he would miss their call.

He did not remember until after eleven, when he was sitting in his car outside his apartment. He sent a message explaining what had happened. Layla replied that she was glad his father was all right, then asked whether Kareem himself was okay.

He wrote, *I'm fine. Just tired.*

He was not fine. He was frightened by how quickly his family could return him to the role of the quiet son who did what was needed and spoke about nothing else. He was angry that his father had barely acknowledged his help, ashamed of being angry, and exhausted by the effort of pretending that none of it mattered.

The next morning, Kareem called his brother before work. He did not have a practical reason. The realization that he wanted to talk about his father made him feel oddly self-conscious, and for a moment he considered waiting until his brother called him about something else.

His brother answered from the car.

"Everything all right?"

"Yes. I just wanted to ask how Baba was this morning."

"He's fine. Complaining about the medicine, which I suppose means he's feeling better."

Kareem smiled faintly. "Good."

There was a pause. His brother had known him too long not to hear that something else had brought the call.

"What's wrong?"

Kareem looked at the empty mug on his desk. "I was frightened yesterday. At the clinic. I don't think I knew how frightened I was until I got home."

His brother was quiet.

"Me too," he said eventually. "I didn't tell you because Mama was already upset, and Baba kept insisting that everyone was making a fuss. I thought if I stayed calm, it would help."

Kareem leaned back in his chair. "That's what I thought."

"We do that a lot."

The words were not accusatory. They sounded like an observation both men had made separately and had not yet compared.

His brother continued, "When we were younger, I thought Baba didn't worry because he never said he was worried. Then I got married and had a child, and I realized I can be terrified about something and still spend the whole day asking practical questions. I don't know if that's how he feels. I just know that not saying it doesn't mean the feeling isn't there."

Kareem listened. He thought about all the years he had interpreted his father's silence as proof that nothing emotional was happening, and all the years he had copied the same silence while hoping someone would see what he was trying not to reveal.

"I wish we could talk to him about things," Kareem said.

"Maybe we can. But I don't think we can make him become someone he hasn't learned how to be. We can try to speak differently ourselves."

Kareem looked down at his hands.

"I'm trying," he said.

His brother laughed gently. "I know. I can hear it."

They spoke for a few more minutes, mostly about practical matters. Before hanging up, his brother told him to come over on Friday and promised that his daughter had been asking about him. Kareem agreed, then stayed on the line for one extra second, as though he were learning not to rush away from a conversation simply because its important part had ended.

When Layla called that evening, he almost told her about the conversation with his brother before she had even asked how his day had been. He was proud that he had made the call; he was also afraid that saying so would make the effort sound smaller than it had felt.

He did tell her eventually. She listened and said, "That sounds like a good conversation."

"It was," he said. "I think I needed it."

She did not praise him for being brave or turn it into a lesson. She simply asked whether he wanted to tell her more. For once, he said yes without first checking whether he could explain the feeling perfectly.

But he did not know how to tell Layla.

The following evening, Layla called while Kareem was putting away the dishes from dinner. He had been home for less than half an hour, and the day's

exhaustion sat heavily in his shoulders. His father's appointment had gone well enough: the doctor had adjusted a medication, recommended another test, and told Mahmoud to return if the symptoms continued. Nothing catastrophic had happened. No one had said anything that could be repeated as a clear explanation of what was wrong.

“How is your father feeling?” Layla asked.

“Fine, I think. The doctor wants him to go back next week.”

“Are you worried?”

Kareem opened the cupboard and stared at the row of glasses. He had spent the afternoon sitting beside his father in a waiting room, watching him answer the doctor's questions with the same economical words he used at home. Kareem had filled out a form, collected the prescription, and asked whether the medication might have side effects. Mahmoud had thanked him in the car and then turned on the radio. They had driven home listening to a discussion about football.

He had wanted his father to say something else. He had wanted him to acknowledge that the afternoon had frightened him, or ask Kareem how he had felt sitting there, or simply look at him as though they had shared something beyond an errand.

Instead, Kareem had taken his father home and left with the familiar sense that he had done something useful without becoming any closer to him.

“Not really,” he said.

Layla was quiet. “You sound tired.”

“I am.”

“Do you want to tell me about it?”

He could hear the care in her voice. He knew that she was not asking him to make the conversation profound. She was offering him a place to put down some of what he had been carrying.

But he did not know how to begin. He did not want to say that his father had made him feel like a stranger. The words sounded cruel, and Mahmoud had not been cruel. He had simply been himself, the way he had always been. Kareem could not work out how to explain that an absence could hurt without anyone deliberately creating it.

“There's nothing much to tell,” he said. “The appointment went fine.”

Layla took a breath. “I wasn't asking whether the appointment went well. I was asking how you feel.”

He looked at the kitchen counter. The prescription was still in his jacket pocket. He had forgotten to take it out.

“I don't know,” he said, then immediately regretted it. He could hear how often he used the phrase, how easily it could become a wall rather than an honest answer. “I don't know how to explain it tonight.”

“Okay,” she said. “You don't have to explain it all tonight.”

Relief moved through him. He should have thanked her and told her that he would come back to the conversation when he could. Instead, he let the relief do the talking.

“I'm fine,” he added.

There was a pause long enough for him to realize that he had contradicted himself.

Layla heard it, too. She did not argue. She wanted him to understand that she was willing to wait, but she could not make him speak if he chose to close the door. She had learned that pressing harder could turn his uncertainty into withdrawal, and she was trying not to make honesty feel like a demand he had to satisfy immediately.

“All right,” she said. “I'm glad the appointment went well. If you want to talk about the rest later, tell me.”

“I will.”

They spoke about her work for a while, then about the train ticket for his next visit. Their voices became lighter, the conversation returning to familiar ground. When they said goodnight, Kareem felt relieved that they had avoided an argument. Layla felt sad that they had avoided the conversation she had tried to begin.

For several days, their calls remained pleasant but shallow. Layla asked about work, and Kareem asked about hers. They discussed what they would do on his next visit. They sent each other photographs and exchanged jokes. They remained affectionate.

Underneath, both were waiting for the other to notice that something had changed. Layla wanted Kareem to tell her what he was carrying, because she could not help him if she did not know. Kareem wanted Layla to ask again, because the first question had not felt safe enough to answer. Each thought the other person understood more than they did.

The February weekend passed more quickly than either of them wanted. Layla had come to Cairo for the wedding, but she had also wanted to see Kareem's family and spend time in the city where their relationship had begun. On Saturday afternoon, they went to his brother's house for lunch. His niece had grown more talkative since Layla's last visit and had developed a habit of announcing everyone's responsibilities as though she were the family's smallest supervisor.

“Uncle Kareem has to build the tower,” she declared, pointing at a collection of wooden blocks. “Layla has to help. Mama has to watch.”

His sister-in-law laughed. “At least someone understands how the household should run.”

Layla sat on the floor and helped the child build a tower. Kareem joined them, following instructions that changed every few minutes. When the structure collapsed, the little girl stared at the pieces, then announced that the tower had to be bigger.

“Why?” Kareem asked.

“Because.”

“An excellent explanation.”

Layla laughed, and the child began rebuilding.

Kareem watched them from the floor. He felt pleased that Layla was here, pleased that she could move through his family without having to become responsible for it, pleased that his niece had accepted her so completely. But there was also a strange sadness in seeing the two parts of his life together. He wanted more of this, not only visits at the edges of a busy year. He wanted to come home with Layla, to share the unremarkable evenings when nothing had to be arranged in advance.

When they were alone in the kitchen later, his brother asked whether the relationship was going well.

Kareem dried a plate. “I think so.”

His brother glanced at him. “That sounds like a careful answer.”

“It is a careful situation.”

“Do you still want to build a life with her?”

Kareem stopped drying the plate.

“Yes.”

“Then don't let the distance make you both passive. You can't solve the year by waiting for it to finish.”

Kareem looked toward the living room, where Layla was helping his niece put the blocks away. “I know.”

His brother nodded. “I believe you. I'm only telling you because I've seen you wait for things to become easier before you do anything. Sometimes they don't become easier. You just get used to them.”

Kareem carried the plate to the cupboard. The advice stayed with him long after they left the house. He was trying to be present for his family, and he was trying to be present for Layla. He was also trying not to make the relationship the only place where he practiced being honest. It would have to be part of a larger change, one that affected the way he spoke to everyone he loved.

That evening, he and Layla walked through Cairo before she returned to Alexandria. They stopped near the old cinema where they had once watched a film together. The building was closed for renovations, its entrance covered with temporary boards. Layla stood looking at it.

“Do you remember the film?” she asked.

“Very clearly. You spent two hours disapproving of the main character.”

“He deserved it.”

“He was trying to make a difficult decision.”

“He was trying to avoid making one.”

Kareem smiled. “Those can look similar from the outside.”

She looked at him, and the humor gave way to something more serious. “Yes. They can.”

He knew she was thinking about them. He wanted to ask what she had meant, but he was afraid of turning the last evening of the visit into another conversation about the relationship. The feeling that they should use the time well made him hesitant to risk the mood.

Layla noticed his hesitation and looked away. She had wanted to ask whether he was thinking about their future, whether he had considered what would happen after the fellowship, whether he could imagine making a change to his own life. She did not ask, because she was tired of being the one who opened every difficult door.

They walked on. Before she returned to the hotel, they stopped outside the entrance and held hands for a moment. The goodbye was tender, and both were

grateful for it. But when Layla boarded the train the next morning, she carried the familiar feeling that they had spent another weekend together without quite reaching the thing they needed to say.

Kareem watched the train leave and told himself they would talk later in the week. He intended to. He also knew that intention had become a place he could stand without moving.

Layla felt it, too.

But she was beginning to understand that progress could be real without being permanent. The same patterns kept returning, not because either of them wanted to hurt the other, but because both knew how to behave when they were frightened and did not yet know how to do something else consistently.

Kareem withdrew, then apologized. Layla asked for clarity, then tried to make the request smaller when he struggled. He feared disappointing her, so he delayed the truth. She feared being left alone in the relationship, so she tried to make herself easier to answer.

They were not standing still.

They were moving, but sometimes in circles.

Neither was ready to call it a problem they could not solve. They loved each other. They were trying. They believed that if they continued to be patient, the distance would eventually become a skill they had mastered rather than a test they had to pass every day.

For a while, that belief carried them.

Then, in early spring, Layla received an email from Salwa asking whether she would consider staying in Alexandria after the fellowship.

The future, which had been waiting quietly at the edge of their plans, moved closer.

CHAPTER EIGHT

A Future in Pencil

“The future becomes frightening when it stops being an idea and begins asking for an answer.”

Salwa did not offer Layla a permanent job in a formal letter. She asked whether Layla would be interested in a role if funding could be secured, then explained the work she hoped to build around the collection and the publishing house's expanding list.

It was a possibility, not a promise.

The week after Salwa first mentioned the possible permanent role, Layla walked home with the idea of staying in Alexandria following her like a second shadow. She tried to imagine accepting the position and waking up in the same apartment the following year. She imagined knowing the neighborhood well enough to recommend a restaurant without checking her phone, knowing the editors well enough to disagree without rehearsing the argument, and working on books that would carry some trace of her judgment.

The image made her feel excited in a way that was almost guilty. She had assumed the fellowship would be a defined interval, an important year that would return her to Cairo with greater experience and a clearer idea of what she wanted. The possibility of staying changed the shape of the question. It was no longer only about what she would learn. It was about where she wanted her life to happen.

She called Nadia after dinner. Her mother asked about the work, Youssef's applications, and whether the apartment was still comfortable. Layla answered the questions, then explained what Salwa had said.

Nadia went quiet.

“Permanent?” she asked.

“If the funding is approved. Nothing has been offered formally.”

“But you might stay?”

“Yes. I might.”

Her mother took a breath. “I thought the plan was that you would come back after the year.”

“That was the plan when I left. I didn't know this would be possible.”

Nadia did not accuse her. That would almost have been easier. Instead, she sounded wounded by a future she had not known to expect.

“What about us?” she asked.

Layla closed her eyes. There it was—the question she had feared and anticipated. She loved her family. She missed them. She wanted to remain close

to them. But she could not make a career decision by pretending that closeness required the same address.

“You'll still be my family if I stay,” she said.

“Of course. But it won't be the same.”

“No. It won't.” Layla tried to keep her voice gentle. “I don't know what I'll decide. I just don't want to reject an opportunity before I even understand it.”

Her mother was silent for a while. Then she said, “I don't want you to reject it either.”

Layla felt relief. It was not full approval, and it did not make the uncertainty disappear. But it was an opening.

“I'll come home,” Layla said. “I'll visit. We'll work out the practical things if it becomes real.”

“I know.” Nadia's voice softened. “I just need time to get used to the idea.”

After they hung up, Layla sat by the balcony doors and looked at the street. She had always believed that taking care of her family meant anticipating the moment when they might need her. Now she was learning that she could not anticipate every reaction to a life she had not yet lived. She would have to allow people to feel what they felt without immediately arranging a solution for them.

The next day, Salwa asked whether she would be willing to take on a larger part of the collection's next stage. Layla said yes. She returned to her desk with more work than she had expected and a stronger sense that she was becoming the editor she had once only imagined. The opportunity in Alexandria was no longer an abstract promise. It was made of meetings, deadlines, decisions, and colleagues who trusted her.

That evening, she thought about telling Kareem how much the possibility of staying had begun to matter to her. She wanted to share the excitement and the uncertainty, not present a decision she had already made. But she also knew that the conversation would touch the question neither had answered: what did they want their lives to look like after the fellowship?

She called him anyway.

They discussed the work and the possibility of the position. Kareem was genuinely happy for her. When she asked what he hoped would happen, he tried to answer with the care he had learned to value. He said that he wanted her to have the career she wanted, and that he hoped they would find a way to live in the same city. He also said that he could not promise to move without knowing whether he could find work he valued in Alexandria.

Layla understood all of that. What she found difficult was how often the conversation stopped at the edge of a decision. They could describe every factor, every risk, every contingency. They could make a careful list of what they did not know. But they still struggled to say what they were willing to risk for the life they hoped to build.

After the call, Layla did not feel angry. She felt tired, and that worried her more. Anger could be discussed. Tiredness could become a kind of surrender if she let it. She wanted to keep loving Kareem without turning the relationship into a second job, one in which every uncertainty had to be identified, named, and carried to him before anything could change.

She wrote the date of Salwa's next meeting in her calendar. Beside it, she wrote: *Ask what I want before asking what everyone else can manage.* Then she closed the notebook and went to bed.

But it was a real possibility.

Layla spent the evening thinking about it. She imagined the next year in Alexandria, the projects she might develop, the authors she could work with, and the work she might eventually lead. She imagined returning to Cairo at the end of the fellowship, taking up a similar role at a larger publishing house, or staying in Alexandria and building a life she had not known she wanted when she first accepted the offer.

The following week, Salwa asked Layla to join her for coffee after work. They walked to a café near the tram line, and for the first few minutes they spoke about ordinary matters: a deadline, a manuscript that needed a new cover, and the difficulty of persuading an author to remove a paragraph that repeated the previous page almost word for word.

Then Salwa set her cup down.

“I wanted to ask how you're feeling about the fellowship.”

Layla smiled. “Good. Busy. Occasionally terrified.”

“That's a reasonable combination.” Salwa leaned back. “You've become a real part of the team. I know the possible permanent role is still uncertain, but I wanted to understand whether you would be interested if the funding comes through.”

Layla looked at the street beyond the window. The answer arrived before she could make it sound more cautious.

“Yes,” she said. “I think I would.”

Salwa nodded. “Good. I can't promise anything yet, but you should know that I would like you to be considered seriously. Your work is strong, and you bring something to the team that we need.”

Layla felt the old instinct to deflect the praise, to say that she was still learning, that other people were more experienced, that there were several editors who might be better suited to the role. She let the instinct pass.

“Thank you,” she said. “I would like to be considered.”

They talked about the role for another half hour: what it would involve, how the funding might be approved, and when a decision could be made. Nothing was guaranteed. Layla left the café with an uncertain possibility, not an offer. But the possibility had a shape now, and she could no longer pretend that Alexandria was only a temporary interruption in her life.

She walked home by the sea.

She imagined returning to Cairo at the end of the fellowship. She imagined staying in Alexandria, taking on more responsibility, building relationships with the authors she had begun to work with, and becoming the editor she had wanted to be when she first started. Neither future felt wrong. That was what frightened her. She had expected the choice to become clear once she had enough information. Instead, more information seemed to create more than one life she could want.

At home, she called Kareem. She told him about the conversation with Salwa, and he congratulated her. She could hear the sincerity in his voice, and it steadied her.

“Would you want to stay?” he asked.

She looked at the notes on her table. “I think I might.”

He was quiet for a moment. “Then I hope the position becomes real.”

She felt grateful for the answer. She also wished she knew what he imagined for them if it did. But she did not ask him that night. She had learned that difficult questions could become harder to answer when asked before either of them knew how to hold the possible outcomes.

After the call, she took out the notebook and wrote two headings on separate pages: *If I return to Cairo* and *If I stay in Alexandria*. Under each, she listed things she wanted: work she could believe in, a life that felt like hers, time with her family, and a future with Kareem.

The last item appeared under both headings.

She stared at it for a long time.

It was not the cities that confused her. It was the fact that she wanted a future with someone she could not make the decision for, and that his hopes might not fit neatly into hers. She had spent years managing other people's needs. Now she was facing a choice in which she could not make the uncertainty disappear by becoming more responsible.

She closed the notebook without writing a conclusion.

She imagined Kareem in each version.

In some, he returned to Cairo after each visit, and she stayed behind. In others, they found a way to live in the same city. She did not know which version was more likely. She only knew that she wanted to make the decision with him, not for him and not without him.

She called him after dinner.

He was pleased when she told him about the conversation with Salwa. He asked about the responsibilities, the timeline, and whether the role would change the kind of work she was doing. He told her she deserved the opportunity, and she felt the familiar relief of being understood.

Then she asked whether he would want her to come back to Cairo after the fellowship.

Kareem knew the answer. He wanted her back. He wanted to be able to see her without planning weeks ahead, to walk with her after work, to share the ordinary hours that had become the foundation of their relationship. He wanted to build a life in the same city.

But he also feared that saying so would become a demand. He worried that she would hear his desire as an expectation, that she would feel obliged to give up a job she loved because he was afraid of losing her. He did not want to become another person whose needs set the limits of her life.

He told her they should see what happened. If the position became permanent, she would have to consider it. If it did not, they could discuss what came next. There was no need to decide anything yet.

Layla understood the logic. She also heard what he had not said.

She wanted him to tell her that he hoped she would come back, that he wanted a future with her, and that the possibility of being apart indefinitely frightened him. She wanted to know that his desire for a shared life was strong enough to be spoken, even if it did not dictate her decision.

Instead, she received a careful outline of contingencies.

She did not argue. She thanked him for listening and ended the call with affection. Later, Kareem realized that he had answered the practical question while avoiding the personal one. He wrote a message telling her that he wanted her back in Cairo, that he wanted them to share a city and build a life together, and that he did not know how to make those desires fit with the opportunities she might find in Alexandria.

He nearly deleted it. Then he sent it.

Layla replied that she was glad he had told her. She said they did not need to decide anything immediately, but she wanted them to keep being honest about what they hoped for.

For a few days, they felt closer. They talked about what a shared future might mean: where they would live, how they would manage work, and whether one of them might eventually move. They did not make promises. They allowed themselves to imagine.

Then their lives became busy again.

Kareem's publishing house began preparing a major list for the coming season. He was asked to take responsibility for a set of manuscripts that required more work than expected. His supervisor mentioned that a senior editorial position might become available, though no decision had been made. The possibility pleased him, but it also made the idea of leaving Cairo more complicated.

Layla's responsibilities in Alexandria increased. The short-story collection she had led was moving toward production, and Salwa asked her to supervise another project. The potential permanent role became more likely, although funding was still uncertain. Layla began to understand that she might be able to build a career in Alexandria that would be difficult to replicate if she returned to Cairo immediately.

Neither told the other everything at once.

A week later, Kareem met Adam for dinner near the university where they had once spent so many afternoons pretending to study. The restaurant had changed owners since then, but the tables were still too close together and the waiter still seemed annoyed when customers asked for anything more complicated than grilled chicken.

Adam arrived late, apologizing while he searched for a place to put his bag. He had recently changed jobs and was trying to decide whether the increased salary

was worth a longer commute. He described the new office, complained about his manager, and asked Kareem whether he had heard anything more about the senior editorial role.

"Nothing official," Kareem said. "My supervisor has mentioned it, but no decision has been made."

"Would you take it?"

"Yes. I think so."

Adam nodded. "You should. You're good at the work, and you'd be good at deciding what gets published."

Kareem smiled, pleased by the confidence. Then he found himself describing the possible permanent position in Alexandria and the question that had begun to trouble him. Layla might stay there. He might have to decide whether to move, or whether he expected her to return to Cairo after the fellowship. Neither option seemed simple, and he could not find a way to think about the choice without feeling that he was about to disappoint someone.

Adam listened, then set down his fork.

"Do you want to move to Alexandria?"

Kareem frowned. "That's not the point."

"I know. I'm asking anyway."

Kareem stared at his plate. "I don't know. I've never thought about living there. My work is here. My family is here. The publishing house might offer me a position that I've wanted for years."

"Those are reasons to stay. What are the reasons to go?"

Kareem hesitated. "Layla. The life we could build. The fact that I don't want to spend the next several years traveling back and forth if we can find another way."

Adam nodded. "Those are reasons, too."

"But they're not a job. They don't tell me how I'd pay rent or what I'd do for work."

"No. They don't. You'd have to find out." Adam paused. "But you keep talking as though the only responsible choice is the one that lets you make the decision without risking anything. There isn't one."

Kareem felt irritated because the statement was too close to the truth. "I'm trying to be realistic."

"I'm sure. But realism can become a very respectable way of doing nothing."

Kareem looked up sharply.

Adam lifted a hand. "I'm not telling you to move. I'm asking whether you've even looked at what work might be available there. Have you contacted anyone? Have you checked whether your publishing house would let you work remotely for part of the week? Have you spoken to Layla about what she'd need if she came back? Or have you both agreed that you'll discuss it when the answer stops being frightening?"

Kareem did not answer.

The waiter arrived to ask whether they wanted dessert. Adam ordered a plate of rice pudding. Kareem declined, then changed his mind when Adam began eating it.

For a while, they spoke about work. But Adam's questions remained with him. Kareem had been treating the future as a decision that would eventually become clear, when in fact clarity might depend on the things he was willing to do to discover his options.

On the way home, he opened a browser on his phone and searched for editorial jobs in Alexandria. The results were imperfect, scattered, and far from conclusive. Some positions required skills he did not have; others paid less than his current salary; several were not relevant to his experience. He could not draw a conclusion from a single search.

He also found two independent publishers whose work interested him. He saved their contact details and drafted a short email asking whether they expected to expand their editorial teams in the coming year. He did not send it. He wanted to refine the wording, make the inquiry sound professional, and be sure he was not creating expectations before he knew what he wanted.

By the time he reached his apartment, the draft was still unsent.

He saved it anyway.

For the first time, the possibility of moving had become something he could investigate rather than a question he could only fear. It did not mean he would go. It meant he had stopped treating not knowing as the final answer.

Kareem waited until he knew more about his own role before mentioning it. Layla waited until Salwa had clarified the terms of the potential position before explaining how serious the offer might become. Each wanted to avoid creating anxiety about a future that had not yet arrived. Each believed they were being considerate.

They were also making it harder to plan together.

When they finally discussed the possibilities, they did it on a Sunday evening when both had promised themselves they would not turn the call into a meeting about the future. The conversation began with Layla showing Kareem the list of responsibilities Salwa had outlined for the possible permanent role. She explained the editorial projects she would be expected to manage, the authors she would work with, and the way the position could grow if the publishing house's new list performed well.

Kareem asked sensible questions. He wanted to understand the work, the salary, the hours, and how much freedom she would have to make decisions. Layla answered as best she could. She was pleased that he was interested, and she was grateful that he did not dismiss the opportunity as a temporary complication.

Then she said, "If this becomes a real offer, I think I might want to stay."

He looked down at the notebook beside his phone. "I thought you might."

"Does that worry you?"

He tried to answer honestly. "Yes. A little."

She waited.

"Not because I don't want you to have the job," he continued. "I do. I want you to have it if it's what you want. I think I'm worried about what happens to us if you stay here."

"What do you think happens?"

He hesitated. "I don't know."

Layla's expression tightened, but she let him continue.

"I want us to live in the same city. I want to see you without planning weeks ahead. I want to come home and find you there, or know I can walk over if you've had a terrible day. But I don't know whether I could find work here that I'd want to do. And I don't want you to come back to Cairo and then feel as though you gave up something important because I was frightened of being apart."

Layla was quiet for a moment. "I don't want to come back because I'm afraid of losing you, either."

He looked at her, and she could hear the relief in his silence. Then she added, "But I also don't want you to treat the possibility of moving as though it's already an unreasonable thing to ask."

"I don't think it's unreasonable."

"Then have you looked at anything? Jobs, publishers, anything that would help us understand what's possible?"

He did not answer immediately.

The question was fair. He had thought about moving, searched a few job listings, and even drafted an email to two independent publishers. But he had not sent the email. He had told himself that a half-formed inquiry would make the situation feel more serious than it was, that he should wait until Layla knew whether the job would happen. Now he heard how neatly that reasoning allowed him to avoid doing anything.

"I've looked at a few things," he said. "I haven't contacted anyone."

Layla nodded slowly. "Why not?"

He felt the familiar urge to defend himself. "Because I don't know whether it's sensible to start looking for a job in a city I might not move to."

"You don't have to accept a job. You don't even have to decide to move. I'm asking whether you're willing to investigate the possibility."

He looked at the screen as though he might find a better answer there.

"Yes," he said. "I can do that."

"Would you want to?"

The question was not about whether he could perform the task. She was asking whether he wanted the future enough to take the first uncertain step toward it.

He wanted to say yes. He wanted to tell her that he could imagine a life in Alexandria if it meant living with her, that he would miss Cairo and his family, that the possibility of leaving a job he had worked for years to earn frightened him. He wanted her to know that the fear did not mean he was unwilling.

But he heard the promise before he spoke it, and he worried that saying yes would make him responsible for a decision he had not yet thought through.

"I want to know whether it's possible," he said.

Layla closed her eyes briefly.

"That's not quite what I asked."

"I know."

She turned toward the window in her apartment. A tram passed below, ringing its bell as it moved through the intersection. She could feel herself preparing to make the conversation gentler, to translate his answer into

something she could live with, to say that she understood and that they did not need to decide anything now.

She was tired of doing that before he had finished speaking.

"I don't need you to promise that you'll move," she said. "I need you to be willing to want a future with me out loud, even if the details are frightening. I need to know whether you're thinking about how we might live together or only about all the reasons it might not work."

He looked down.

"I'm thinking about both."

"Then let me hear both. You can tell me that you want to live with me and that you're frightened of leaving Cairo. You can tell me that you want me to have this job and that you wish the job were in Cairo. Those feelings aren't mutually exclusive. I don't need you to make them neat before you talk to me."

He was silent for a long moment. Her words were close to the truth he had been trying to reach, and hearing them from her made him feel both understood and ashamed that she had had to do so much work to get him there.

"I want you back in Cairo," he said at last. "I want us to build a life together. I also want you to take the job if you decide it's right for you. I'm scared that if you stay, we'll become people who keep visiting each other until the visits are all we have. And I'm scared that if I ask you to return, you'll feel as though you have to give up something you worked for."

Layla's face softened, but she did not let the moment become an ending. "That's what I needed to hear."

He felt relieved.

Then she asked, "What will you do with that fear?"

He had not expected the question to follow so quickly.

"I'll think about it. I'll look into the jobs. I'll talk to my supervisor about whether there might be a way to work remotely for part of the week, at least temporarily."

"And when will you do that?"

The question was gentle, but it had edges. Kareem recognized the difference between a promise that expressed intention and a plan that could be followed.

"This week," he said. "I'll send those emails and ask about the remote-work option. Then we can talk about what I find out."

Layla nodded. "All right. That's something we can work with."

They stayed on the call for another half hour, discussing practicalities without pretending they could solve every question. They agreed not to make a final decision until the offer became real. They would look at work options, compare the costs of travel, and talk about what each of them would need if one of them moved. They did not promise that the answer would be simple.

When they ended the call, Layla felt hopeful and frightened. Kareem felt relieved and newly responsible for doing something with the truth he had finally spoken.

He opened the email draft he had saved after speaking with Adam. This time, he finished it and sent it. It was a small action, not a decision about where he would live. But it was the first time he had treated the future as something he might help investigate rather than something he had to wait to become certain about.

They had taken a step toward each other. Neither knew yet whether they could keep doing it when the next step required more than a conversation.

There was more information a month later. Salwa told Layla that the publishing house was applying for funding to create a permanent editorial role. If approved, the job would likely begin shortly after the fellowship ended. Layla could not accept it yet, but she was the preferred candidate.

She told Kareem during their Sunday call.

He congratulated her, and he meant it. Then he asked when she would need to make a decision.

“I don't know yet,” she said. “A few months, probably.”

He nodded, though she could not see him.

“I think we should talk about it properly when we know more.”

She had begun to hate the phrase *when we know more*. It was sensible and often correct. It was also the place where every difficult question seemed to go when neither of them knew how to answer it.

“Okay,” she said.

They spoke about her work and his. They made plans for the next visit. They said goodnight.

Later, Layla sat beside the balcony doors, looking at the sea. She loved the work she was doing. She loved Kareem. She wanted to build a future in which neither love had to be treated as a reason to diminish the other.

But she could no longer tell whether they were moving toward that future or simply postponing the moment when they would have to decide what it required.

In Cairo, Kareem lay awake thinking the same thing in a different form. He wanted to choose her. He was afraid of making the wrong choice, and he kept waiting for the moment when the choice would become clear enough that it no longer required courage.

He did not understand that courage was needed precisely because it could not become clear in advance.

In Cairo, the possible promotion arrived on an ordinary Tuesday. Kareem's supervisor asked him to stay after a meeting, then closed the door and showed him a proposed structure for the coming year. The publishing house was considering him for a senior editorial role. It would mean more responsibility, a modest increase in pay, and the chance to shape the editorial list rather than only work on individual manuscripts.

He listened carefully, asking about responsibilities, salary, and the timeline. He was pleased in a way he had not allowed himself to be when the possibility had first been mentioned. He had spent years wanting someone to trust his judgment. Now the chance had appeared, and he could imagine the work he might do with it.

“Would you be interested?” his supervisor asked.

“Yes,” Kareem said.

The answer came quickly. He did not have to pretend the opportunity was unimportant simply because Layla's future had become complicated. His work mattered to him. He had built skills, relationships, and a reputation in Cairo. He wanted to see what he could do with the chance to lead.

When he left the office, pleasure gave way to calculation. If the role became permanent, moving to Alexandria would mean giving up something he had wanted for years. If Layla accepted the position there, asking her to return to Cairo might mean asking her to give up something she had earned. He wanted to believe that a shared future would allow both of them to keep the parts of their lives that mattered most. He did not know whether that was possible.

He thought about telling Layla that evening. He wanted her to know that his work was changing, that someone was trusting him with more responsibility. He also feared that bringing up his own opportunity would make it appear that he was using it as a reason not to move, or placing his career beside hers as though they were competing claims. He decided to wait until he had more information.

A few days later, he met Adam for dinner. They had been trying to see each other more often, partly because Kareem had realized how easily he allowed old friendships to fade when no practical reason required him to maintain them. Adam listened while Kareem described the position and the kind of work he might be able to lead.

“You've wanted that for a long time,” Adam said.

“I have.”

“So what's the problem?”

Kareem looked down at his plate. “Layla might be offered a permanent job in Alexandria.”

Adam nodded slowly. “And you think the two things can't fit together.”

“I don't know whether they can. I don't know what work I'd find there. I don't know whether moving would be sensible.”

“Would you want to move if you could find good work?”

Kareem hesitated. “I think so.”

“Then that's something you should know about yourself before you start deciding what is sensible.”

Kareem laughed faintly. “Everyone has become very interested in my decisions lately.”

“That's because you've spent years acting as though you don't have any.” Adam took a sip of water. “I'm not telling you to move. I'm asking whether you've considered it as a real possibility, or whether you're using the uncertainty as a reason not to think about it.”

The question irritated Kareem because it was close to the one he had been avoiding. He wanted to protect his career. He wanted to support Layla. He wanted to make a decision that would not lead to regret. The desire to prevent regret had become so powerful that he was struggling to imagine a decision at all.

“I don't want her to choose Cairo because of me,” he said.

“Then don't ask her to. Tell her what you'd be willing to consider. Let her make her decision with the truth in front of her.”

“You make it sound very simple.”

“It isn't simple. It's just not the same thing as impossible.”

The conversation followed Kareem home. He opened the email from his supervisor and read the details again. For several minutes, he considered telling

Layla that he had been offered a chance to lead. He could explain that he was interested and that he wanted them to consider all the possibilities together, even if neither knew what the right decision would be.

Then he remembered that the position had not been confirmed. He worried she would interpret the information as a reason to question whether he would ever be willing to move. He told himself he would wait until he had more details. The decision seemed sensible. It also meant he was once again choosing to manage the uncertainty alone.

A week later, Layla told him that Salwa had asked her to take on a larger role in the collection. Kareem congratulated her, then almost mentioned the conversation with his supervisor. He decided to wait until the offer was more definite.

Layla heard the omission as she had heard other omissions: not as a lie, but as a small door he had chosen to keep closed. She did not know he had been offered anything. He did not know she was beginning to wonder whether he wanted her to know him only in the parts of his life that were easy to explain.

Neither had intended to keep secrets. They were each waiting to make the future less uncertain before sharing it with the person who would be affected by it. They were both trying to be considerate. They were also making decisions alone and calling the silence kindness.

The future remained in pencil. They continued to live inside it as though someone else would eventually ink the lines.

CHAPTER NINE

The Cost of Trying

“Love can survive a great deal of distance, but it cannot live forever on what two people mean to do.”

By the time the fellowship had six weeks remaining, Layla and Kareem had learned to speak about nearly everything except the question that mattered most.

They talked about work, family, books, money, the weather, and the inconveniences of train schedules. They knew when the other person had eaten, when a deadline was approaching, and which colleague had said something absurd. They remembered birthdays and sent photographs. They planned visits and looked forward to them.

They also knew how to avoid a difficult subject with impressive precision.

Whenever Layla asked what they were going to do after the fellowship, Kareem said they should wait until the position was confirmed. Whenever Kareem asked whether she wanted to stay in Alexandria, Layla explained that she had not made a decision. Both answers were true. Neither contained the thing the other person most wanted to know.

Layla wanted Kareem to say that he would be willing to build a life with her, even if it meant changing his own. She did not need an immediate relocation or a reckless promise. She needed to know that he would participate in choosing a future rather than wait for circumstances to choose it for them.

Kareem wanted Layla to tell him that she still imagined him in that future, that her growing independence did not mean he was becoming optional. He feared that asking for reassurance would make him sound small, so he tried to be generous and waited for her to offer it unprompted.

She did not know he was waiting.

He did not know she was tired of asking.

Their first serious argument that spring began because of a missed train.

Layla had arranged to come to Cairo for a weekend. She had a meeting on Friday afternoon, then planned to take the evening train. A problem at the publishing house delayed her departure. She sent Kareem a message explaining that she might arrive an hour later than expected.

He replied that it was fine.

By the time she reached the station, the train had been delayed again. The next available service was much later, and she would not arrive until nearly midnight. She called Kareem to tell him.

He sounded tired.

“That's all right,” he said. “We can see each other tomorrow.”

She had spent the day working, rushing to the station, and trying to preserve a visit she had been looking forward to for weeks. His answer was sensible. She knew that. But she heard something else in it: that the lost evening did not matter enough to be regretted.

“Do you want me to come tomorrow instead?” she asked.

“If that's easier.”

She closed her eyes.

“That's not what I asked.”

He was silent.

She wanted him to say that he was disappointed too, that he had been looking forward to seeing her, that he wished the train had not been delayed. She wanted him to share the frustration instead of converting it into a practical adjustment.

He wanted her to tell him what she needed instead of asking a question whose answer seemed to contain a test.

Neither said those things.

They ended the call politely. Layla booked the later train and arrived in Cairo close to midnight. Kareem met her at the station. He was tired, but when he saw her, his face softened, and he took her bag before she could protest.

They held hands for a long time.

For a few minutes, the argument seemed too small to matter.

Then, in the taxi, Layla asked, “Were you disappointed that I wasn't coming earlier?”

He looked at her.

“Of course I was. I wanted to see you.”

“Then why didn't you say so?”

He frowned. “You were already upset about the train. I didn't want to make it worse.”

“You could have said you were disappointed and still been kind.”

He looked out of the window. “I thought I was being understanding.”

“I know. But sometimes it feels as though you think understanding means not having feelings about anything.”

He turned toward her. “And sometimes it feels as though you ask me a question, then get upset because I haven't guessed the answer you wanted.”

The words were out before he could soften them.

Layla stared at him.

He wanted to take them back, but some part of him knew that they contained a truth he had avoided. She sometimes hoped he would intuit her needs, and when he did not, she felt abandoned. He sometimes hid his needs until she could not know they existed, then resented the fact that she had failed to recognize them.

Neither of them was innocent of the pattern.

Neither knew how to stop it when they were hurt.

She mistook his silence for the absence of love. He mistook her anger for the absence of understanding. They were both wrong, and neither was wrong enough to stop hurting.

They spent the weekend together, but a carefulness had entered their conversations. They were affectionate. They visited her mother's house, had lunch with Kareem's brother, and walked through the city they had once explored without needing to plan it. Yet they kept returning to the argument in small, indirect ways.

On Sunday, when Layla returned to Alexandria, Kareem promised they would talk more during the week.

They did not.

Work became busy. A manuscript was delayed. Layla had a meeting with Salwa about the permanent role. Kareem's supervisor asked him to take on another project. Each of them waited for a better moment to return to the conversation, and each day the better moment seemed to move farther away.

In March, Kareem missed a scheduled call because he fell asleep before nine. He had spent the day reviewing a manuscript that had been returned to him three times, and by the time he reached his apartment, he was too tired to do anything beyond eat and sit on the sofa for a few minutes. He meant to rest his eyes until his dinner warmed. When he woke, the room was dark and the clock showed 11:18.

His phone lay beside him.

There were two messages from Layla. The first had arrived at nine: *Are we still talking tonight?* The second, sent nearly an hour later, read: *I hope you're all right. I'll assume you fell asleep. We can talk tomorrow.*

Kareem sat up, suddenly wide awake. He called her, but she did not answer. He typed an apology, deleted it, then typed it again with more explanation. He told her he had been exhausted, that he had not meant to forget, and that he was sorry she had waited.

He knew the explanation was true. He also knew it was not enough.

Layla had spent the evening waiting to tell him that the first draft of her collection had been approved. She had been excited, nervous, and proud of herself. She had imagined telling him over the phone, hearing him ask what the editor thought, and describing the moment when Salwa had said the manuscript was ready to move forward. When the call did not happen, she had tried to make the evening smaller. She told herself that people fell asleep. She told herself that he had not forgotten her deliberately. She told herself that it was unreasonable to be so disappointed by one missed call.

None of those thoughts changed how she felt.

The following morning, she read his apology on the tram. She was already on her way to work and had less than ten minutes before a meeting. She called him and told him the news in a rushed conversation between stops. He congratulated her, and she could hear how pleased he was. She thanked him, then had to end the call.

For the rest of the morning, she was angry with herself for feeling as though the moment had been diminished. The collection had been approved. It was a genuine achievement. She could celebrate it with her colleagues and still be pleased. Why did she need Kareem to have been there at the precise moment?

Because he was the person she had wanted to tell, she admitted. Because she wanted him to be part of the ordinary moments that made up her life, not only the scheduled conversations when both of them had enough energy to report what had happened.

That evening, Kareem called to apologize again. He told her about his day, the manuscript, and the way he had fallen asleep without meaning to. He did not defend himself. He told her he understood why she had been hurt.

Layla was quiet for a moment.

“I know you didn't do it on purpose,” she said. “But I was looking forward to telling you something that mattered to me, and I ended up telling you in a hurry between meetings. It made me feel as though the part of my life I wanted to share with you had to wait until you were available.”

He closed his eyes.

“I don't want you to feel that way.”

“I know.”

“I should have messaged you when I was tired. I should have told you I might fall asleep.”

“Yes.”

He waited, then said, “I'm sorry.”

She believed him. That did not immediately remove the hurt, but it allowed the conversation to continue without either of them needing to defend themselves.

They discussed what they could do differently. If one of them was too tired to talk, they would send a message rather than leave the other waiting. If something important happened, they would not assume there would always be a perfect time to share it. They agreed that the plan was not about never disappointing one another. It was about not making the other person guess whether they still mattered.

When they hung up, Kareem felt relieved. Layla felt heard. Both believed they had learned something useful.

Neither realized how easily the same problem could return in another form, with a different explanation and the same underlying silence.

A week after the missed-train argument, Kareem and Layla managed a weekend that seemed, at first, to prove they could still be happy together. Layla arrived in Cairo on Friday afternoon and stayed with her family. Kareem met her at the station, and they bought lunch from a small shop and ate it in the car because the traffic made it impossible to reach the restaurant they had planned to visit.

Layla told him about an author who had sent a manuscript with two different endings. Kareem argued that the writer should keep both and call the book an experiment in indecision. She accused him of making a joke out of everything, then laughed because she knew he was trying to lighten her mood.

They spent Saturday morning at a market, looking for a small table she wanted for her apartment in Alexandria. Kareem helped her compare prices. She rejected the first three tables, and he accused her of judging furniture more harshly than prose. She replied that furniture had to support real weight, whereas prose only had to pretend.

They found a secondhand table with a scratched surface and sturdy legs. Layla stood beside it, considering the price. Kareem waited without trying to persuade her. Finally she nodded to the seller.

On the walk back, she said, “I like that you didn't tell me what to choose.”

“I learned from past mistakes.”

“No, I mean it. You let me think.”

He smiled. “You are very capable of thinking.”

She glanced at him. “You'd be surprised how often people confuse being helpful with taking over.”

“I can imagine.”

They stopped for coffee and sat outside while the city moved around them. Layla talked about the possibility of keeping the table in Alexandria if the permanent role became real. She described how she might rearrange the apartment, where she wanted to put a reading chair, and how she imagined inviting friends over for dinner.

Kareem listened. He could picture the apartment with the table, the books, and the lamp. He could picture her life continuing there in ways he did not yet know how to share. The image hurt a little, but he did not try to turn the hurt into a warning.

“I like hearing you talk about what you want,” he said.

She smiled. “Even when it doesn't include you?”

He looked at her. The question was half a joke, but it carried a real fear.

“I hope it includes me,” he said. “But I don't want you to make the things you want smaller just so I can find myself in them.”

Her expression softened. “I want you in them. I just need to know that you want to be there, too.”

“I do.” He paused. “I think I'm still learning how to say that before I start worrying about what it might require.”

She reached for his hand. “Then keep learning.”

For the rest of the weekend, they seemed to manage it. They spoke openly, laughed, and did not turn every pause into a test. On Sunday morning, they met for breakfast at a café near the station. Kareem arrived early enough that the waiter had started asking whether he was expecting someone. He ordered eggs and tea, and Layla teased him for choosing a table with a view of the entrance as

though he were conducting surveillance. They argued about whether the eggs needed more salt. He told her about a childhood memory he had never mentioned before, and she listened without trying to draw a lesson from it.

Later, Layla returned to her family home to collect her bag for the journey back to Alexandria. Kareem waited downstairs while she said goodbye to her mother and siblings. When she came down, she found the postcard she had bought with Kareem months earlier tucked inside a book. She had forgotten it was there. She held it up.

“Do you remember this?”

He smiled. “You bought it because you liked it.”

“Yes.”

“You were very proud of yourself.”

“I was trying to become a person who buys things for no reason.”

“And how is that going?”

She looked at him for a moment. “Better, I think.”

He took her hand, and she held it. For a few seconds the future felt less like a problem and more like a place they might reach if they continued to choose each other.

Then her train time arrived. He carried her bag downstairs and walked her to the taxi. They agreed on the next visit and confirmed the date in their calendars. Nothing went wrong. Nobody forgot anything. They said goodbye with affection, and Layla left feeling hopeful.

Kareem watched the taxi disappear and felt the ache return. He did not want to lose the life they had shared that weekend. He wanted to find a way to keep it. He also knew that their ability to be happy together for two days did not answer the question of how they would build a life over months and years.

For the first time, he understood that love could make a difficult future worth attempting. It could not decide the details for them.

He planned to tell Layla what he wanted when they next spoke. He wrote the words in his notebook that evening, not as a script but as a reminder: *I want us to make choices together, even when we don't know how they will turn out.*

He left the notebook open on his desk.

By Monday, work had become busy again, and the sentence remained where he had left it.

Two weeks later, Layla had a difficult conversation with her mother, who was struggling with the idea that the fellowship would end without Layla necessarily returning to Cairo. Nadia said she knew Layla deserved a career, but she worried that the family would become less close. Layla listened, then told her she would not make a decision about her future simply to reassure everyone else.

Afterward, she called Kareem. He was in the middle of an edit and answered distractedly. He asked whether she wanted advice. She said she did not. He asked whether she wanted to talk. She said she did. But when he began asking what she planned to do about her mother, the conversation returned to a problem she had not called him to solve.

She ended the call gently and spent the evening alone.

The following day, she told him what she had needed. He apologized, and he meant it. He also explained that he sometimes felt helpless when she was hurt and wanted to offer something useful. She told him that listening was useful. They agreed to try again.

Each time they repaired a small fracture, they became more confident that they could repair the next one. Each time, they also learned how to make the injury sound smaller than it had felt, because neither wanted the relationship to be defined by its difficulties.

There was a weekend in April when they almost managed to change the pattern.

Kareem had traveled to Alexandria on a Friday evening. Layla had been working late, and when he arrived at the apartment she was still at her desk, surrounded by notes. She apologized for not being ready. He told her not to worry and went into the kitchen to make tea.

When she finished, she came to sit beside him. He asked whether she wanted to talk about work, and she said yes. He listened for nearly an hour, asking questions and resisting the urge to offer solutions. When she began to criticize herself for missing a detail in a manuscript, he reminded her that she had caught the mistake before publication and that correcting it was part of her job, not evidence that she was bad at it.

She looked at him, grateful.

“This is what I need sometimes,” she said. “Not for you to fix anything. Just for you to understand why it matters.”

He felt proud that he had managed to do it. The pride was not misplaced. He had listened better than he might have a few months earlier, and Layla had felt the difference.

The next morning, however, a message from his supervisor reminded him that a manuscript was overdue. Kareem spent half an hour answering emails while Layla prepared breakfast. When she asked whether he could put the phone away, he said he only needed five minutes. The five minutes became twenty.

When he finally looked up, Layla had finished eating.

“I'm sorry,” he said.

She nodded. “It's fine.”

But it wasn't entirely fine. They had just spent an evening talking about how much it mattered to be present, and the following morning the old habit had returned. Kareem felt ashamed, and because he felt ashamed, he tried to make the rest of the day perfect. He insisted on choosing lunch, suggested a walk, and bought her a book she had mentioned wanting.

Layla enjoyed the day. She also noticed that he was trying to compensate for the morning rather than acknowledge that it had happened.

That night, she told him so.

“You don't have to make the whole weekend wonderful because you disappointed me for twenty minutes,” she said. “You can just say you got distracted, and then put the phone away.”

He laughed, embarrassed. “I thought I was making it up to you.”

“I don't want to be compensated for. I want to be with you.”

He took her hand and apologized. She accepted it. They felt closer because they had said the truth.

Then, as the train carried him back to Cairo, Kareem told himself the problem had been addressed. He did not make a plan for what he would do the next time work interrupted them. He assumed the understanding would remain available when he needed it.

They did not notice that the apologies were beginning to repeat. They noticed the hurt, but they treated the apology as the ending rather than asking what had to change in order for the same hurt to stop returning.

Three weeks later, Layla received formal confirmation that the publishing house had secured the funding. The permanent position would be offered to her

after the fellowship ended. She was delighted, though the news carried a decision she could no longer postpone indefinitely.

Before she called Kareem, Layla reread the email three times. The subject line was ordinary—*Editorial role: funding confirmed*—and the body was only a few paragraphs long. It described the position, the expected start date after the fellowship, and the salary range. Salwa had included a short note thanking her for the work she had done and explaining that the formal contract would follow after the final budget review.

Layla printed the email.

She did not know why she needed a paper copy. Perhaps she wanted the offer to exist somewhere she could touch, separate from the screen where so much of her life now appeared. She placed it beside her notebook and took a photograph, then laughed at herself for photographing a document she had just printed.

She called Nadia first. Her mother listened, offered congratulations, and then asked whether the salary would be enough to cover rent and travel to Cairo. Layla answered as best she could. They talked about the practicalities for a few minutes, but the conversation felt different from the one they would have had months earlier. Nadia still worried; she simply did not treat her worry as a reason for Layla to stop.

"I'm proud of you," she said at the end.

Layla sat still. "Thank you, Mama."

"Your father would have been proud, too."

The words brought tears to Layla's eyes. Her mother rarely spoke about what her father would have thought, perhaps because the absence of an answer had become too painful to touch. Layla wanted to stay on the call and ask her to tell a story, any story, but Nadia had begun talking about Youssef's application again and the moment passed.

After they hung up, Layla opened the notebook where she had written her two possible futures. She read the lists. The same things appeared beneath both headings: work that mattered, time with her family, a life that felt like hers, a future with Kareem. The offer made one choice more immediate, but it did not remove the question she had been asking herself since the fellowship began.

Could she stay in Alexandria and still build a life with Kareem? Would he be willing to consider moving? If he could not, would she return to Cairo because she wanted to, or because the relationship made the alternative too painful? If

she stayed, would she spend the year waiting for him to tell her how much he wanted her to come back?

She did not want to choose from fear. She also did not want to pretend that the relationship was separate from the decision. She loved Kareem. His hopes mattered to her. But they could not be the only thing that mattered.

She picked up her phone and called him.

Kareem answered on the second ring. He sounded tired, but when she told him the position was confirmed, his voice warmed immediately.

"Layla, that's wonderful. You did it."

She smiled, looking down at the printed email. "I haven't actually signed anything yet."

"You know what I mean. They want you. They want you to stay."

"Yes."

"I'm happy for you."

He meant it. She could hear that he meant it, and for a few moments she let herself enjoy the news with the person whose opinion mattered most to her.

She told him about the expected start date, the work she would be responsible for, and the projects Salwa hoped to develop over the next year. Kareem asked about the team, the salary, and whether the role might eventually involve managing other editors. He sounded interested, and she felt the familiar reassurance of being able to talk about her work with someone who understood it.

Then she said, "I think I'm going to accept it."

He was quiet.

The pause was brief, but she felt the change in it.

"I thought you might," he said.

She placed the email on the table. "Are you upset?"

"No. I'm happy for you."

"Kareem."

He stopped.

"Please don't say that if there's something else you want to say."

He looked at his desk. He had been trying to prepare for this possibility for weeks. He had written lists, searched for jobs, and spoken to Adam. He had

thought about the practical realities of moving: the work he might find, the salary he might need, the possibility that the publishing house could offer him the senior role he had wanted for years. He had also imagined waking up in Alexandria with Layla and finding that the life he had been afraid to ask for was, in fact, possible.

He had not turned those thoughts into a clear answer.

"I don't want to influence your decision," he said.

Layla closed her eyes.

"I'm not asking you to make it for me."

"I know."

"Then help me understand what we're trying to build."

He had a thousand things to say to her, and somehow every one of them became impossible the moment she needed to hear one.

He took a breath. "I want a future with you. I want us to live in the same city. I want us to stop treating every visit as something we have to arrange around work and train schedules. But I don't know whether I can find work here that makes sense for me. I don't want to move and then become resentful, and I don't want you to come back to Cairo and feel you've given up something you wanted."

"Those are real concerns," Layla said. "I'm not asking you to ignore them. But have you contacted the publishers you looked up? Have you asked your supervisor whether remote work is possible? Have you tried to find out whether moving is something you could actually do?"

Kareem looked at the notebook beside his laptop. The email he had sent to the independent publishers had received one polite reply, asking him to send a CV. His supervisor had said he could explore a temporary remote arrangement, though no promise had been made. These were not answers, but they were information. He had not yet told Layla about them because he had wanted to understand the situation before presenting it as a possibility.

"I've started looking," he said. "I have a reply from one publisher. And my supervisor said we could discuss a temporary remote arrangement. I don't know what either will lead to."

Layla listened, surprised. "Why didn't you tell me?"

He felt the question like a small rebuke. "I wanted to know whether it was possible before I made you think it might happen."

"But you don't have to bring me a finished answer. You can tell me that you're looking. You can tell me that you don't know yet. I would rather be part of the uncertainty than find out about the work you've done after you've made your mind up."

He was silent.

She continued, quieter now. "I'm not asking you to promise you'll move. I'm asking whether you're willing to consider a future where we don't keep travelling between two lives indefinitely."

"I am willing."

"Then why does it always feel as though I'm the only one asking what happens next?"

He wanted to say that he had been trying. He had made calls to his brother, spoken to his supervisor, searched for work, and forced himself to admit that he wanted a shared future. He had done things he once would have avoided. He wanted that effort to be visible.

But she was not asking whether he had tried. She was asking whether he would keep going when the next step required him to risk disappointment.

"I think I'm afraid of choosing something and discovering I've made the wrong decision," he said.

Layla's voice softened. "So am I."

He looked up.

"I'm afraid I'll stay and regret it. I'm afraid I'll return to Cairo and regret that, too. I'm afraid I'll lose you no matter what I choose. But I can't let the fear make the decision for me, and I can't keep asking you to do all the work of figuring out what we're doing."

He felt the truth of it, and the shame that followed. She was not asking him for certainty. She was asking him to stand beside her while they faced the uncertainty together.

"I am trying," he said.

"I know." Her voice was exhausted, not angry. "I just don't know whether trying is enough anymore."

The words left them both quiet. Kareem wanted to answer, to say that he would do whatever was needed, that he would move, that he would find a way. He knew he could not promise that he would be able to make every part of the

future work. He was afraid of offering a certainty that later became another disappointment.

He also understood, dimly, that his refusal to promise anything was making a decision of its own.

He could not yet say that aloud.

The call ended without a resolution.

For the next several days, they spoke less. They still sent messages. Kareem asked how work was going. Layla told him about the final stages of the collection. He sent a photograph of a book she had recommended. She responded with a joke. They did not stop saying they loved each other.

But they stopped talking about the future.

One evening, Layla sat at her kitchen table and realized that love alone could not answer the practical questions gathering around their future. She loved Kareem, and she wanted to marry him. She needed them to speak honestly about where they might live, what each of them was willing to change, and how they would build a life that belonged to both of them. She was not preparing to leave him; she was preparing to ask him to choose a future with her instead of leaving it undefined.

She called him the following night.

“Can we meet next weekend?” she asked.

He felt a small dread arrive before she explained why.

“Yes,” he said. “Of course.”

“I think we need to talk in person.”

He knew what she meant.

“All right.”

They agreed that she would come to Cairo on Friday evening. Kareem booked a table at the restaurant where they had celebrated the first month of their relationship. He told himself that meeting in person would help them understand each other. He told himself that they could find a way forward if they spoke honestly, if he could finally explain what he wanted without turning it into a demand, if she could tell him what she needed without feeling that she had to make the whole decision herself.

He believed there was still time.

On the Wednesday before Layla's trip to Cairo, Kareem tried to prepare for the conversation by writing down what he wanted to say. He made a list of the things he wanted to tell her: that he loved her, that he wanted a shared future, that he was frightened of moving too quickly and frightened of waiting too long. He wrote that he could imagine living in Alexandria if the right work became possible, and that he did not want her to choose Cairo simply because he was there.

He looked at the list and found that it sounded like a speech written by someone asking to be judged fairly. It contained explanations, qualifications, and enough careful language to leave every possible outcome open. It did not say what he was willing to do.

He crossed it out.

He tried again, this time writing only: *I want a life with you. I want to work out how to make it possible.*

He left the sentence on the page.

The next day, a message from his brother arrived while Kareem was still at work. Mahmoud had been taken to hospital after a bout of severe chest pain. By the time Kareem reached the emergency department, his father was awake and irritated by the number of people asking him questions. The doctors had found a significant narrowing in one of his coronary arteries. They recommended a procedure rather than waiting for another episode.

“It isn't a heart attack,” Mahmoud said, as though the distinction should settle everyone. He asked whether the car had been parked somewhere it would not be fined and whether Kareem had remembered to bring his phone charger. He did not ask how frightened his children had been when they heard he was in hospital. He seemed embarrassed by the attention and annoyed that his body had become a problem other people needed to discuss.

The procedure went well. The cardiologist was cautiously reassuring, but the recovery would take months, not days. Mahmoud would have to stop working for a while, return for follow-up appointments, take medication, and avoid the exertion he had always dismissed as ordinary. The family had savings, but the procedure, medicines, transport, and loss of his usual income would place them under pressure.

His brother contributed what he could, and his sister took on several appointments and bills. Neither refused to help. Neither had enough time or money to make the problem disappear. Kareem began covering more of his parents' household expenses than he had planned, while trying to keep up with

the senior editorial role that was still only a possibility. His salary remained steady; the demands on it did not.

For several days, the family lived by the phone. Hala called Kareem whenever Mahmoud complained of dizziness, whenever a nurse gave an instruction she did not understand, whenever he was quiet for too long in the next room. Her fear was not theatrical. It was the fear of a woman who had spent years assuming that the practical parts of a life would continue because someone had always managed them, and who had discovered that no one could promise her they would.

At home, Mahmoud followed the doctor's instructions with visible resentment. He wanted to return to work before he was cleared to do so. He treated the medication as an inconvenience and the follow-up appointments as interruptions. Hala tried to control every detail, and when he resisted her, she called Kareem to settle the argument. The family did not suddenly become cruel or unloving. It became tired, frightened, and less able to hide the habits that had always made it difficult to talk about what mattered.

One evening, after Kareem had paid for a prescription and arranged his father's next appointment, Hala sat at the kitchen table with the receipts in front of her. She looked smaller than he remembered. “I don't know how I'll manage if you aren't here,” she said. “Your brother has his own family. Your sister has her life. I know you have work, but I don't know what I'll do if something happens and I can't reach you.”

He told her he would answer when she called. He said his brother would help. He reminded her that Mahmoud was recovering and that the doctor had been clear about what to watch for. Each answer was reasonable, and none made her look less afraid.

When he left, Hala held his arm at the door. “You wouldn't really leave us now, would you?”

Kareem could not tell whether she meant Alexandria, the possible promotion, or the slow change that comes when an adult child begins building a life that cannot be arranged around the family home. He promised that he would not abandon them. He did not promise that he would never leave Cairo. The difference was one he understood; he was not sure his mother could hear it.

He told Layla that his father had suffered a cardiac episode and that the procedure had gone well. He said the doctors were pleased with the recovery so far. When she asked whether he was all right, he said he was managing. He did not tell her about the money, the calls, or the way his mother's fear had made

him feel as though every possible future began with a question about whether he could be reached at short notice.

He told himself he was sparing her worry until he had a clearer idea of what the family needed. It was the same kind of reasoning he had used before: wait until the facts are settled, then explain them cleanly. But the facts were not settling. They were becoming the shape of his days.

By the time he sat down to prepare for the weekend, he had spent weeks trying to make the sentence he had written—*I want a life with you. I want to work out how to make it possible*—true in practical terms. He had not stopped wanting a marriage; he had worked late, called his siblings, compared budgets, and looked for another job because he wanted there to be a way. Yet the sentence now looked less like an intention and more like a promise he did not know how to keep. He could imagine marrying Layla. He could imagine being happy with her. He could also imagine her learning to recognize the sound of his mother's anxious calls, measuring their plans against his father's next appointment, and discovering that a family emergency could enter their home without asking either of them for permission.

Layla was doing her own version of preparation, though she had not written a list of questions this time. She had written one sentence and kept returning to it: *I want to build a life with you, even if it is difficult. I want us to decide together what difficult means.* She knew the role in Alexandria might become a real offer. She knew returning to Cairo could change the direction of her career. She was not pretending these choices did not matter. She wanted Kareem to know that she was willing to weigh them with him, rather than make a decision out of fear of losing him.

She did not know that he had begun to think her willingness was precisely what made him afraid. Nor did she fully recognize how often her questions had started to sound like demands. She was not trying to corner him or force him into a promise. She was trying to find out whether he was already leaving while she was still standing beside him. After her father died, she had learned how quickly a future could disappear without waiting for anyone to be ready. She knew Kareem was not her father, and his hesitation was not the same as death, but the old fear often arrived before reason could quiet it. She pressed for answers because she was afraid of losing another person she loved deeply, and her fear sometimes came out as urgency instead of vulnerability.

A few days after his father's procedure, Kareem visited his brother after work. His niece had fallen asleep on the sofa, one arm tucked beneath her head, while his sister-in-law folded laundry in the other room. Kareem sat at the kitchen table

with his brother and told him that Layla might be offered a permanent role in Alexandria. He also admitted that the expenses and responsibility around Mahmoud's recovery had grown heavier than he had expected, and that he had told Layla only the simplest version of what was happening.

His brother nodded. “That's good news.”

“It is.”

“You sound as though you're about to tell me someone died.”

Kareem smiled faintly. “I'm trying to work out what it means for us.”

His brother put down the mug he was holding. “Have you asked her what she wants?”

“Yes.”

“What did she say?”

“She hasn't decided yet.”

“And what do you want?”

Kareem looked at the table. “I want her to come back to Cairo. I want us to live in the same city. I want to build a life together. But I don't want her to turn down a job she loves because I want her here.”

His brother nodded slowly. “Those are two different things. You can want her back without asking her to give up something important.”

“I know.”

“Do you?”

Kareem looked up.

His brother's voice was not critical. “You've always been careful not to ask for anything. Now you're doing the opposite: you're deciding what she should not be asked to carry. Tell her the truth about the money, the appointments, and what your mother expects of you. Let her tell you whether she can live with it. You don't get to decide what she can bear and call that protection.”

Kareem felt the familiar heat of defensiveness rise, then recede. It was difficult to hear the pattern described by someone who had lived beside it for years.

“I don't want to do that to her,” he said.

“Then don't. Tell her what you want. Let her tell you what she wants. You don't have to make the decision tonight, but you can't expect her to live inside a future you refuse to describe.”

Kareem glanced toward the living room, where his niece was still asleep. He had come to his brother's house because he wanted to be more present in his family. Now he understood that showing up was not only about turning up at the door. It was also about letting people know what was happening inside him, even when he did not have a neat answer.

“I think I'm afraid that if I say what I want, she'll hear it as a demand,” he said.

His brother shrugged. “Then tell her it's what you want, not what she has to do. She's an adult. She can hear the difference.”

Kareem almost laughed. The simplicity of the advice made him feel foolish for not having arrived at it on his own. But he knew the difficult part was not understanding the advice. The difficult part was trusting that he could say what he wanted and survive the answer.

When he returned home, he opened his notebook and wrote a few sentences about the conversation he hoped to have with Layla. This time, he did not try to make the sentences sound wise or unassailable. He wrote that he wanted to live with her, that he wanted to consider moving if the work could be made possible, and that he did not want her to decide her future out of guilt. He wrote that he was afraid of moving and afraid of staying, because both choices carried a risk of regret.

The words were honest. They were also incomplete. They did not explain what he would actually do if Layla accepted the position, or what work he would seek, or how he would decide when to stop waiting for certainty.

He knew this. Still, writing the words felt like a beginning.

He did not decide to leave Layla that night. For the next several weeks, he tried to find a way to keep the future they had imagined from collapsing under the weight of his family's needs. He asked his brother and sister to draw up a more realistic rota for appointments and household expenses, and he offered to cover a larger share of the bills while Mahmoud recovered. He asked his supervisor whether the senior role could include some flexibility, or whether a move to Alexandria might be possible if Layla's permanent position came through. The answer was not an outright refusal, but there was no branch to transfer to and no promise that remote work would be enough. He searched for editorial positions in Alexandria and drafted enquiries to two publishers, then hesitated over sending them because he could not tell whether he was genuinely ready to leave Cairo or merely trying to escape the pressure of choosing.

He made budgets for three versions of their future: Layla returning to Cairo, Kareem moving to Alexandria, and both of them maintaining two homes for a

while. He recalculated them whenever a prescription changed, a bill arrived, or his father complained that he could not return to work yet. He and Layla kept their calls and visits. He made plans and tried to keep them. He told himself that if he could find a practical arrangement, he would ask her to marry him without making her carry the uncertainty he was afraid to name.

Some possibilities were difficult but not impossible. That was part of what frightened him. There was no single fact that proved they could not make a life together; there were only expenses, responsibilities, competing careers, and a future that could not be guaranteed. Kareem kept searching for a plan that would remove the risk before he asked Layla to share it. His effort was real, and so was the flaw inside it: he was trying to solve the future alone, as though love meant arriving with an answer rather than letting the person he loved help shape the question.

In Alexandria, Layla spoke to Mariam on the phone the same evening. She told her about the possible permanent job and the conversation with Kareem. Mariam listened, then asked a question Layla had been avoiding.

"If Kareem told you tomorrow that he wanted you to come back to Cairo, what would you do?"

Layla looked at the printed offer beside her notebook. "I don't know."

"Would you want to come back?"

"I love Cairo. I love my family. I miss things about it every day." She paused. "But I also like my life here. I like what I'm becoming."

"Then you need to separate the questions. Do you want the job? And do you want a future with Kareem? You can want both. But if they lead in different directions, you have to decide what you can live with."

Layla rubbed her forehead. "I know. It feels awful to say that, as though I'm ranking them."

"You aren't ranking them. You're deciding what kind of life you want. The people you love can matter without making the decision for you."

Layla was quiet. Her sister had been learning this lesson in her own way. Mariam still asked for advice, still called when something went wrong, but she had begun to take responsibility for her decisions without expecting Layla to supervise the result.

"What if he thinks I'm choosing work over him?" Layla asked.

"Then you need to tell him that isn't what you mean. And he needs to tell you what he wants. You can't keep making room for a future he won't describe."

Layla closed her eyes. "I don't want to force him to move."

"Then don't force him. Ask whether he would consider it. That's not the same thing."

The sentence stayed with her after the call ended. She sat beside the balcony door, listening to the city, and tried to imagine the conversation she would have with Kareem when she returned to Cairo. She did not want to threaten him with a choice. She wanted to tell him that the time had come to make one together.

For the first time, she understood that being clear about what she needed was not the same as demanding that he provide it. She could ask for a shared future. He could say what he wanted. Neither could guarantee the answer would be easy.

She wrote one sentence at the bottom of her list: *I need to know whether we're working toward the same life, not only whether we still love each other.*

Then she closed the notebook and booked her ticket to Cairo.

“If he asked you to come back, would you?”

Layla looked toward the lamp beside her bed. “I don't know.”

“Would you want to?”

Layla took a breath. “I want to be with him. I also want to keep doing this work. I don't know whether the choice is between those things yet.”

Mariam was quiet for a moment. “Then don't make it that choice until it actually is. But don't pretend you have no preference just because you're afraid of hurting him.”

Layla leaned back against the chair. She had spent so much time trying to protect the people she loved from disappointment that she sometimes forgot disappointment was not the same as harm. A difficult truth could hurt and still be necessary. A decision could make someone sad without being a betrayal.

“I don't want to keep asking him to tell me what he wants,” she said.

“Then don't ask him again. Tell him what you want, and see whether he meets you there.”

After they hung up, Layla sat with the phone in her hand for a long time. She did not want to leave Kareem. She did not want to turn their relationship into a test he had to pass. But she was beginning to understand that she could not build a shared future by being the only person willing to describe it.

She packed a small suitcase for Cairo. She did not know what would happen during the weekend, but she knew she could no longer return to Alexandria with

another beautiful apology and another plan that left the central question unanswered.

She would ask once more, if she had to.

Then she would listen to the answer—not only the words Kareem said, but what he was prepared to do with them.

Both of them were preparing to tell the truth. Both were afraid of the moment when the truth would require a decision. Neither understood how much their preparation was becoming another way to delay the thing they needed to do.

He did not understand that Layla was no longer coming to ask for a plan.

She was coming to ask whether they would choose a future together, knowing that it would require sacrifices from both of them.

CHAPTER TEN

Almost Enough

“Sometimes two people reach the same door and discover that love has not taught them how to open it together.”

Layla arrived in Cairo on Friday evening with one suitcase and a sentence she had spent the journey learning how to say without making it sound like a sacrifice.

She wanted a life with Kareem. The permanent role in Alexandria mattered to her, and she did not want to pretend otherwise, but she was willing to return to Cairo if they decided that was the life they wanted to build. They could look for work together. They could talk about the practical details after they had told each other the truth. She was not coming to demand a promise that nothing would go wrong. She was coming to offer him her willingness to face what did.

Kareem was waiting at the station. He had arrived early, bought her water, and checked the arrivals board several times even though he knew the train was on time. When he saw her, he smiled and took her suitcase. She reached for his hand, and for a moment the familiar warmth returned so completely that he almost told himself the decision he had been making all week was unnecessary.

They took a taxi to the hotel where she had booked a room for the weekend. She wanted a place of her own to think if the conversation became difficult. He accepted that without asking what it meant. He had begun to recognize the importance of asking what she meant; he had not yet understood that he could not protect her by deciding the answers in advance.

Before they went to the restaurant, Layla called Mariam.

“Are you there?” her sister asked.

“Yes.”

“Are you going to tell him?”

Layla looked at the suitcase beside the wardrobe. “I'm going to tell him I want to marry him.”

Mariam was quiet for a moment. “Even with everything happening with his father?”

“Especially because everything is happening. I don't want him to think he has to become a different person before I can choose him.”

“You understand that this might be difficult. Not just for a while.”

“I do.” Layla pressed her fingers together. “I know what it is to live with fear in a family. I know what it costs when everyone depends on the person who seems strongest. I'm not naïve, Mariam. I'm saying I want to face it with him, and we can set boundaries as we go. I am not agreeing to disappear into his family's needs. I'm asking him to build a marriage with me.”

“Then tell him that,” Mariam said. “But don't make your willingness into a promise that you will accept anything. You can choose him and still need him to choose you.”

Layla closed her eyes. “I know.”

“Do you?”

She smiled faintly. “I'm trying to.”

When the call ended, Layla sat still for several minutes. She was frightened of the life they might have. She was also frightened of making fear the only voice allowed to speak. She had already lost a father before she understood how much of a future could vanish without warning. She would not ask Kareem to guarantee that nothing would happen to the people they loved. She wanted to know whether he would let her stand beside him when it did.

Across the city, Kareem stood in his apartment with his father's latest prescription and a stack of bills on the table. His father had been home for less than a week. The doctors were satisfied with his recovery, but the instructions were strict, the medication expensive, and the next appointment already written into Kareem's calendar. The money was not catastrophic, but it was not a problem that would disappear once the immediate fear passed. Mahmoud's work would remain interrupted for months. Kareem's family had divided what they could, but he was the one covering the largest part of the monthly shortfall.

His phone rang. Hala wanted to know whether he would come by after dinner. Mahmoud had been tired that afternoon and had refused to rest. She had argued with him, then worried she had made him angry. Kareem said he would come. He listened to his mother become calmer as soon as he had agreed, and he felt the familiar mix of tenderness and resentment: he wanted to be there for her, and he hated that being needed could feel so much like being tied down.

When he ended the call, the note he had written on Wednesday was still on the desk: *I want a life with you. I want to work out how to make it possible.* He could still mean every word. What he no longer knew was whether wanting the life made it fair to ask Layla to live it.

He pictured her in a hospital corridor with her phone in her hand, waiting for news. He pictured her putting aside a meeting because Hala was frightened, learning the difference between a routine follow-up and a real emergency, and becoming the person who could calm everyone else while hiding her own fear. He pictured his mother calling Layla because she could not reach him, and Layla feeling she had no right to say no. He pictured bills arriving in months when one

of them was already exhausted, and the way every plan could become provisional because Mahmoud was unwell again.

He also pictured Layla in Alexandria, working at a desk she had earned, laughing with friends who knew her as more than the person everyone called when something went wrong. She had spent years carrying her family after her father's death. He had watched her begin to build a life in which she could be more than dependable. He did not want the life he brought her into to take that away.

But beneath the fear for her was another fear he did not know how to admit: that she would choose him, that he would accept, and that when the strain eventually hurt her, he would have to face the possibility that his love had not been enough to make the life good. He could not tell where his wish to protect her ended and his terror of failing her began.

He folded the note and put it in a drawer. Then he took his keys and left for the restaurant.

They went to the restaurant where they had celebrated their first month together. It was busier than she remembered. The table near the window was occupied, so the waiter led them to a smaller one beside the wall. Kareem tried to make a joke about the restaurant's declining standards. Layla laughed, but the sound did not settle anything.

They ordered. They spoke about the train, the weather, the manuscript Kareem was editing, and the collection Layla was finishing in Alexandria. Kareem asked about the permanent role. Layla answered honestly. They did everything two people could do to postpone a conversation while remaining technically present for it.

At last, Layla put down her fork.

“I've thought about what happens after the fellowship,” she said.

Kareem felt his chest tighten. “So have I.”

“I don't want us to treat the job in Alexandria as a decision I've made against you. I haven't decided yet. And I don't want you to treat moving as a test of whether you love me.” She took a breath. “I want a life with you. If the job comes through, I'll consider it seriously, but I'm willing to come back to Cairo. We can look for a way to make our work fit. I don't need everything solved tonight. I need us to choose what we want and then face the practical things together.”

For a moment, Kareem could not speak. The sentence was what he had wanted to hear. He had imagined her saying it, had pictured the relief that would

come when he no longer had to wonder whether she would choose him. But now that she was offering him the future, he could see its possible cost with a clarity that felt almost cruel.

“Layla, don't.”

Her expression changed. “Don't what?”

“Don't give up the job because of me. Don't come back to Cairo because you think you have to make this easier.”

“I'm not saying I have to.” Her voice stayed even, though he could hear the hurt beginning. “I'm saying I want to. There is a difference.”

He looked at his hands. He had promised himself he would tell her the truth, and now that the moment had come, he wanted to soften it until it became something less final.

“Something happened with my father,” he said. “I told you about the procedure, but I didn't tell you everything.”

Layla waited.

He told her about the expenses, the income his father would lose during the recovery, the appointments, and the way the family had divided the tasks without being able to divide the worry. He told her that his brother was helping, that his sister was doing what she could, and that no one was abandoning their parents. Still, the family needed more from him than it had before. He had started paying bills he had not expected to carry and making himself available whenever his mother became frightened. The senior role at the publishing house might bring a better salary, but it would also bind him more closely to Cairo at the very moment Layla's life was becoming established in Alexandria.

“I thought it was temporary,” he said. “I keep telling myself it will settle. But even when Baba is better, the fear won't disappear immediately. And I don't know what the next year will look like. I don't know whether we'll have to pay for more treatment, whether he'll be able to return to work, whether my mother will be able to manage without me there as often as she wants me to be.”

Layla's eyes had filled with tears. “Why didn't you tell me all of this?”

“I didn't want you to feel responsible for it.”

“I'm not responsible for it. I'm your partner.”

“You're not my wife yet.” He regretted the words as soon as he heard them, but he continued. “And I can't ask you to become my wife and then discover that this is the life you have to live. I can't ask you to marry into a family that is frightened

and financially strained, where I may have to cancel our plans because someone needs me, where my mother may call you when she can't reach me. I can't promise you a peaceful life."

"You cannot promise anyone a peaceful life," she said. "You can promise to face it with them."

He shook his head. "You have already spent so much of your life being the person everyone depends on. You lost your father, and you had to become strong for your mother and your brother and your sister. I watched you start to build something that belonged to you. I don't want you to marry me and find yourself doing it all over again, only this time you are expected to carry my family, too."

She looked at him as though she could not tell whether she had heard a confession or an insult.

"I am not a child you have to save from knowing what a difficult life looks like," she said.

"I know that."

"Do you? Because I came here to tell you I would stay. I came here knowing your father was ill. I know your family is frightened. I know this may be hard, and I am still here. You keep talking as though my willingness is evidence that I don't understand what I'm choosing."

"It's evidence that you love me," he said. "And that you'll keep choosing me even when it costs you something. That's what I'm afraid of."

"Then be afraid with me." Her voice cracked. "Don't turn your fear into a decision I never got to make."

He looked away. He could hear how it sounded: that he knew what was best for her; that the life he feared would hurt her was a life she had offered to share. He understood that she was not asking him to make everything easy. She was asking him not to withdraw the choice from her. But the image of her slowly becoming responsible for his family had taken hold of him, and he could not make himself release it.

"I don't think I can marry you," he said.

Layla stared at him.

"Are you saying you don't want to marry me?"

"No. I'm saying I can't ask you to live this life."

"That isn't what I asked."

He heard the echo of all the conversations they had struggled to finish. He could explain the bills, the appointments, his mother's fear, the constraints of his job. He could describe each reason carefully enough that it sounded like a conclusion. But none of those details changed what he was doing: he was ending the relationship because he had decided that the price of staying together would be too high for her.

“I've made up my mind,” he said, and the finality of the words frightened him even as he spoke them.

She took her hand off the table.

“So this is a breakup.”

He nodded.

“After everything,” she said, almost too quietly to hear. “After I came here to tell you I would stay. After I told you I was willing to build a life with you even if it wasn't easy. You are leaving me because you think you know what that life would do to me.”

“I am trying to protect you.”

“You don't get to call leaving me a gift.”

The words struck him because some part of him had wanted her to understand the decision as an act of love. He had wanted his motive to make the pain meaningful, perhaps even forgivable. She refused to give him that comfort.

She looked at him. “I know you love me. I just can't spend the rest of my life translating it.”

“Layla—”

“No. You say you're doing this for me, but you never asked me what I would accept. You made a whole future in your head, decided I would be unhappy in it, and then left me for something I have not even had the chance to choose.” Her tears fell now, without restraint. “Maybe you are right about how difficult it could be. Maybe some of your fears will come true. But you have made my willingness irrelevant because you are more frightened of my sacrifice than you are willing to trust my choice.”

He had no answer that could make her wrong. He also could not make himself take the decision back. His father was still recovering. His mother was still afraid. The bills were still on his table. The family needed him, and the future he could offer Layla no longer looked like the peaceful life he had wanted to give her.

“I don't want your life to become this,” he said.

“And I don't want you to decide what my life can be.” She wiped her face. “I would have married you anyway. I would have come home from work and sat with you in the hospital. I would have helped when I could, and I would have told you when it was too much. You don't know whether I would have been able to live with it. You never let us find out.”

He looked at her, and for a moment he wanted to say that he might be wrong. He wanted to promise that they would find boundaries, that he would protect their home from becoming an extension of his mother's fear, that they would make decisions together. But he had spent days convincing himself that he could not promise any of that, and he could not offer the promise now without knowing whether it was courage or panic that made him want to take it back.

“I can't,” he whispered.

Layla looked at him for a long time. She did not tell him he was a good man. She did not tell him he was cruel. She looked as though she was trying to recognize the person who had once told her that most people were temporary and that he hoped she would remain in his life forever.

“I won't thank you for saving me from a life I was willing to choose,” she said.

“I don't expect you to.”

“Then I hope you understand that, from where I'm sitting, you didn't sacrifice yourself for me. You decided my love was not something you could risk accepting.”

He absorbed the words without defending himself. They were not the whole truth, but they were part of it. He had wanted to spare her pain. He had also wanted to avoid the possibility that accepting her love would make him responsible for the life that followed, including every time it became difficult and he could not fix it.

The restaurant continued around them. A waiter set a plate on a nearby table. Someone laughed near the entrance. A glass broke in the kitchen, followed by an apologetic voice and the sound of a broom.

Kareem looked down at his hands. “I don't want to lose you.”

“Then you should have let me choose you.”

He closed his eyes.

They remained at the table for a long time. They spoke about practical matters because practical matters were easier than grief. They discussed the book she had left at his apartment, the remaining weeks of the fellowship, and whether they should contact each other. Layla did not agree that the breakup was

necessary. Kareem did not ask her to agree. They settled only on taking some time apart, because neither could imagine how to leave the restaurant and return to an ordinary conversation.

When they finally left, Kareem walked her to the hotel. At the entrance, she turned toward him.

“I love you,” she said. They had said it before, on an ordinary walk home from work, when the words had felt like the beginning of something. Now they sounded less like a promise than the last truth they could still give each other without changing the decision between them.

“I love you, too.”

She reached for his hand, held it for a few seconds, then let it go. She did not forgive him, and he did not ask her to. For the first time since they had met, Kareem understood that her love could remain real even when she refused to make his decision easier for him.

Layla went inside.

Kareem stood on the pavement until he could no longer see her through the glass doors. He wanted to follow her. He wanted to tell her that he might be wrong, that there was no way to know the cost of the life they had not lived. But he could not promise that the fear would leave him, and he had already made his fear the final authority.

He walked home alone.

In his apartment, he found the notebook she had once borrowed, the book he had bought for her, and the small objects she had left behind during her visits. He sat at his desk and stared at them until the light outside the window changed.

He did not delete her number.

He could not yet imagine a life in which he did.

Across the city, Layla sat on the edge of the hotel bed and cried until she was too tired to continue. She had not stopped loving him. She had not decided that he was a bad man or that their relationship had been a mistake. But she had come to Cairo prepared to choose him, and she was leaving with the knowledge that he had chosen for them both.

Neither slept much that night.

In the morning, Kareem woke with the instinct to check his phone. For a few seconds, he expected to find a message from Layla asking whether they could talk again, whether he had reconsidered, whether there was still something they

could do. The screen showed only a message from his brother about lunch. He put the phone down and stared at the ceiling.

He went to work because it was Monday and work was what he knew how to do when everything else felt unmanageable. He corrected a sentence, answered an email, and sat through a meeting without remembering what had been discussed. At lunch, Hany asked whether he was all right. Kareem said he was tired. Hany looked at him for a moment, then changed the subject without pretending to believe him.

Layla spent the morning in the hotel room packing her bag. She had planned to return to Alexandria that afternoon, but she kept finding reasons not to leave: a message to answer, a cup to wash, a book she wanted to put in the right pocket of her bag. Eventually, she sat on the bed and admitted to herself that she was waiting for Kareem to call.

She wanted him to call. She wanted him to say that he had thought about what she had said, that he had decided to trust her with the truth instead of using it to remove her from his life. She wanted him to ask her to stay—not because she needed him to rescue her from the consequences of the choice, but because she wanted him to let her share it.

He did not call.

She did not call him either.

At the station, when she finally boarded the train, she put her phone in her bag and looked out of the window. Cairo moved away in the same ordinary way it always did. A man crossed the platform carrying two cups of tea. A child waved at someone through the glass. The train gathered speed.

Layla was leaving a city, but the part she was grieving was not the city itself. She was grieving the life she had chosen and the person who had refused to let her choose it with him. She did not know whether Kareem had protected her from a future that would have hurt her or denied them both a future because he could not bear the risk of being wrong.

She could not decide that on the train.

When the train reached Alexandria, Layla did not turn on her phone immediately. She carried her suitcase through the station, found a taxi, and watched the city pass the window without trying to name what she felt. By the time she reached her apartment, the evening had darkened. She set the suitcase beside the door and stood in the living room without turning on the light.

The apartment looked exactly as she had left it. The books remained on their shelves. The plant stood beside the balcony door. The lamp was on the bedside table, its shade still faintly stained. Nothing in the room knew that she had lost the future she had been willing to choose.

She turned on the lamp.

The light fell across the wall, familiar and warm. She remembered Kareem bringing it to her desk in Cairo, how she had teased him about the stain, how pleased he had been when she told him she would keep it. She had thought of the lamp as a small piece of him she could bring to Alexandria without making the move about loss.

Now it felt more complicated. It was still a gift, still an expression of care. It was also evidence that the man who had chosen it for her was no longer someone she could call when she wanted to tell him something about her day.

She sat on the edge of the bed and opened their conversation. Her fingers moved toward the message box before she stopped herself. She wanted to tell him she had arrived. She wanted to say that she was sorry, that she loved him, that she wished he had trusted her enough to let her choose the difficult parts as well as the good ones.

She put the phone down.

Then she picked it up again and typed, *I've arrived safely.*

She stared at the sentence. It was harmless. It did not ask for anything. It was also a way of keeping the door open when they had agreed to close it, at least for a while.

She deleted it.

In Cairo, Kareem sat at his desk with the book Layla had left behind. He opened the cover, saw her handwriting, and thought of sending a photograph to ask whether she wanted him to mail it to her. It was a reasonable question. It was also a question that could wait, and he knew he was searching for a practical reason to reach her because the emotional reason felt too exposed.

He placed the book in a drawer.

He stood there for a while, his hand still on the drawer handle, then called his brother.

His brother answered with the sound of traffic in the background. “Everything all right?”

Kareem almost said yes. The answer rose automatically, so familiar that for a moment he was not sure how to replace it. Then he remembered the restaurant, Layla's face when she told him she would have chosen the difficult life with him, and the fact that he had ended the relationship anyway.

“No,” he said. “Layla and I broke up.”

The traffic noise continued for a moment, then faded as his brother moved somewhere quieter.

“When?”

“Last night.”

His brother did not immediately ask what happened. That kindness made Kareem's throat tighten. He had spent years expecting people to ask the practical question first, then quietly wishing they would ask the emotional one. Now his brother waited, giving him room to say what he needed to say.

“I ended it,” Kareem said. “I thought I was protecting her from what my life has become. I told her about Baba's recovery, the bills, and how much my family needs me. She said she knew it would be hard and that she still wanted to marry me.”

His brother was quiet for a moment. “And what did you say?”

“I told her I couldn't ask her to live that life.”

“Did she ask you to decide what she could live with?”

Kareem looked at the drawer. “No.”

“Did you ask her what she was willing to do?”

“She told me.” His voice faltered. “She told me she would stay.”

His brother exhaled slowly. “Then you didn't protect her from a decision. You protected her from making one. Maybe you have good reasons to be frightened. Maybe the life you're describing really would be hard. But you don't know what the two of you could have made of it, because you decided not to find out.”

Kareem wanted to argue that the bills were real, the appointments were real, and his mother's fear was not something he could resolve with a speech about boundaries. He wanted to say that he had seen what happened when Layla became responsible for the people around her and that he could not stand to be the person who asked her to do it again.

“I know,” he said, though he did not know whether he meant that his brother was right or that he had heard the words.

“You can love her and still make the wrong decision,” his brother said. “And you can be trying to do something kind and still hurt her with it.”

Kareem lowered his head. The answer did not absolve him. It did not make him a villain either. It left him with the uncomfortable possibility that love could be both the reason for his decision and the thing he had failed to trust.

“I don't know what to do now,” he admitted.

“Tonight? Nothing. Eat something if you haven't. Go to bed, even if you don't sleep. Don't call her to make yourself feel better about the decision you made. If you ever talk about it again, you'll need to hear her, not just explain yourself.”

Kareem swallowed. “All right.”

His brother paused. “You can call me, you know. Not because you need me to fix anything. Just call.”

“I will.”

After they hung up, Kareem sat on the sofa in the dark. He wanted to contact Layla more than he had wanted anything in a long time. He wanted to tell her that he was sorry, but he did not know how to apologize without asking her to relieve him of the guilt. He wanted to tell her that he still believed his fear was reasonable, and he knew that saying so would sound like a request for her to validate the choice that had hurt her.

He left the phone on the table and went to bed without sending another message.

The restraint did not feel noble. It felt like standing in a room with a door he desperately wanted to open, knowing that the person on the other side had asked him not to.

Neither knew whether the other had nearly written. Neither knew that, for a few minutes, they had each stood at the same invisible threshold and chosen not to cross it.

They did not contact each other that night.

Neither believed the story was over.

That was why the next part would be so difficult.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Messages We Kept

“Some endings are not endings at first; they are conversations that keep finding reasons to continue.”

For nine days after the breakup, Kareem did not contact Layla.

He opened their conversation repeatedly, read old messages, and closed the application without typing anything. They had agreed to take some time apart, but Layla had not asked to end the relationship, and he could not stop hearing the difference. He wanted to respect the space they had agreed to. He also wanted to hear her voice so badly that the simplest tasks began to feel like obstacles placed between him and a person who had once been only a call away.

He went to work. He answered emails. He visited his brother and played with his niece. He called his father on Sunday, and for the first time in years, he told Mahmoud that he had been having a difficult time.

His father said, “I'm sorry.” The words sounded sincere enough, but Mahmoud did not ask what was wrong. He waited a moment, then glanced back at the television as though he believed Kareem would continue if he needed to.

Kareem told him that he and Layla had separated. Mahmoud looked at him, then gave a small nod. He did not ask what had happened or how Kareem was managing. After a brief silence, he asked whether Kareem had checked the car's insurance, which was due for renewal that month.

Kareem could have stopped there. Instead, he continued, as though the words might make a place for themselves if he gave them enough air.

“I ended it,” he said. “I thought I was protecting her from everything happening here. She told me she was willing to stay, but I couldn't bear the thought of her losing the life she'd built because my family needed me.”

His father remained quiet. It was not the silence of someone considering how to respond; it was the silence of someone who did not know what to do with a feeling that had no practical solution. After a moment, Mahmoud returned to the question about the insurance.

Kareem said he would look at it. He was good at being useful. He was less sure how to remain in a conversation in which the thing he needed was not a task, an answer, or a promise, but simply a little curiosity about what hurt.

He had managed to say the truth aloud, and he was glad he had not hidden it. But it had not become a conversation. He wished he had learned how to tell his father more years ago, then understood that the wish could not make Mahmoud into someone who knew how to receive it.

On the tenth day, Layla sent a message.

I found the book you left in my apartment. Would you like me to send it to you?

Kareem stared at the screen for a long time.

He could have said yes and provided an address. He could have asked her to leave it with the building manager. He could have chosen the cleanest, most practical way to return an object that belonged to him.

Instead, he wrote:

You can keep it for now. I don't need it urgently.

Her reply came a few minutes later.

All right.

He looked at the message, then typed another.

How are you?

He nearly deleted it. He knew the question was not neutral. It was a door, and he was asking whether she might be willing to open it.

He sent it anyway.

Layla answered after several minutes.

I'm managing. Work is busy. I miss you.

Kareem felt the sentence move through him like pain and relief at once.

He typed, *I miss you, too.*

Then they began talking.

At first, the conversations were careful. They discussed the book, the weather, the collection she was finishing, and a family dinner Kareem had attended. They did not talk about the breakup. They did not discuss whether they should remain in contact. They did not ask what the messages meant.

They told themselves they were being kind to each other.

In truth, neither was ready to stop.

The messages became more frequent. A photograph of the sea. A sentence from a book. A question about the author's name they had once argued over. A memory that appeared unexpectedly and demanded to be shared with the only person who would understand why it mattered.

They began calling again, first for a few minutes, then for longer. Layla told Kareem about a difficult meeting. Kareem told her that his brother had invited him to spend a weekend at the coast with the family. They laughed, and for stretches of time the relationship returned in the form that had always been easiest for them: two people who knew each other's minds, who could make each other laugh, who wanted to hear what the other person had to say.

It was comforting.

It was also dangerous.

They had ended the relationship because Kareem had decided that a life with him would ask too much of Layla. She had never agreed with his calculation. Now they were recreating their intimacy without resolving the argument at its centre: he still feared that accepting her choice would make him responsible for the pain his family might bring into her life, while she still believed he had denied her the right to choose that life for herself. They could share their days without deciding where they stood. They could miss each other without asking whether missing was leading anywhere. They could offer affection without making a plan.

For a while, the arrangement felt like a gift.

Then it began to hurt again.

Kareem would hear Layla's voice and imagine that they might find their way back to each other. He would start to say something about the future, then remember that they were no longer together and stop. Layla would hear the hesitation and feel the old uncertainty return. She wanted to ask what he meant, whether he was thinking about trying again, but she feared that doing so would turn the fragile connection into another difficult conversation.

They were back where they had been, except now they had lost the right to assume the other person would stay.

Kareem's next birthday, the first since their breakup, came in the middle of the first month of secret contact. Layla had set a reminder on her phone weeks earlier, back when they were still together, and had never removed it. When the notification appeared, she stared at it for several minutes before sending a message.

Happy birthday, Kareem. I hope this year is kind to you.

She considered adding a joke about his age, then decided against it. She did not want the message to sound so familiar that it pretended nothing had changed. She also did not want it to sound so formal that it denied the history between them.

He replied almost immediately.

Thank you. I hoped you'd remember.

The sentence made her chest tighten. She had remembered because birthdays had mattered to them, because she knew the date without checking, because she still thought of his life as something she wanted to celebrate. She wrote back that of course she had remembered.

That evening, he called.

“Is this allowed?” Layla asked when she answered.

“I don't know,” he said. “I thought I'd ask you in person, but apparently we live in different cities.”

She laughed despite herself. “That's an inconvenient detail.”

They spoke for nearly an hour. Kareem told her about a dinner his brother had arranged, and Layla asked whether his niece had insisted on choosing the cake. He said she had demanded a cake with a giraffe on it, which had caused a dispute with the bakery because the baker had apparently interpreted “giraffe” as “horse with a long neck.” Layla laughed until she had to wipe her eyes.

For a moment, the call felt like the old relationship. They knew how to make each other laugh. They knew the stories that mattered, the details that would have been unremarkable to anyone else, the exact tone that could turn a bad day into something survivable.

Then Kareem grew quiet.

“What?” Layla asked.

“Nothing.”

She could hear the old pattern arriving, even now, when they had no formal relationship to protect. She could have asked him what he was feeling. She could have waited for him to tell her. Instead, she tried to make the conversation lighter.

“Are you getting sentimental because you're older?”

He laughed, but the silence remained underneath it.

“I wish things were different,” he said finally.

Layla looked toward the window.

“So do I.”

He took a breath. “Sometimes I think we could do it differently now.”

Her heart moved before she could stop it. She wanted him to continue. She wanted him to say that he had thought about what he would change, that he had found a way to act before the fear made decisions for him, that the relationship they might build now would not simply be the old one with better explanations.

Instead, he said, “I don't know.”

Layla closed her eyes.

They were no longer together, and still she was waiting for him to finish a sentence.

“It's all right,” she said, though it was not entirely all right. “We don't have to decide anything tonight.”

Kareem knew that he had let the moment pass. He also knew that he had not been ready to make the promise she was silently hoping to hear. He feared offering another future he could not sustain, and the fear had kept him from saying whether he wanted to try.

They wished each other goodnight. Layla sent him a message the next morning thanking him for the call. Kareem replied with a joke about the giraffe cake, and the conversation returned to ordinary things.

For the next few days, they spoke more often than they had the week before. Their messages were affectionate, playful, and almost indistinguishable from the ones they had exchanged during the relationship. When Layla had a difficult afternoon, Kareem was the first person she thought of calling. When Kareem found a passage in a book that made him think of her, he sent it without considering whether he should.

Neither asked what the birthday call had meant.

They were afraid that naming the hope would force them to decide whether it could be trusted. They preferred the warmth of uncertainty to the pain of a clear answer.

But the contact was changing what the breakup had been supposed to do. They had ended the relationship because they needed space to live without the same repeated injuries. Now they were keeping the intimacy while postponing the decision about whether they were willing to return to it. They were asking each other to remain emotionally available without giving each other the security of a shared commitment.

They did not think of it in those terms. They thought of it as kindness, as friendship, as a way to preserve something good after the relationship had ended.

It was all of those things.

It was also keeping them from letting go.

The first month of secret contact changed the shape of Kareem's days in ways he did not want to examine. He no longer woke expecting to call Layla before work, but he had begun checking his phone before he got out of bed. He did not plan his evenings around her, but he felt a small lift whenever a message appeared. He had told himself that they were only keeping in touch because the

breakup had not erased their affection. It was true. It was also a way of avoiding the fact that their affection continued to ask something of them.

One Friday, Layla sent him a photograph of the small table she had bought for her apartment. The surface was still scratched, but she had placed a vase on it and arranged two books beside the vase. The picture was ordinary, almost deliberately so.

It looks like a home now, she wrote.

Kareem stared at the photograph. He was pleased to see the apartment taking shape around her. He was also aware that he had not been invited into the decision to arrange it, and that he no longer had a claim to be included in the ordinary details of her life.

It looks like you, he replied.

She sent a heart.

The exchange should have ended there. Instead, he asked what she had been reading, and she told him about the book. They talked for nearly an hour, sharing opinions and jokes as though the relationship were only temporarily interrupted. When the call ended, Kareem sat with the phone in his hand and felt a sharp, familiar emptiness.

He wanted to ask her to try again.

He did not.

He told himself that he was respecting her decision, that he had no right to ask her to reconsider until he was certain he could offer something different. He believed both things. But another part of him was afraid that if he asked and she said no, he would lose even the fragile intimacy they still had.

The next week, Layla had a difficult day at work. An author rejected several edits, and Salwa asked her to reconsider the order of a collection that had occupied her for months. Layla spent the afternoon at her desk, trying to understand whether the criticism pointed to a real weakness in the work or simply the author's discomfort with being challenged.

She could have called a colleague. She could have spoken to Salwa again. Instead, she opened Kareem's contact and stared at his name.

She knew what she was doing. She was reaching for the person who had once been her first call, the person who could make her laugh and help her see a problem from another angle. It was not wrong to want that. It was also not neutral. Every conversation made it harder to accept that the relationship had ended.

She called him anyway.

Kareem answered warmly. He listened while she described the meeting and asked questions that helped her clarify what she thought. When she began to criticize herself for missing an inconsistency, he reminded her that noticing the problem now was part of the work, not proof that she should never have been trusted with it.

“You still know how to make me feel better,” she said.

He was quiet for a moment. “I wish I knew how to make things better in a more permanent way.”

Layla closed her eyes.

She wanted to ask what he meant. She wanted to know whether he was finally prepared to try again, whether the conversations they were having were leading toward anything, whether the months apart had given him a clearer understanding of what he could change.

Instead, she said, “I should get back to work.”

They said goodbye.

Afterward, Kareem felt ashamed of having spoken ambiguously. He had wanted to tell her that he still loved her and that he was beginning to understand the things he had done wrong. But he had not asked her to return, because he did not know whether he could sustain the change he wanted to promise.

He was still protecting himself from a clear answer.

Weeks passed. Their messages became more frequent. They shared photographs of books, snippets of family conversations, and small complaints about work. Sometimes they called for a few minutes; sometimes the conversations stretched late into the night. They did not make plans to visit one another. They did not define the relationship. They simply kept returning to the familiarity of being known.

Layla tried to make her days belong to the life she was building in Alexandria. She put more care into her work, accepted responsibility for a new part of the collection, and began setting limits with her family without explaining every decision. She met Dalia for coffee, walked by the sea without turning every beautiful view into a photograph to send Kareem, and learned that an experience could matter even when he did not know about it.

Still, when something good happened, he was the person she wanted to tell. When something hurt, she could hear the answer he might give. She was not

waiting idly for him to return; she was trying to teach herself how to live without arranging the day around whether he might.

Kareem, meanwhile, wanted to ask her to try again. He had begun to understand how often he used uncertainty as a reason to avoid making a choice, but he was afraid that recognizing the pattern did not mean he had changed it. He did not know how to ask her to trust a new promise without evidence that he could keep it. He told himself that this caution was respect. Sometimes it was. Sometimes it was fear wearing a more generous name.

The first weeks of secret contact were almost gentle. Kareem and Layla did not speak about getting back together. They sent each other things they would once have shared without thinking: a line from a book, a photograph of the sea, a complaint about work. The messages were small enough to seem harmless, and the affection beneath them was familiar enough to feel like relief.

One night, Layla called Kareem because she could not sleep. She had received a difficult email from an author and was worried that she had mishandled the project. She had already spoken with Salwa and knew what she needed to do the next morning, but she wanted to hear a voice that knew her before the fellowship, before the job title, before she had learned to stand her ground in a room full of people who disagreed with her.

Kareem listened. He asked what had happened, and when she began to explain, he did not interrupt with a solution. He told her that he knew how hard she worked and that a difficult email did not erase what she had done well. She laughed at one of his jokes, then fell quiet.

“I miss talking to you like this,” she said.

“Me too.”

For a moment, they were back in the relationship they had lost, speaking with the ease that had first drawn them together. Kareem wanted to ask whether they should try again. Layla wanted him to ask. Neither did.

They said goodnight, and Layla lay awake for another hour, wondering whether the call meant something had changed or whether it had only reminded them of what they still missed.

The next afternoon, she sent Kareem a message.

I think we should take a little space again. Not because I don't want to talk to you. Because I do, and I think that's the problem.

He read it while sitting at his desk. He understood what she meant, and the understanding hurt. He typed a reply, deleted it, then wrote that he agreed. They

could stop messaging for a while and see whether the silence helped them settle into their separate lives.

They did not say how long the pause would last.

For four days, neither contacted the other. Kareem went to work, visited his brother, and spent a Saturday afternoon with his niece. Layla finished the revisions on her collection, met Dalia for coffee, and tried to make her evenings belong to the life she was building rather than the one she had lost. Both checked their phones more often than they wanted to admit.

On the fifth day, Kareem received a message from his brother with a photograph of his niece holding a drawing. The child had drawn a crooked house with a long-necked giraffe in the doorway. Kareem stared at the picture, then remembered the afternoon Layla had helped his niece build the giraffe's house from wooden blocks. He almost sent the image to her. The habit was so immediate that he had typed her name before remembering the agreement.

He closed the conversation.

An hour later, Layla saw a book in the window of a shop near work, an old collection of stories that reminded her of the first one they had bought together. She did not take a photograph. She walked past the shop, turned at the next corner, and found herself wishing that Kareem could have been there to tell her why the cover was terrible.

The silence was doing what they had asked it to do. It was making them feel the full absence of the relationship without allowing them to soothe it through a message. It was also making them realize how deeply the relationship had entered their ordinary habits.

On the eighth day, Kareem's father called to tell him that a follow-up appointment had been moved. The conversation was brief, but it left Kareem unexpectedly unsettled. He had tried to explain something to Mahmoud the week before, and his father had changed the subject. Kareem had driven home feeling angry and ashamed, then spent the evening trying to convince himself that the exchange did not matter.

His first impulse was to call Layla.

He sat with the phone in his hand for several minutes. He could tell her what had happened. She would understand why it hurt. She might say something that made the feeling less lonely. He would feel better, at least for a while.

He could also leave the feeling where it was and learn to carry it without making her responsible for helping him process it. That was one of the reasons

they had ended the relationship. They had needed space to find out what remained of themselves when the other person was not immediately available.

He did not call.

The following morning, Layla sent him a photograph of the sea. It was not a deliberate decision to break the silence. She had taken the picture while walking to work and had nearly deleted it before sending it. When he replied, *Beautiful*, she felt the familiar relief of being understood. The pause ended without either of them deciding that it had ended.

They told themselves they had simply shared a moment. They did not ask whether sharing the moment had undone the work of the previous eight days.

A few weeks later, Kareem had a difficult day with his father. Mahmoud had made a dismissive remark about his work, and Kareem had answered more sharply than he intended. They ended the conversation without resolving it. Kareem sat in his car outside his apartment and found himself opening Layla's contact before he could stop himself.

He called her.

She answered warmly. He told her what had happened, and for the first time in years he described his feelings without trying to make them sound reasonable. He admitted that he was hurt, angry, and ashamed of how much he still wanted his father's approval. Layla listened, then said, “You don't have to earn the right to be upset about that.”

He felt the old relief of being understood.

After they ended the call, he sat quietly in the car and wondered why he had been able to speak so freely now, after they were no longer together, when he had struggled so much while they were trying to build a life.

The answer frightened him. It was easier to be honest when he no longer had to negotiate a future around the honesty. The consequences were smaller; he could tell Layla what he felt without having to decide what it meant for their next year, their work, or the distance between their homes.

He wanted that ease to mean they could be together again.

He did not yet understand that the ease came, in part, from no longer asking the relationship to carry the future. His publishing house was attending a small book event, and he had volunteered to help coordinate the meeting with the local team. He knew Layla would be there. He told himself he had not chosen the trip because of her, although he had checked the dates before accepting.

The train journey gave him too much time to reconsider the story he had told himself about coming. He had a legitimate reason to attend: the event involved a publisher whose catalog his office had been tracking, and he was expected to meet two editors about a possible collaboration. He had prepared questions, printed the schedule, and packed a notebook. He could have made the trip without thinking about Layla at all.

He had thought about her before booking the ticket.

He had checked the event date, noticed that she was listed among the editorial team, and accepted the assignment before allowing himself to examine why the detail had pleased him. He told himself that working in the same city for one afternoon was not the same as seeking her out. He told himself that he might not even see her. He told himself several things that were technically true and incomplete enough to be useful.

At the venue, a converted building near the waterfront, Kareem spent the first hour speaking with the editors he had come to meet. They discussed the market for translated fiction, the cost of printing, and the difficulties of discovering new writers without overwhelming a small editorial team. Kareem asked questions and took notes. He was interested in the work. He was not pretending that the work was unimportant simply because another reason for being there had traveled with him.

Then Layla crossed the room carrying a stack of programs.

She was speaking to a young editor who looked nervous about an upcoming panel. Layla listened, then pointed to a passage in the program and explained how she would introduce the author. The young editor nodded, visibly relieved. Layla made a joke, and the woman laughed.

Kareem stood near the back of the room and watched.

He had known Layla was good at her job. He had watched her manage difficult authors in Cairo and lead a presentation in Alexandria. But seeing her here, in a room where people turned to her because they trusted her judgment, made her feel both familiar and newly distant. She had become someone whose confidence had a history he had not witnessed. He could see the shape of the life she had built, but he did not know all its small details.

He felt proud of her. He also felt the ache of being outside it.

The two feelings arrived together, and for a moment he could not make one cancel the other. He was no longer asking her to be less successful. He was not

even wishing he had been there for every part of it. He simply wished he knew how to be included in a life that had continued to grow without him.

Layla looked up and saw him.

For a moment, neither moved. Then she smiled, and he felt the same sudden warmth he had felt at the station when she arrived in Cairo, the relief of being recognized by someone who knew more than the version of him he could present to strangers.

She returned to the young editor, finished the conversation, and crossed the room.

"Kareem."

"Layla."

They both laughed softly at the formality of the greeting.

"I didn't know you were coming," she said.

"It was a late decision. Work-related." He heard how quickly he had added the explanation and felt embarrassed by it. "I did want to see you, though."

Her expression changed. It was not quite surprise and not quite relief. "I'm glad you did."

He wanted to ask how she was, whether she had been happy, whether she still thought about them. Instead, he looked at the program in her hand.

"You're busy."

"A little. The next panel starts in twenty minutes. Can you stay?"

"Yes."

She smiled and pointed him toward a seat near the aisle. "I'll find you afterward."

He watched her return to the work, then sat down. The event continued around him. Authors spoke about memory and place, about what a book could hold and what it had to leave unsaid. Kareem listened, took notes, and tried not to turn each reference to absence into a private message. He was there to work. He was there because he wanted to see Layla. Both things were true.

For once, he did not make himself choose only one.

When the event ended, Kareem waited until Layla had finished speaking with Salwa before approaching her. For a moment, neither spoke. Then Layla smiled, and he felt the familiar warmth of being recognized by someone who knew the person he was trying to become.

“Hello,” she said.

“Hello.”

They went for a walk by the sea.

The conversation was easy at first. They talked about work, the book event, and the city. They remembered the first time Kareem had come to help her view apartments, and she laughed at the lamp he had bought her. They spoke about the past without pretending it had not happened.

Eventually, the conversation moved toward the relationship.

“I still think about us,” Layla said.

Kareem looked at her.

“So do I.”

“I don't know what to do with that.”

He took a breath. He had prepared for this conversation, in fragments, during the train journey and the long walk to the event. He had imagined saying that he still loved her, that he was beginning to understand how fear had made him call a decision protection, and that he wanted another chance to build a life in which he would let her choose alongside him. He was not certain that he could yet promise the change the words implied.

He had also imagined her saying no.

“I think I made a mistake,” he said.

Layla stopped walking.

“What do you mean?”

“I told myself I was protecting you. I thought that if I ended it before you became responsible for my family, I could spare you the years of worry I could already see coming. But I made that decision without you. You told me you were willing to stay, and I treated your willingness as proof that you didn't understand the cost.”

She looked at him, her face carefully still.

“I wanted you to let me choose while we were together.”

“I know.”

“You could have told me everything. You could have said your father might need you for months, that money was frightening, that your mother was depending on you. I wasn't asking you to promise me a quiet life. I was asking you to trust me enough to let me decide whether I wanted it with you.”

“I know.”

He stopped, aware that every answer sounded like an admission made after the consequences had already arrived.

“I love you,” he said. “I still love you. I don't think I've stopped for a single day.”

Layla's eyes filled with tears.

She had wanted to hear him say them when they were deciding what their future might look like—not only on the pavement after he had already chosen to leave. She had wanted his love to arrive beside a willingness to try, when she was waiting to know whether the relationship had a place in his plans. Now the words were true, but they could not become the decision she had once needed them to accompany.

Now they were standing beside the sea, both of them changed by the absence they had chosen.

“I love you, too,” she said.

He closed his eyes briefly.

“Then perhaps we can try again.”

Layla looked out at the water.

For several seconds, she imagined it. They could start over. They could make a plan, speak more honestly, return to the problems that had separated them with new understanding. They still loved each other. They were still able to make each other laugh. They still wanted to share their lives.

But she remembered the night he had called his decision protection and left her with no part in it. She remembered that his fears were not imaginary; the family crisis was real, and life with him might have been hard. What she could not accept was that he had treated the possibility of hardship as an answer she was not allowed to give.

“I don't know if we can,” she said.

Kareem nodded, though the words felt like a door closing.

“I understand.”

She turned toward him.

“Do you?”

He looked at her, and this time he did not answer quickly.

“I think I understand why you don't trust it,” he said. “I know I have told you things too late. I know I have understood what I should have done after you were already hurt. I want to believe that I can do better, but I don't want to ask you to build your life around the possibility that I will.”

Layla began to cry.

He reached for her hand, and she let him take it.

They stood beside the water, holding hands without pretending that the gesture meant they had found a way back.

For a while, they were simply two people who loved one another and had no idea what to do with the love that remained.

They spent the rest of the afternoon together. They ate dinner, walked through the city, and sat in a café near the waterfront until the evening had grown late. Kareem accompanied her to the entrance of her building, then took a taxi back to his hotel. They held hands briefly before parting, neither pretending that the contact had changed what they still needed to decide.

Neither called it a mistake.

Neither called it a reconciliation.

They continued messaging after he returned to Cairo. The contact became more intimate again, then less frequent, then intimate once more. They told themselves they were being careful. They avoided asking what the arrangement meant, because they were afraid that naming it would force them to decide whether to keep it.

They were no longer a couple, but they were not free of each other.

One night, after weeks of messages, Layla sent Kareem a photograph of the bookshop where they had once bought her father's old collection of stories. He answered with a memory of the day they had found the notebook. She told him that she still kept it beside her bed, though she had stopped reading it every night.

They began talking about the things they remembered: the first walks, the bad coffee, the sentence they had argued about, the old film that had made them argue about caution and cowardice. The memories came easily, and for a while they were able to speak about the relationship without the pain of its ending pressing directly against them.

Then Kareem said, “I keep thinking about what I would do differently if we had another chance.”

Layla's fingers tightened around her phone.

“Do you?”

“Yes. I think I understand some things now that I didn't understand then.”

She wanted him to continue. She wanted him to tell her that the understanding was new, that he had not simply learned to describe the same problem more clearly. She wanted to believe that they could use the months apart to build something different.

Instead, she asked, “Do you think we should try again?”

He was silent long enough for her to know that the answer frightened him.

“I think about it,” he said. “I don't know if I can promise that I won't hurt you in the same ways.”

She closed her eyes.

“Neither of us can promise that.”

“I know.”

“Then what are we doing?”

He had no answer. They stayed on the call for another half hour, talking about ordinary things until the conversation seemed safe again. When they hung up, Layla felt both comforted and bereft. She had heard the man she loved, but she had not heard a decision.

The next morning, she promised herself she would not be the first to message him. She wanted to see whether he would reach for her without being prompted. She lasted until the evening, when a small thing happened at work and she instinctively wanted to tell him.

She sent the message.

Kareem answered warmly, and they talked for an hour.

Afterward, she sat at the kitchen table and cried, not because he had been unkind but because he had been kind enough to keep her hoping and careful enough never to ask what hope was doing to them.

Kareem, in Cairo, read the conversation again before going to bed. He wanted to write that he loved her, that he still wanted a life with her, and that he was ready to try differently. But he was frightened of offering another promise he might not know how to keep. His father was recovering, but the appointments and bills remained; Hala still called him first when she was afraid. He did not know how to promise Layla a life in which those demands would not reach into

their home. He also knew that she had never asked him for such a promise. She had asked him to let her help decide what their life could hold.

They had not learned how to let go.

And because they still loved one another, they could not yet understand that the tenderness they kept returning to was preventing them from healing.

CHAPTER TWELVE

What Remains

“Some people leave your life once; others must leave it every time you remember how to reach for them.”

The final conversation began with a photograph of the sea.

Layla sent it to Kareem on a Sunday afternoon, when the light was pale and the water looked almost silver. She had taken the photograph from the same stretch of the Corniche where they had once spoken about the future, and she had nearly deleted it before sending it. There was nothing unusual in the picture. A few boats were visible in the distance, and the wind had roughened the surface of the water.

But Kareem knew the place.

He replied, *Beautiful.*

Layla stared at the word, then wrote:

I thought you'd like it.

He sent a heart.

They had been in contact for nearly six months after the breakup. The pattern had become familiar: a message sent for a practical reason, a joke, a question about work, and then a conversation that lasted longer than either had planned. Some weeks they spoke every day. Other weeks they barely spoke at all. Each time they grew distant, one of them found a reason to return.

They had stopped pretending the contact was entirely innocent. They knew they were keeping one another close because the idea of complete separation felt unbearable. They also knew the closeness was preventing either of them from building a life that did not revolve around the possibility of returning to the relationship.

Layla tried to give the rest of her life the attention it deserved. She put more care into her work, accepted projects that frightened her a little, and learned to spend an evening alone without treating the quiet as a problem she had to solve. She became more deliberate about the responsibilities she carried for her family. When Youssef asked her to fix something he could do himself, she asked him to try first. When Nadia called with a worry, Layla listened without automatically promising to take over. These were small changes, but each one made room for a version of herself who could be loving without being indispensable.

Kareem, in Cairo, tried to put the same effort into the life that remained around him. He helped his father through the appointments, sent money when the bills exceeded what his parents could manage, and worked toward the senior editorial role he had once doubted he would earn. He did not know how to separate missing Layla from the hope that one day he might find a way to explain

himself better. He was learning that the two feelings could exist together without requiring him to act on them.

But neither could continue asking the other to remain emotionally available while offering no shared future in return.

They knew this.

They kept messaging anyway.

In the weeks before the final conversation, Layla began to notice how thoroughly the messages with Kareem still shaped her days. If something funny happened at work, she saved it for him. When a project went well, she imagined how he would understand the effort behind it. When a conversation between them ended warmly, she spent the next hour both comforted and unsettled, as though the warmth had reopened a door neither could walk through.

One evening, Dalia found her sitting on the balcony with her phone face down beside her. They had become friends during the fellowship, and Dalia had learned that Layla could describe a problem for an hour without admitting when it had become painful.

“Did talking to him make you feel better?” Dalia asked.

“For the time we were talking.” Layla looked at the dark screen. “Then I had to come back to the rest of my life.”

“Do you think you are waiting for him?”

Layla was quiet for a long time. “Sometimes I think of all the ways to lose someone, and I wonder whether death is the gentlest. At least it closes the door. The living can leave it ajar, and hope keeps you waiting outside.”

Dalia turned toward her. “You don't really think death is gentle.”

“No.” Layla swallowed. “I know what it takes. I don't mean it isn't devastating. I mean death doesn't leave you wondering whether one more conversation, one better season, one different choice might bring the person back. When someone is alive and still loves you, hope can make possibility look like permission to keep waiting.”

Dalia did not rush to correct her. “And do you want him to come back?”

“I want him to want to build a life with me. I don't want to keep living inside the possibility that he might.” Layla rubbed her palms together, trying to warm them. “I can understand why he was afraid. I can even understand why he thought he was protecting me. But I can't keep treating his fear as a promise that one day he'll be ready.”

Dalia put her hand over Layla's for a moment. “You don't have to stop loving him tonight. You only have to stop letting the hope make every decision for you.”

Layla nodded, though the answer would take longer to live than to hear.

In Cairo, Kareem was having a similar realization, though it arrived through a different door. His niece had asked whether Layla would visit again. She had remembered the woman who helped her build the giraffe's house, and she wanted to show Layla a drawing she had made at nursery.

Kareem had said, “Maybe one day.”

His niece looked at him. “Why not now?”

He did not know how to answer a child who assumed that people who loved each other could simply decide to be in the same room.

That evening, he opened his messages and found a photograph Layla had sent him earlier in the week. It showed a page from the book he had bought her, with one sentence underlined. He had replied with a joke, and she had sent a laughing face. The exchange looked harmless. It was also the latest in a string of conversations that gave him the comfort of a relationship without the responsibility of choosing one.

He thought about his brother's advice: tell her what you want, and let her tell you what she wants. At the restaurant, he had finally told her what he feared, but he had not let that conversation become a choice they made together. He had explained the problem and announced the conclusion in the same breath. Since then, he had held on to the contact because it allowed him to feel that he had not lost her completely. He had not asked whether keeping that door half-open was helping either of them live.

He knew he still wanted Layla. He also knew that wanting her was not a plan. He could not ask her to remain available while he continued to be afraid of what a future with her would require. If he wanted to try again, he would have to say so plainly and accept that she might refuse. If he was not prepared to make that request, he had to stop using their affection as a substitute for a decision.

The thought frightened him enough that he spent most of the evening doing housework he had neglected. He washed dishes, folded laundry, and reorganized a shelf that did not need reorganizing. When he finally sat down, he did not send a message.

For several days, neither of them reached out.

Then, on a Sunday afternoon, Layla walked along the Corniche and took a photograph of the sea. The light was pale, the water almost silver, and a few

boats moved slowly in the distance. She had taken photographs from that same place many times, but this one reminded her of the afternoon she and Kareem had spoken about the future before she knew how complicated it would become.

She looked at the photograph for a long time.

She could have kept it. She could have sent it to Mariam or saved it for herself. Instead, she opened Kareem's conversation.

She did not send it because she wanted to restart the cycle. She sent it because he had been part of the memory, and she did not know how to pretend that he had not.

She knew that one message could become another month of contact. She knew it could reopen hope. She also knew she was tired of leaving the truth unspoken simply because the truth hurt.

She sent the photograph.

That was where the final conversation began.

On that Sunday afternoon, Layla was sitting at her kitchen table when Kareem sent a question.

Can we talk properly? Not over messages.

She looked at it for a long time. For months, their messages had allowed them to approach the truth without having to remain inside it. She knew what he was asking, and she knew she could not keep doing this through a screen.

She had a work meeting scheduled in Cairo later that week. After a long pause, she replied:

I'm in Cairo on Thursday. We can meet then, if you still want to.

I do.

They chose a coffee shop a few streets from the publishing house where they had first met. It was public, quiet, and familiar enough that neither had to pretend they were strangers, but not so full of memories that it belonged to the beginning of their relationship. Kareem arrived early. He ordered two coffees, then let his own grow cold while he watched the door.

When Layla came in, he stood. For a moment, they both seemed unsure whether the old habits of greeting should still apply. They exchanged a small, careful smile and sat down. No embrace could have made the conversation easier, and neither asked the other to offer one.

For the first few minutes, they spoke about ordinary things. Kareem asked how work was going. Layla told him about the collection she had just finished

editing. He described a manuscript he was struggling with, and she offered a suggestion that made him laugh. The conversation had the familiar rhythm of two people who knew each other's minds, who could move from a joke to an important question without needing to explain the transition.

Then Kareem took a breath.

“I've been thinking about us.”

Layla lowered her eyes to the cup.

“I know.”

“I don't think we can keep doing this.”

She was quiet for a moment.

“Neither do I.”

The agreement surprised them both. They had spent months avoiding the sentence, hoping that the contact might somehow become something less painful without requiring either of them to give it up. Now the words had arrived, and neither could pretend not to understand them.

Kareem continued. “Every time we talk, I start hoping we'll find a way back to each other. We have a good conversation, and for a little while I think perhaps we can. Then we reach the same place again. We miss each other, but we don't decide anything.”

Layla looked at the window. Outside, the afternoon traffic moved in a slow, bright line along the street.

“I do the same thing,” she said. “I tell myself I'm only answering a message or checking how you're doing. Then we talk, and for a while I forget why we ended things. I start imagining what it would be like if we tried again.”

He was quiet.

“Do you ever think about trying again?” he asked.

She swallowed. “Yes.”

He looked at his hands. “Me too.”

For several seconds, neither spoke.

The truth was so simple that it seemed impossible to understand why they could not act on it. They loved each other. They missed each other. They could still talk for hours, still make each other laugh, still recognize the small details that made the other's life feel familiar.

They could also remember the relationship they had lived inside. They remembered the conversations that had gone nowhere, the promises that had been sincere but insufficient, and the silences that had made every difficult moment feel larger than it needed to be. They remembered the family crisis that had frightened Kareem and the future he had imagined for Layla without allowing her to help shape it. They remembered how hard he had tried to keep the relationship going, how she had tried to show him she was willing to stay, and how their fears had turned those efforts into another way of hurting each other.

“I don't think love is the problem,” Layla said.

Kareem looked at her. “I know.”

“I think that's why this is so difficult. If we stopped loving each other, it would be easier to understand why we can't be together.”

He nodded.

“I keep thinking that if I'd said things sooner, if I'd been more honest, if I'd trusted you with what I was afraid of—”

“Kareem.”

He stopped.

“I know there are things we both wish we'd done differently,” she said. “I wish I'd been able to hear how frightened you were without feeling that you were already leaving me. But I wish you had trusted me enough to tell me the truth and let me choose. I could understand why you were afraid. I still don't agree that it was yours to decide what I could bear.”

She took a breath.

“But I can't keep living inside all the things we might have done differently. I have to live with what we actually did.”

Kareem felt the sentence settle into him. He had spent months imagining alternative versions of their relationship: the words he could have said, the truth he could have shared, the moment when he might have trusted her with his fear instead of deciding for her. He had imagined those possibilities as doors that might still open if he found the right way to describe them.

Layla was telling him they were possibilities, not a life they could return to.

“I don't want you to think I regret loving you,” she said.

“I don't regret loving you either.”

Her eyes filled with tears. She looked down at the table until she could speak again.

“I don't know how to stop wanting you to call me when something happens.”

“I don't know how to stop wanting to tell you.”

“Then we have to stop giving that feeling somewhere to go.”

He knew what she meant. “I think we need to stop for good.”

She nodded slowly, though the movement seemed to cost her something. “I don't know how to do that.”

“Neither do I.”

“I still don't agree with what you did.”

“I know.”

“I understand why you were afraid. I can even understand why you thought you were protecting me. But I can't keep treating your fear as a promise that one day you'll be ready to let me choose.”

He did not defend himself. He had no right to ask her to make his decision easier by seeing it only as he had intended it. He had wanted to spare her pain. He had also wanted to avoid the possibility that accepting her love would make him responsible for a future he could not control. Both things were true, and neither could erase the other.

They sat for a long time, speaking about what they would miss: the ordinary messages, the jokes, the small discoveries, the feeling of being known by someone who had been there for the beginnings of their adult lives. They talked about the ways they had hurt each other, not to assign blame but to acknowledge what had happened. They admitted that they still wanted to try again, and that wanting was not the same as knowing how to build something different.

There were no accusations left that either could use to make the decision easier.

Layla had not been unloving. Kareem had not been indifferent. They had made choices out of fear, habits out of old wounds, and explanations out of things they had not yet learned how to change. Kareem had tried to protect Layla from a future he feared would hurt her; Layla had tried to make him understand that she was willing to choose it with him. His fear was real. So was the choice he had taken away from her. They had both loved each other, and neither interpretation made the other disappear.

Each could describe the same decision as an act of love or an act of abandonment; neither could make the other description untrue.

Kareem looked at her across the table. “We did not stop loving each other. We stopped asking love to excuse the things we kept failing to change.”

Layla wiped her cheek with her thumb. “I know.”

For a while, neither moved. Then Layla reached into her bag and took out the book he had given her for her birthday. She set it on the table between them. A single flower, now dull and pressed flat, rested between its pages. Beside the book, she placed a small folded pouch. She opened it and lifted the silver butterfly bracelet from her wrist.

Kareem stared at it. He had seen the bracelet on her every day since he gave it to her. It had become so much a part of her that he had stopped noticing it consciously, though its silver flicker had often caught his eye when she spoke with her hands or turned a page. Now her wrist was bare.

“I can't keep these with me,” she said.

“You don't have to give them back.”

“I know. But I can't keep carrying them, either.” She touched the cover of the book. “I kept the flower between the pages after it faded. I told myself I was keeping a memory, and I was. But I think I was also keeping a small place I could return to when I missed us. The bracelet, the book, the flower—they remind me of the days when being with you felt simple and happy. I don't want to lose those memories. I just can't keep looking at them as if they mean I can go back.”

She looked at the bracelet in her palm before setting it beside the book.

“I wore this every day,” she said. “I never took it off. I think some part of me believed that if I kept it close, I would never have to accept that we might really be over.”

Kareem's throat tightened. “I didn't know.”

“You couldn't have. I didn't know how to tell you.” She breathed in carefully. “I'm not giving these back because they meant too little. I'm giving them back because they meant too much to carry any farther.”

He placed his hand beside the book without touching it. “I'm sorry.”

“I know you are.” Her voice was tender, but it did not soften the boundary. “I don't want to be angry with you for the rest of my life. But I need to stop arranging my life around the possibility that you'll come back and ask me to try again.”

He nodded. “You shouldn't have to.”

“No. I shouldn't.”

The coffee had gone cold. Outside, a bus stopped, let out a handful of passengers, then pulled away again. The city continued, indifferent to the fact that two people were returning the small things that had once made a shared future feel imaginable.

They agreed not to contact each other again. They would delete the message history separately, after they left, because neither wanted the last thing between them to be another test of who could press the button first. They would not ask friends to carry messages, and they would not use birthdays or good news as reasons to reopen the door.

Kareem wanted to ask whether she would remember him kindly. He wanted to ask whether she would ever think that he had been trying to protect her. He wanted to ask for forgiveness, although he knew that forgiveness was not something he could request as the price of saying goodbye.

Instead, he said, “I hope life is gentle with you.”

Layla smiled through her tears. “I hope you find somewhere you can breathe.”

She stood. He stood, too, but neither reached for the other. She watched him gather the book and the bracelet, the pressed flower still tucked between the pages. Only when the gifts were safely in his hands did she turn and walk out into the afternoon. Kareem watched her through the window until she was lost among the people passing on the pavement.

He stayed at the table for several minutes after she had gone. Then he paid for the coffees and carried the book carefully home, as though the flower inside it were still alive.

In his apartment, he placed the book on his desk. He opened it slowly, expecting to see the pressed flower where it had been. It slipped against the page, its edges pale and brittle. Beneath it lay a folded note he had not noticed at the coffee shop.

He opened it.

Kareem,

I kept these things because they held the days when loving you felt as easy as breathing. I thought keeping them might keep those days close enough to return to. But a memory is not a door, and I cannot keep standing in front of one that no longer opens.

You were loved here, fully and without reservation. I will not call that love a mistake simply because it ended.

I am giving back the things I can hold, because the things I cannot hold will take longer to let go of.

Please remember me kindly. And please, let this be goodbye.

Layla

He read the note once, then again, and then a third time, as if there might be another sentence hidden beneath the first. There wasn't. The simplicity of the goodbye hurt more than any accusation could have. She had not tried to punish him. She had simply told him how much she had loved him, and that she could not keep living inside the memory of it.

He sat down on the edge of the bed, the note trembling in his hand, and began to cry. He cried for the gifts she had returned, for the girl who had worn the bracelet every day, for the woman who had finally understood that she needed to stop waiting, and for the future he had been too afraid to let her choose.

That evening, Kareem opened their message history one last time. He scrolled to the beginning, to Layla's first joke about the manuscript, the photographs of books and meals, the small exchanges that had made up the days of their relationship. He read the first message again.

This is Layla. In case you need to ask the manuscript any further questions.

He smiled through his tears, then deleted the conversation. The list of messages returned to an ordinary screen, and the blank space where her name had been looked almost unbearable.

In Alexandria, Layla sat at her kitchen table with the phone in her hands. She had been the one to ask for the end, and still she could barely bear the act of making it final. She opened their conversation, paused at old photographs and voice notes, then deleted them one by one until there was nothing left to reopen.

She looked down at her bare wrist. Her fingers moved to the place where the silver butterfly had rested for so long. For a moment she felt the strange lightness of its absence, then the full weight of what that absence meant. She cried, not because she had changed her mind, but because choosing to let go did not make love disappear.

She had wanted to be loved without having to be indispensable. She had wanted to build a life that was hers, and to share it with someone who could walk beside her without making her responsible for every uncertain step. She still believed those things were possible. She just no longer believed she and Kareem

could reach them together while he still believed that loving her meant deciding, before she could answer, which difficulties she should be spared.

The following months were not easy. There were mornings when Kareem woke with the impulse to tell Layla something and had to remember that the conversation no longer existed. There were evenings when Layla found a sentence in a book and reached for her phone before remembering that she had promised not to write. Sometimes they heard the same song in different places. Sometimes they passed a shop that reminded them of the first months in Cairo. Sometimes they dreamed of one another and woke with the old ache still present.

A year after their final meeting, Layla was asked to mentor a new editor who had joined the publishing house with too much energy and not enough confidence in her own judgment. The young woman apologized before every suggestion, as though she expected the room to punish her for noticing something other people had missed.

During their first review meeting, Layla listened to the editor explain a proposed change to a story. The idea was good, but the young woman kept weakening her argument with phrases like *perhaps I'm wrong* and *it's probably nothing*.

“Tell me what you think is wrong with the passage,” Layla said.

The editor hesitated, then explained her reasoning. Layla asked two questions and suggested one adjustment. The young woman returned to her notes, revising the argument until it became clearer.

“You don't have to apologize for having a thought,” Layla said. “You do have to be willing to examine it. Those are different things.”

The young woman smiled, relieved. “Thank you. I always worry that being direct makes me difficult.”

Layla thought about the years she had spent turning her own needs into careful questions, then apologizing when the answers did not arrive. She thought about Kareem, about the conversations that had come too late, and the ways both of them had learned to soften the truth until it became difficult to recognize.

“Being direct can be uncomfortable,” she said. “That doesn't mean it's unkind.”

After the meeting, she returned to her apartment. The lamp beside her bed still worked, though the shade had grown more yellow with time. She turned it on, placed her notebook on the desk, and prepared the list of manuscripts she would review the following morning.

She did not think about Kareem every day anymore. Some weeks passed without a memory strong enough to interrupt her work. Other days, a line in a book or a smell on the street brought him back so vividly that she could almost hear his voice. When that happened, she allowed herself to remember. She did not open a message thread that no longer existed. She did not mistake the ache for an instruction.

In Cairo, Kareem had begun supervising a younger copy editor who reminded him of himself at twenty-seven: careful, intelligent, and convinced that the safest answer was usually the one that revealed the least. When the young man hesitated to challenge an author, Kareem asked him to explain the problem aloud.

“I don't want to sound as though I'm telling him he's wrong,” the editor said.

Kareem looked at the marked page. “Then tell him what isn't working. Be specific. You don't have to make the person feel small in order to say that the sentence needs to change.”

He heard his own words and remembered the first week he had known Layla. He remembered the paper she had left on his desk, the note about a character admitting her fear, and the way that small act had made him feel seen. He had spent years learning to describe the difference between criticizing a sentence and condemning the person who wrote it. He was still learning the difference between disappointing someone and failing to love them.

That evening, he visited his brother. His niece was older now, old enough to argue about the rules of a game and to demand explanations when someone changed them. Kareem listened to her story about school, helped her with a puzzle, and stayed until his brother began clearing the table.

On the way home, he passed a secondhand bookshop and stopped to look at the display in the window. A novel lay open beneath the glass, its page marked with a line he knew he would once have sent to Layla. He read it, smiled faintly, and continued walking.

He did not feel that he had betrayed the memory by not sharing it. It belonged to a part of his life that had changed. He could remember her without reopening the conversation, and he could be grateful for what they had shared without asking it to become something else.

Neither had forgotten.

They had simply stopped using memory as a reason to return to the door they had agreed to close.

For the first few months after their final meeting, the absence was practical as well as emotional. Kareem had to teach himself not to open their conversation when he found a sentence he wanted to share. Layla had to learn not to look for his name when a difficult day ended. Both had to discover that habits could survive the relationship that had given them meaning.

Kareem continued visiting his brother. His niece grew taller and more talkative, and she began asking him questions that were difficult to answer without laughing. He told her stories, read the same book repeatedly, and learned the names of the children she played with at nursery. The visits did not replace Layla. They gave him another part of his life to care for.

He also began writing in the margins of his books again, but the notes changed. Once, he had underlined sentences about people who failed to say what they meant and treated the underlining as a form of understanding. Now he began writing questions beside them: *What would he have needed to say? What would she have needed to hear? Why does he believe intention should excuse the result?*

He did not always have answers.

Layla's life continued in Alexandria. She accepted the permanent role and began working with younger editors. She grew confident in meetings, learned to negotiate deadlines, and became less afraid of disagreement. She called her mother because she wanted to, not always because something needed doing. She visited Cairo often, but she stopped treating every visit as an opportunity to prove she had not abandoned the family.

Sometimes she missed Kareem sharply. She missed the way he could make her laugh with one sentence, the way he remembered small details, and the way their conversations could move from an argument about a novel to a question about what it meant to be loved. She allowed herself to miss him without interpreting the feeling as a sign that she had made the wrong decision.

They both lived. They did not become completely free of the past, and they did not need to. They learned that memory could remain without becoming an invitation. They learned, slowly, that it was possible to honor a relationship without keeping it open forever.

The work was not dramatic. There were no final speeches, no sudden revelations, and no moment when the pain disappeared. There were only ordinary days in which they did not reach for each other, and gradually those days became a life.

They did not contact each other.

Not because they had stopped caring, but because they had finally accepted that caring could not be their only reason for continuing.

Layla's birthday arrived several months later, on a bright morning when the city was already warm before she left for work. Dalia had left a small cake on her desk with a note that read, *Twenty-eight is a perfectly respectable age to stop pretending you enjoy networking events.* Layla laughed when she saw it, then glanced instinctively at her wrist. The silver butterfly was no longer there. She had returned it to Kareem at their last meeting, yet her fingers still moved toward the place where it had rested, as if the habit had not been told that the bracelet was gone. She felt the small ache of knowing there was one person who would have understood the joke in a slightly different way.

Kareem had always remembered her birthday. On her twenty-seventh, he had surprised her at a coffee shop with a book she had mentioned only once, a single flower, and a silver bracelet shaped like a butterfly. He had remembered a passing comment, chosen the gifts with nervous care, and watched her happiness as though he had not expected something so small to matter so much. She had worn the bracelet every day afterward. When the flower began to fade, she pressed it between the pages of the book and kept it there. Now the book, the dull flower, and the bracelet were with Kareem again, and Layla was left with the memory of how completely happy she had been when he placed them in front of her.

This morning, she looked at her phone and found messages from her mother, Mariam, Youssef, and colleagues. She read each one and replied. She called Nadia during her lunch break, listened to her mother's insistence that Layla should visit Cairo soon, and promised to come when her schedule allowed. She did not feel the familiar guilt at the thought of delaying the visit. She could miss her family and still have a day of her own.

That evening, Dalia took her to a restaurant near the water. Two other colleagues joined them, and someone ordered a dessert with so many candles that the waiter appeared worried about the tablecloth. Layla laughed, blew them out, and listened as her friends argued about whether birthday wishes counted if they were made while laughing.

She was happy. Not in a way that erased the past, and not in a way that required her to prove she had moved on. She was simply having a good evening with people who knew her as she was now. She had work she cared about, a home that felt like hers, and friends whose presence did not depend on her being useful to them.

On the walk home, she took out her phone and opened a new message. She knew Kareem would remember the date. The old habit was so strong that she could almost hear his voice, offering a joke about the number of candles or asking whether she had eaten a proper dinner. She wanted to tell him that she had had a good day. She wanted him to know she was happy.

For a moment, she typed his name.

Then she stopped.

The wish to share the day did not make the boundary less real. She could be grateful that he had once celebrated her without asking him to return to the role he no longer occupied. She could remember the birthday he had made special without making the memory into a message.

She deleted the unfinished text and put the phone in her bag.

When she reached the apartment, she switched on the lamp and set the small box of leftover cake on the table. She sat beside the window and let herself feel both things: the happiness of the day she had lived and the sadness of the person she had not told about it. Neither feeling cancelled the other. She did not have to decide which one was the truest.

In Cairo, Kareem remembered her birthday, too. He saw the date on the calendar he had not updated since they were together. For several minutes, he considered sending a simple message. It would be polite, he told himself. It would not ask for a conversation. He could say happy birthday and leave it there.

But he remembered their last meeting. He remembered how they had agreed that any small message could become another opening, another night of speaking as though they were still part of each other's ordinary days. He could not know what a birthday message would mean to Layla, and he had no right to decide that it would be harmless because he wanted to send it.

He put his phone down and called his brother instead. They talked about the weekend and his niece's new school project. It was not the conversation Kareem had wanted, but it was a real one with someone who was there. When he hung up, he still missed Layla. He also knew that he had kept the agreement they had made.

Neither knew what the other had nearly done. Neither was comforted by the possibility. They were learning to carry the small, private disappointments of no contact without turning them into reasons to break it.

Layla stayed in Alexandria. The permanent role was confirmed, and she accepted it. Her work grew more demanding. She became a better editor, learned

to defend her decisions without apologizing for taking up space, and began mentoring a younger colleague who reminded her of the person she had been when she first arrived.

She visited her family regularly. She learned to say no without always explaining herself. Her mother learned to call before assuming Layla would be available, and Youssef gradually became less dependent on his sister's help. The family did not change all at once, and Layla did not become free of guilt. But she learned that she could love them without making herself responsible for every part of their lives.

The months after the final conversation did not become simple. They became quieter, which was not the same thing. Layla accepted the permanent position in Alexandria when the funding was confirmed. She signed a new contract, negotiated her responsibilities, and began working on a collection she had once only been allowed to observe from the edge of the office. The job demanded more of her than the fellowship had, but it also gave her a sense of direction that did not depend on the people she loved being proud of her.

She continued to miss Kareem. Sometimes she saw a book in a shop and reached for her phone before remembering that she could no longer send him a photograph and expect a reply.

In the spring, the collection she had edited was published. The launch took place in a small room at the publishing house, with rows of chairs, a table of books, and a bowl of sweets that someone kept moving to make room for another stack of copies. Layla stood near the front while Salwa introduced the project and thanked the editorial team. When Salwa mentioned Layla's work, the room applauded, and Layla felt a rush of pride so sudden that she had to lower her eyes for a moment.

Afterward, colleagues came to congratulate her. Dalia hugged her and said the collection was the best thing the office had produced that year. One of the authors thanked Layla for insisting on a revision he had initially resisted. He admitted that the story was stronger now, and that he had been wrong to think the edit would take something away from it.

Layla laughed, thanked him, and tried to hold the moment without immediately asking what she could have done better.

For years, she had wanted her father to be there when something went well. After his death, she had learned to share good news with her mother and siblings, but the announcement had often turned quickly toward the next thing that needed doing. Now she stood among people who were celebrating something

she had helped make, and she allowed herself to feel the happiness without converting it into a task.

When she got home, she put a copy of the book on the table beside the lamp. She opened her phone and looked at Kareem's name. She wanted him to know that the collection had been published, that the authors had praised her work, that Salwa had told her she was ready to lead a larger project. He would understand how much the day mattered. He would probably make a joke about the title, then ask her what she thought of the cover.

She began typing.

It's out. The collection is finally published.

She read the sentence and felt the familiar pull toward the person who had once been her first call. She could send it. He might reply with congratulations. They might talk about the book and the day, and the conversation would feel like a small, harmless return to the life they had shared.

But she knew what the message would ask of them, even if neither said it aloud. It would ask them to continue being the people who shared everything while refusing to decide whether they were willing to share a future.

She deleted it.

For a moment, the loss felt fresh. Then Dalia sent a message asking whether Layla wanted to celebrate over dinner. Layla answered yes and put the phone away.

She did not stop missing Kareem. She simply let someone else stand beside her in the moment she had wanted to share with him. It did not make the achievement less meaningful, and it did not erase what he had been to her. It gave the achievement a place in the life she was living now.

That evening, they went to a restaurant near the waterfront. Dalia ordered too much food, argued with the waiter about the menu, and made Layla laugh until she forgot to check her phone. When she returned to the apartment later, she placed another copy of the collection on the shelf beside her father's notebook.

She stood there for a moment, looking at both books. One held the memory of a person whose life had ended before she could finish asking him everything she wanted to know. The other held the work she had completed by continuing to live her own life. Neither cancelled the other. Both belonged on the shelf. Sometimes she heard a joke at work and imagined the way he would have responded. The impulses did not disappear because she had chosen not to act on them.

At first, she treated each impulse as a test of whether she had truly moved on. If she missed him, perhaps she had made the wrong decision. If she thought about him during a happy moment, perhaps she was still waiting for him to return. Gradually, she learned to let the thoughts arrive without turning them into instructions. Missing him was part of her history. It did not require her to reopen the door.

On the anniversary of her father's death, she took the notebook from the bedside table and read the two reminders again. She did not cry immediately. She read the entries, closed the notebook, and went for a walk beside the sea. She thought about how much she had changed since leaving Cairo, how much she had learned about work, friendship, and the limits of her own responsibility. She also thought about the things she still did not know: how to ask for help without feeling guilty, how to rest without deciding she should be doing something else, how to love someone without trying to carry both sides of the relationship.

She did not make a list of lessons. She let the day belong to grief and memory, and she let herself return home without needing to have become wiser by evening.

In Cairo, Kareem became a senior editor after several months of difficult work. The promotion was announced at a short meeting on a Wednesday morning. His supervisor spoke about his judgment, the care he brought to difficult manuscripts, and the way younger editors had begun turning to him when a book seemed impossible to save. The role meant more responsibility, a modest increase in pay, and a chance to shape the publishing house's list rather than work only on the sentences other people had written. Kareem thanked his supervisor and answered the questions put to him. By the time he returned to his desk, the news felt both wonderful and strangely incomplete.

His first thought was to tell Layla. It arrived so quickly that he reached for his phone before remembering that there was no longer a life in which he could simply call her with good news.

He could imagine her reaction clearly. She would congratulate him without qualification, ask what the new role involved, and demand to know whether the salary increase was any good. When he tried to make the achievement sound smaller than it was, she would tell him not to edit the best part out of his own life. She would remind him how long he had worked toward this, how many difficult manuscripts he had rescued, how much of his judgment he had learned to trust. She would be proud of him, and her pride would make it easier for him to be proud of himself.

He opened their conversation. The last message remained months old, preserved at the top of the screen by the app's quiet insistence that old things could still be reached with a tap. He typed, *I got the promotion today.* He looked at the words and imagined the reply, the questions, the joke she would make about him becoming a man with meetings. For a few seconds, the joy felt almost shared.

Then he remembered their final agreement. The boundary was not a rule that applied only when he was sad or lonely. If he broke it whenever he had something important to say, he would be asking Layla to keep carrying the relationship after they had both agreed to put it down. He deleted the message. The news was still good; it simply had nowhere to go that he wanted it to go.

At work, his colleagues congratulated him, and he thanked them. Hany clapped him on the shoulder and said the publishing house had finally realized what everyone else knew. Kareem smiled and tried to let the moment settle. People were pleased for him, and he was grateful. Still, he found himself waiting for the particular delight that he knew would have come from Layla—not because the others cared less, exactly, but because she understood what the promotion meant to the person he had been before the title existed.

His brother called that evening. Kareem had not told him. A friend of his brother's worked in the production department at Dar al-Masafa and had heard the news during the ordinary circulation of office gossip. He had mentioned it over lunch, and Kareem's brother had phoned as soon as he could.

“So,” his brother said, “I hear we have a senior editor in the family.”

Kareem sat down. “Who told you?”

“My friend at your publishing house. Apparently, everyone there knew before I did.” His brother laughed, then added, “Congratulations, Kareem. You've worked for this. I'm happy for you.”

The words were sincere. Kareem knew that. Yet the congratulations came between a complaint about traffic and a question about whether he could visit on Friday. His brother did not ask what the moment had felt like, what Kareem hoped to do with the new responsibility, or whether he had been proud when his supervisor told him. The call moved on, as family calls often did, to the next practical thing. Kareem was left feeling ungrateful for wanting more from it, and disappointed that the news he had imagined sharing with a roomful of people had landed in the space between errands.

The following day, his brother mentioned the promotion to Hala. He assumed Kareem had already told her; he had not imagined that his younger brother

might keep the news to himself. Hala was surprised enough to ask when it had happened, then hurt enough to ask why she was hearing it from someone else.

She called Kareem that evening. “You were promoted, and you didn't tell me?”

“It was announced this week,” he said. He could hear the disappointment in her voice and felt the old reflex to defend himself before she had finished speaking. “I've been busy. I was going to tell you when things had settled.” It was an excuse, though not an entirely false one. He had been busy. He had also wanted, for once, to keep a piece of good news to himself until he understood what it meant.

“Your brother had to tell me?” Hala asked. “I'm your mother, Kareem. I shouldn't have to hear about important things in your life from other people.”

He waited for her to say she was proud of him. She did congratulate him eventually, but the congratulations came after several more questions about why he had not called, whether the salary increase was significant, and whether the new duties would keep him at work later. Her concern was real, but it gathered around the fact that she had not been told. By the end of the conversation, Kareem felt as though the promotion had become another thing he had done incorrectly.

He did not tell his father. A few evenings later, he sat at his parents' table while Mahmoud watched the television with the volume turned up. His father asked whether Kareem had found the mechanic's number and reminded him that the car needed checking before the next family visit. He did not ask about work. Kareem could have offered the news without being asked, could have said that he had been promoted, that his responsibilities had changed, that something he had worked toward for years had finally happened. He felt the words rise to his throat, then let them pass. He did not want to offer the most important thing that had happened to him to someone who might acknowledge it with a nod and return to the television. His father never learned about the promotion from him.

It was not that Kareem expected his family to celebrate him as though they had never disappointed him before. He had learned to lower his expectations long ago. But some quiet part of him had still imagined that good news might draw them together, that the announcement would give them a reason to pause and look at him, not as the youngest son who could run an errand or arrange a phone number, but as a person who had achieved something he once doubted he could. Instead, his brother had offered a brief congratulations, and his mother had been more wounded by his silence than delighted by the news. His father did not know.

No one, he thought, would have been happier than Layla. She would have celebrated the title, certainly, but she would have cared even more about what it meant to him. She would have asked whether he felt proud. If he shrugged or tried to make the promotion sound inevitable, she would have told him that he had a habit of making his own achievements seem smaller so no one could accuse him of wanting too much. She would have made him talk about the years of work behind it, the mistakes he had learned from, the younger editors who now trusted him. She would have looked at him as though the news were not merely good fortune but proof of something she had seen in him all along. With her, he would have felt proud not only of the position, but of himself.

He did not contact her. The wish to tell her remained, vivid and immediate, but it was not permission. The promotion could not make their final decision less real, and good news could not become a loophole through which they returned to the life they had agreed to leave behind. He let himself imagine her happiness without pretending it belonged to him now. It was a comfort, and a fresh grief: he knew the person who would have been most delighted for him, and he could not tell her.

The promotion was not the last change in Kareem's life. A few months later, a former colleague forwarded him an opening at a small independent publishing house abroad. The role would ask him to start again in a city where no one knew his family, his silences, or the places in Cairo that still carried the shape of his old life. He read the offer more than once. His first instinct was to refuse; Mahmoud was still recovering, Hala still called when she was frightened, and Kareem had spent years believing that being a good son meant remaining close enough to be needed.

But he had begun to feel like a visitor in his own life. In Egypt, every street seemed to return him to a version of himself he no longer knew how to inhabit. Even at the family table, he understood how to be useful more easily than he understood how to feel that he belonged. He loved his family. He also felt unseen by them, and the difference had become harder to ignore. He could not tell whether he was leaving because he needed distance or because he no longer knew how to stay without disappearing inside the things everyone expected of him.

He accepted the position.

Telling his family was harder than signing the contract. Hala asked who would take Mahmoud to appointments, who would help with the bills, and what would happen if something went wrong while Kareem was too far away to come. He answered as carefully as he could: his brother and sister would share the

appointments, he would keep sending money each month, and he would pay his share of the household expenses and medicine. He would call. He would visit when he could. He would not abandon them.

Hala heard the distance more clearly than the promises. Mahmoud asked about the job title, the salary, and whether Kareem would have to sell his car. The practical questions filled the room. Kareem waited for someone to ask whether he was frightened, whether he was sad to leave, whether he felt as though he had reached the edge of the life he knew. No one asked. He did not explain it himself.

A few days before Kareem's departure, Nader came over to help him pack. They had been friends long enough that Nader no longer needed to ask permission before moving a stack of books or opening a cupboard in search of tape. He worked steadily, folding shirts and arguing that Kareem was taking too many books for someone who had to fit his life into a few suitcases.

Near the back of the wardrobe, Nader found a plain cardboard box. It looked like the sort of thing that would contain cables, old chargers, or receipts Kareem had forgotten to throw away. He opened it and found that it did contain receipts—dozens of them, folded and faded, from restaurants, coffee shops, bookshops, and little places that seemed to have mattered only to the people who had been there. There were paper sleeves from takeaway cups, a ticket from a film, and several flattened snack wrappers. On one empty packet of chips, Kareem had written a date in blue ink.

Nader picked it up and frowned. “You've kept all this?”

Kareem turned from the open suitcase. “Apparently.”

“Receipts I can understand, if you're the sort of person who thinks he might need to return a sandwich. But an empty packet of chips?” He held it up. “And you've written a date on it. What does that mean?”

Kareem looked at the box. For a moment, he considered telling Nader to put everything back and leave it alone. Instead, he sat on the edge of the bed.

“They're from days I don't want to forget.”

Nader's expression softened, though his hand remained over the open box. “You think you might forget?”

“No. Not exactly.” Kareem searched for the right words. “I think I kept them because there were days when I was happier than I've ever been. Not the big days. Not birthdays or celebrations. Just coffee after work, dinner that lasted longer than we'd planned, walking somewhere with a packet of chips between us, sitting in a place neither of us had tried before. I didn't know those were the days

I'd spend remembering. At the time, they were just days. I was happy, and I didn't know I should be paying attention."

He picked up the wrapper from Nader's hand and smoothed its fold with his thumb.

"These scraps are proof that it happened," he said. "That I didn't invent the happiness because I miss her. There was a time when I was happy without having to persuade myself that I was."

Nader sat beside him. "You know you don't need a receipt to prove you loved someone."

"I know." Kareem gave a small, tired smile. "I think I need them to remind me that I was there while it was happening. That I didn't only become grateful for it afterward."

For a while, neither spoke. Nader looked through the box again, more carefully now, as though the things inside had become something other than rubbish.

"Are you taking it with you?" he asked.

Kareem looked at the open suitcase, then at the box. "I don't know which things I can throw away."

"Then don't decide today." Nader folded the top flaps gently. "You can take the box. You don't have to carry every memory in your hands just because you're afraid you'll lose it."

Kareem nodded. They packed the box between two sweaters so it would not be crushed. Nader returned to the shirts, and Kareem went back to folding them. Neither pretended the conversation had made the leaving easier. But Kareem felt, for once, that someone had seen the thing he was trying to keep without telling him he should be over it.

Leaving was bittersweet in a way he could not make neat. He was leaving friends, familiar streets, old cafés, and the memories of a life that had once seemed certain. He was leaving a family that might need him at the very moment he was finally admitting that he could not always be the person who arrived first. He carried guilt in one suitcase and relief in the other. From abroad, he continued to support his parents financially, sent money for prescriptions and household costs, and called often enough to remain part of their lives. But he could no longer drive his father to the clinic or appear at his mother's door whenever fear found her. The distance forced the family to share responsibilities

more evenly, though no one said aloud that this was part of what the move had made possible.

In his new city, Kareem built a small, careful life around work, groceries, long walks, and calls home. He felt grateful for the quiet and ashamed of how grateful he was. He could miss the country he had left and still know that he could not have remained in it as the person he had become. He had not found a place where he belonged overnight. He had only found enough space to begin asking what belonging might mean.

On one of his visits back to Cairo, his niece asked about Layla again. They were sitting at the kitchen table while his sister-in-law cut fruit into small pieces and his brother tried to persuade the child to finish her lunch before asking for dessert. The girl had found an old drawing in a folder, a lopsided house with a giraffe at the door, and wanted to know whether Layla still remembered it.

"I think she would remember," Kareem said.

"Can we send it to her?"

The question was innocent. It did not know about boundaries, about the six months of messages, or the final conversation in which two adults had agreed not to keep reaching for each other. It knew only that someone it liked was absent and that drawings were meant to be shown to people.

Kareem looked at the picture.

He could have sent it. It would have been easy to explain the message as something for his niece, not for him. He could have told himself that a child had asked and that refusing would be needlessly severe. He could have turned the drawing into another harmless reason to reopen a conversation neither he nor Layla had been able to leave alone.

Instead, he took a breath.

"I don't think we should send it," he said gently. "Layla and I aren't speaking anymore. Sometimes people need that so they can get on with their lives."

His niece frowned. "But I like her."

"I know. I like her, too."

"Then why can't she come?"

Kareem searched for an answer a child could understand. "Because liking someone doesn't always mean they can be part of everything. And sometimes the kindest thing is to let someone have the space they asked for, even when you miss them."

She considered this, unconvinced. Then she slid the drawing toward him.

"Can you keep it?"

He nodded. "Yes. I'll keep it."

He put the drawing in a drawer at home. Later, when he was alone, he took it out and looked at it again. The house was crooked. The giraffe's neck was almost as tall as the roof. A small figure stood in the doorway, holding what might have been a flower or a lollipop. He did not know whether his niece had drawn Layla or simply a person she wanted to invite inside.

The drawing hurt him. It also reminded him that the boundary was not a denial of the love that had existed. It was a decision about what they could continue to do with it. He could miss Layla, and he could let the drawing remain in the drawer. He could remember the afternoon they had built the giraffe's house without asking her to return to it.

The next weekend, he helped his niece make another drawing. This time she drew a cat on a roof. He hung it on the refrigerator, where she could see it when she came to visit, and did not tell her that he had kept the first one.

He was learning that moving forward did not require erasing what had mattered. It required discovering where to place it.

A year after the breakup, he found the note he had written before their final conversation. It was folded inside a book on his desk. The paper had softened at the creases, and the sentence was still there: *I want a life with you. I want to work out how to make it possible.*

He sat with it for a while, then placed it inside the book and returned the book to the shelf. He no longer read the sentence as proof that he had been too late to become a better man. He read it as evidence that he had known what he wanted and had been afraid to act while the choice was still open. That truth hurt, but it did not require him to punish himself forever. He could learn from it without pretending he could change what had happened.

Layla's life in Alexandria continued. She developed her own routines, made friends, and led projects she was proud of. Sometimes, when she walked along the sea at dusk, she remembered Kareem beside her and felt the familiar ache. She no longer tried to turn the ache into a question about whether they might have had a different ending. The question could never be answered in a way that changed the present.

They would occasionally hear about each other through the publishing world. Someone mentioned a book Kareem had edited; someone told him that Layla's

collection had received a favorable review. They did not ask for further details. They did not send messages through mutual acquaintances. The lives they had once shared remained connected by memory, but not by a line either of them was willing to pull.

Almost is a cruel place to live. It looks so much like the beginning that you can spend years there without realizing you've never arrived.

Neither stopped loving the other in the clean, decisive way they had once imagined people stopped loving. The love changed. It became less urgent, less involved in the daily decisions, less likely to disrupt an ordinary afternoon. It remained as a part of the story each told about the person they had been and the life they had almost built.

Years later, when Layla came across the old lamp while rearranging her apartment, she considered replacing it with something smaller. The shade was still stained. The wooden base had acquired another scratch. She turned it on and watched the familiar light fall across the wall.

She smiled, then left it where it was.

When Kareem returned to Cairo to visit his family, he sometimes passed the café where he and Layla had first argued about the meaning of a sentence. He no longer stopped outside. He walked past, remembering how she had insisted that the final clause was where the character admitted what she feared. He understood the edit now, though the memory remained more complicated than the sentence itself.

They had almost learned how to stay. Almost learned how to ask without fear, answer without retreating, and allow love to be a place where two people could be known without being required to become simpler versions of themselves.

Almost.

Some love stories end. Others remain almost.

And for Kareem Nassar and Layla Fares, that was not the same as saying their love had never been real. It had been one of the truest things either had known. It had simply not been enough to make a life.

Perhaps, in another life, love would be enough to make two people stay. In this one, it was not.